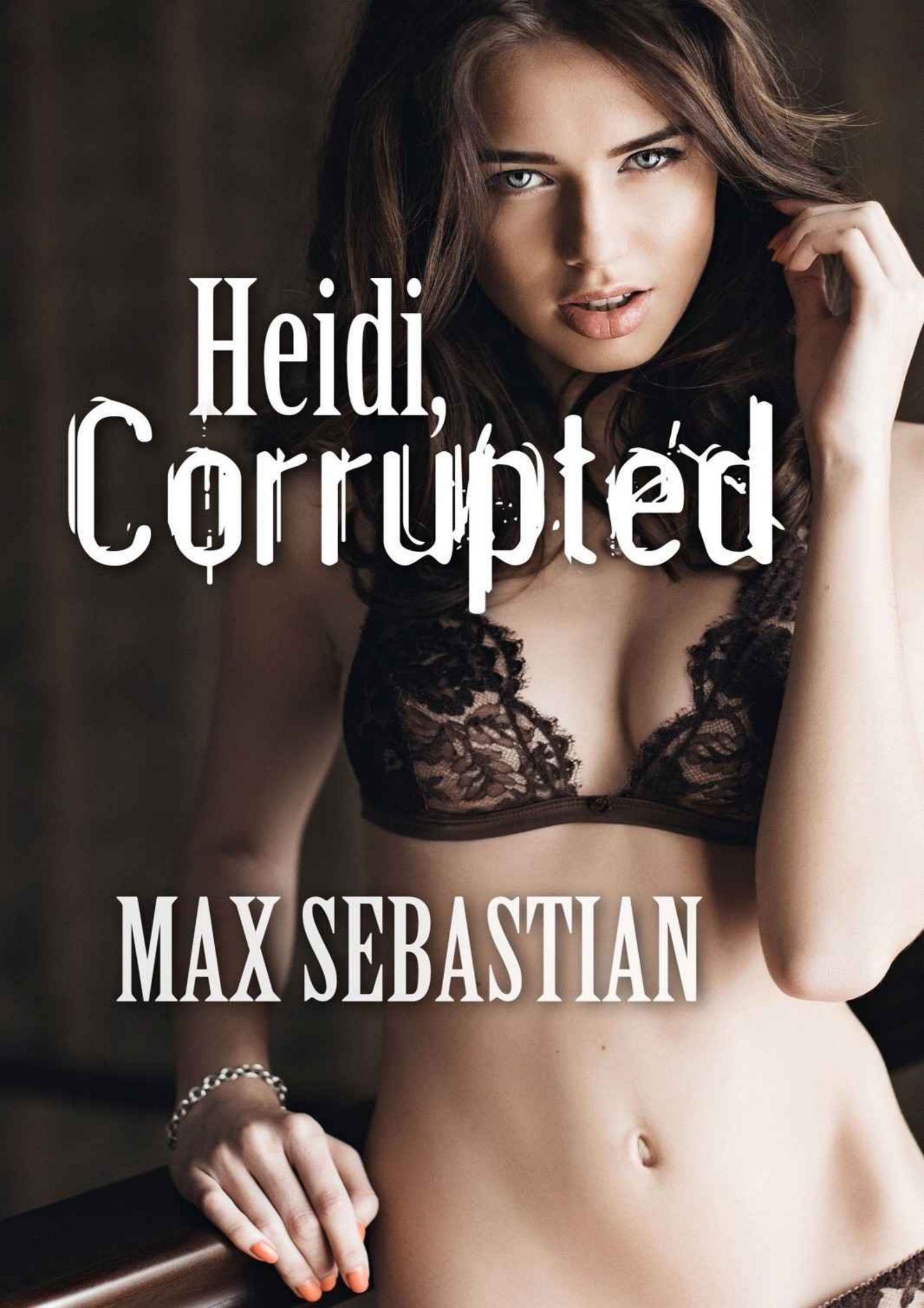




Heidi, Corrupted

MAX SEBASTIAN

About the Author

Max Sebastian is a thirty-something writer, author and occasional journalist who lives in London with his wife and two children. He has been writing erotica for more than 15 years, starting out at the website Literotica.com before joining the indie publishing revolution in late 2011.

You can find Max online at **MaxSebastian.net**, on Twitter **@MaxSebastian**, on Facebook at **facebook.com/writermax**, and on GoodReads at **goodreads.com/maxsebastian**.

And, you're always very welcome to contact Max by emailing **Max@MaxSebastian.net**.

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Heidi, Corrupted

MAX SEBASTIAN

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Contents

[Chapter One](#)

[Chapter Two](#)

[Chapter Three](#)

[Chapter Four](#)

[Chapter Five](#)

[Chapter Six](#)

[Chapter Seven](#)

[Chapter Eight](#)

[Chapter Nine](#)

[Chapter Ten](#)

[Chapter Eleven](#)

[Chapter Twelve](#)

[Chapter Thirteen](#)

[Chapter Fourteen](#)

[Chapter Fifteen](#)

[Chapter Sixteen](#)

[Chapter Seventeen](#)

[Chapter Eighteen](#)

[Chapter Nineteen](#)

Chapter One

Heidi, Heidi. I wasn't really fair to Heidi — I can see that now. I should have never asked her out in the first place. I should never have stuck with the relationship. Should certainly never have married her. I should have walked away the moment I lost interest.

Only, what happened after the relationship crumbled... I wouldn't change that for the world. So, while I could have been more fair and should have pulled the plug on things earlier, I'm glad I didn't.

To begin at the beginning: we were graduating college. I was just getting over the break-up of my second-ever long-term girlfriend — and in my case, 'long-term' meant a relationship of nine months, which was forever for a college kid like me. The previous had been blonde, pretty, bright and athletic — with large breasts and a phenomenal sex drive. Your basic wet dream growing up. I think I spent most of those nine months in bed, or at least the equivalent of a bed, because Suzi liked to fuck in all manner of places.

The break-up was brutal and sudden; even after just nine months we had foreseen a life together, possibly even marriage, kids.

Heidi was a friend of a friend's friend. I don't precisely know the origins of how she came into my sphere. She hung out on the fringes of the same group whose fringes I orbited myself, and eventually my orbit passed near hers. She was the antithesis of Suzi — petite, dark-haired, flat-chested, pale. Musical rather than athletic. She played the cello in the college orchestra.

I developed a little crush on her — I thought she was pretty, in her own way, though she was hardly the magazine cover girl Suzi might have been. She was quirky, she was interesting, she was cheerful — at least in the early days — and so I guess that drew my attention during the dark times in the wake of Suzi. But she was taken, and not really my type, so that made her less intimidating to talk to, even if I did have a little thing for her.

Then she broke up with the guy she'd been seeing, and it seemed to devastate her to the same degree as my break-up with Suzi had me. The misery pushed my orbit into hers, and we crashed together with a certain degree of inevitability.

And it was a crash, in every sense of the word.

I don't even remember how I came to be alone with her in a bar a couple months before graduation. Yet there we were, bitching about those who dump people without mercy, talking as though we might even come up with a plan to change the entire rules of dating in the modern world.

"I mean, he never even looks at me when I pass him now, it really hurts inside," she said.

"You'd have to outlaw that."

"Exactly. There should be a clear agreement that if things go wrong, for whatever reason, you should still be friends after you stop dating."

"Definitely. You liked each other enough to start dating, right? So why can't you be friends after you finish?"

"At least be on polite terms."

Over many drinks that night, it slowly dawned on me that Heidi might be available for the taking. I didn't actively consider that I might be a strong candidate for a rebound for her — and a few months after I'd broken up with Suzi, I didn't even think that she would turn out to be a rebound for me. We were increasingly inebriated, and talking about how our next lovers would have to pledge to let us down gently if ever the time came to end a relationship — or we'd never go out with anyone again.

I guess it evolved to me persuading her that such an approach would work, that if I were to ask her out, I wouldn't have a problem pledging to let her down lightly when it came time to move on.

And then we seemed to cross over from the hypothetical, and I really was telling Heidi how much better we'd be together, even when it came time to split up, and she was sitting there actually considering taking our strange friendship out of the realms of the platonic.

So along came the end of the night and she invited me back to her room to listen to classical music, sip a glass or two of red wine, and make out for what seemed like hours and hours.

It was a rebound relationship in every sense of the word, for both of us. Only, then it kind of continued, on and on. Neither of us were brave enough to call it off — because both of us had been hurt so badly before. And, I suppose, because in the middle of our relationship we left college and went out into the world to find work, and the uncertainty in our lives kept us together for mutual support.

In the beginning, there was the new relationship energy, and it was exciting. We saw each other every night, and things steadily moved from making out to random fumbblings and fondling, to naked exploration and eventually oral sex and — once contraceptives had been arranged — the full home run.

And I did still have that little crush on her, so even though she was a little awkward, it didn't matter so much. She was a touch skinny, didn't have much to hang onto, was a little gawky and didn't move with that innate feminine grace that Suzi had flaunted every moment. She wore plain clothes and plainer underwear. She rarely used make-up, her long near-black hair was usually a little unkempt.

And she wasn't a great kisser, something I'd never really happened across in a woman before.

But she was female, willing to be friends with me, willing to get naked, willing to make out. And we had plenty to talk about when we weren't making out. We were either at her place or mine every night, it was almost as though we'd moved in together. Graduation came, and we both decided to rent a place together in London, since I had a job in the City lined up, and Heidi had the offer of a place in the City Philharmonic Orchestra among others.

Leaving college and joining the rat race was a lot more of a strain than either of us could have predicted. My job was hard, fairly dull since it was so administrative, with fairly long hours, though it paid quite well. Heidi's job was fairly intense, too — and became quite a baptism of fire as the winter drew on and the orchestra was hit by the flu.

I think the stress probably helped things fizzle out between us. Heidi was miserable all the time — she moped about, she spent the whole time complaining about little tiny, trivial things in her life, and no attempts to cheer her up would pull her out of it — and when she was miserable, it really poured cold water on any kind of sexual feelings.

We were always tired when we got home. When we did have sex, it just seemed to irritate me more than stimulate me. I guess we'd never been that great together, and Heidi wasn't ever what you'd call experienced in bed — and she never progressed. Looking back, it was unfair of me to expect her to, as I had felt so awkward about it I didn't want to raise the subject. There was the way she often managed to sink her teeth into me as she went down on me, to the point where it started to feel as though I was being sucked by a meat grinder. She just got into bed and laid there on her back, letting me do what I wanted with her never mixing things up. Even the small issue of her dark pubic hair being a little too effusive, even sprouting out of her underwear.

She never initiated anything, and when I eventually stopped initiating things, she said nothing about it. Our sex life quietly died. We re-entered the friend zone — and yet we stayed together.

Things felt uncertain and difficult, with little in the way of a light at the end of the tunnel. Then Heidi had the idea of getting married, and while we didn't talk about it in a very romantic way, it did seem like a good idea to me at the time, even with our stalled sex life. Marriage offered stability, security, the sense that we could start building a life together and chart some course towards an improved situation for us both. And I think, even months after our painful break-ups, we still saw our relationship as preferable to being single, preferable to being alone. It was no doubt the wrong state of mind to be in.

Our families were happy enough for us, though perhaps they were a touch disappointed by our wish for a fairly quiet ceremony, nothing special.

On our honeymoon... well, it was restful. I felt this strange pressure that we were supposed to spend the whole time in bed, doing it like bunnies. But I looked at Heidi and just didn't feel the urge any more. We enjoyed the sunshine of our Caribbean resort, but my new wife didn't seem to push for any kind of physical consummation, either.

After we got home, neither of us commented on the complete lack of sex on our honeymoon. We soon got back into the same routine — I was off to the City for work, Heidi was either practicing on her cello at home in our little place in Camden, or else rehearsing with the orchestra at the Philharmonic's base in Shoreditch.

I found myself wondering if we'd made a mistake, getting married. But again, the subject seemed too difficult to bring up with Heidi. Perhaps if we hadn't married, we would have split up. I'm not sure. The thing was, it was easier not to split up: we didn't want to argue, we didn't

want to have "The Talk". We didn't want the cold emptiness of singledom to return, especially with our lives changing so dramatically on entering the real world. Marriage did nothing to stir our passion for each other. Yet rather than believing we should do something about it, we simply languished in a general acceptance that in the real world, you just can't have a stable, long-term relationship that protects you from the pain of break-ups while also having really good sex. Or even just plain good sex, for that matter.

I felt sure that if I went out looking for another Suzi, I might have a chance of meeting someone who really got me going, and sex would be amazing again. I was also certain that any relationship like that would likely flame out after a matter of weeks, leaving me feeling broken again.

Things stretched out for eight, maybe nine months, and we didn't even talk about the fact that we never had sex any more. Heidi moped about and generally I probably did as well, but neither of us really seemed to know how to address the elephant in the room. I focused on my yawn-inducing work at the investment bank PJP while she focused on her music. We almost seemed to be living separate lives, coming together only to eat supper together and watch TV on the couch before retiring to bed to lie chastely on the same mattress as we slept.

It was probably a flaw in our relationship that we never argued. It wasn't that there were no disagreements, but both of us were the kind of people who simply repressed them. It simmered below the surface, festered. Every time I felt like that toward her, it seemed to push me further away from her.

By then, it would have been embarrassing to even suggest making out, let alone actual sex. Heidi spent all the time we were together moaning about everything — but never about the state of our relationship. To begin with I commiserated with her, tried to cheer her up, but then gradually cared less and less until her constant misery really began to irritate and annoy. She almost seemed to revel in it, enjoying her constant complaints at the world around us.

Until at last the tension broke. We did have a blazing argument. I can't even remember what it was about — something trivial, perhaps. Perhaps not. After a stable relationship tinged with passive aggressive resentment, it all came down to a big shouting match in the middle of the street, and finally I said something along the lines of...

"Maybe we just shouldn't see each other any more."

And she said, "Fine. Maybe we shouldn't."

I walked away.

She walked after me a few steps. "Is that it? Is that really it?"

I think she was expecting me to maybe apologize — that the whole state of desperation that faced me, having no relationship any more, would be so horrific that it would keep me back from the brink of walking away from her. Only, it seemed I came to my senses, I saw that walking away from her was the most healthy thing to do — the most healthy thing for both of us.

We shouldn't have been together.

I said, "That's really it."

In our argument, I'd got to the stage where I didn't care in the slightest whether I won or lost the argument: the important thing was, I couldn't be with her any more, it had to end.

So I walked away, not even turning back. She was silent, but I never looked to see what she did. I got myself a room in a half-decent hotel on Liverpool Street, close to work, with the intention of finding a new apartment.

I assume she went back to our place in Camden.

God, we hadn't even explicitly said we should get a divorce, but that was what I was assuming.

I actually felt relief, I felt as though I was breathing fresh air for the first time in months. I felt a little sorry for Heidi, from what our relationship had started out. I felt hugely guilty that we'd had that long, deep conversation about changing the dating rules so that a break-up was never hard for either party — and here I was walking away from Heidi just months into a fairly rapidly-arranged marriage, not intending to see her again.

I think she probably expected me to call her that evening; apologize, suggest dinner, suggest that we let it go, whatever had been bothering us. Or she thought I'd take a day or two to calm down, then come back to her and maybe even initiate something we hadn't done for so many months to reinvigorate our relationship.

But I didn't. I felt free. For the first time since I'd started becoming aware of the desirability of women, it actually felt good to be single. Jesus. Divorced and we were only 23.

I wasn't a very nice guy. I wasn't very nice to Heidi. I knew that, even at the time. I was a coward from the start. I was a coward not to end things when it fizzled between us. I was a coward in how I did finally pull the plug, walking away from her without any plan at all to communicate with her ever again. At the same time, I thought the best thing for Heidi would be for her to move on, perhaps find someone else

who would be better for her. She was damaged goods, I was damaged goods. It wasn't good for the two of us to console each other. It was the blind leading the blind.

I consulted a lawyer, and after discussing the options, discovered that we didn't even need a divorce. We hadn't had sex since the wedding. Not even once. Our marriage could be annulled on the grounds that it was defective or "voidable" — simple, straightforward, and we didn't even have to wait a year as we would have with a divorce.

I found myself a new flat out in the Limehouse area of East London, overlooking the docks with an easy commute from my job in the City. As for our apartment in Camden... well, my lawyer wrote to Heidi to let her know that I would continue to pay my share of the rent until the end of the current lease, which was only a few months. Not unbearable considering the salary from my finance job. Then she'd be free to find another roommate or roommates, since it was a three-bedroom apartment, or move on to wherever she chose.

Jesus, it was a brutal end to our relationship. I assumed that Heidi must hate me with a passion for how things had ended. But she never tried to get in touch with me — other than providing the required consent for the annulment process, and agreeing via my lawyer to stay in the apartment in Camden until the lease ran out.

She didn't call me, she didn't email me, she didn't text me. She was gone.

I knew what a coward I'd been, but it just felt like nothing was going to happen otherwise.

For a few weeks, I enjoyed my own time, and since I didn't hear from Heidi, I assumed she was okay, that she had moved on, that she might even have come to the same conclusions I had: that we just weren't good together. There was the awkwardness of telling my family, of course, but I figured there were worse things people had to tell their families, and it was soon done and dusted. It seemed easier telling my friends, most of whom, at that age, had a somewhat horrified view of marriage anyway.

My guilt left me and I was truly free. To be honest, I forgot about Heidi. I felt great, living life, spending my earnings, enjoying myself out with my friends as a fully-fledged grown up. I even went on a few dates here and there, but never felt like committing myself to anything because of the wonderful taste of freedom I was experiencing after the stifling oppression into which things had developed with Heidi.

Then perhaps eight or nine months into my fresh start, on one particularly miserable Saturday evening when the rain was just incessant, there was a buzz at my door, and it was Heidi.

Chapter Two

"Do you mind if we just... talk?" she asked in a small, quiet voice.

Instead of buzzing her in to the building, I said, "Wait."

I went down to see her in person, there on the street. I had to — I was in two minds about how to deal with her. I heard the pitiful tone of her voice through that intercom, and I instantly felt sorry for her; I felt guilty for how I'd left her. After the callous way I'd ended our marriage, I suddenly felt some responsibility for her well-being. Yet at the same time, I knew how well Heidi had always been able to lull me into feeling pity for her, commiserating with her, wanting to make her feel better. I feared it was a road that might lead inexorably back to the kind of semi-comatose relationship ours had been for so many months.

I wanted to go down there so that I might be clear in refusing her entry after hearing her make her case, or inviting her in if it seemed safe.

I opened the door and there she was, dressed conservatively in jeans and a fairly plain blue sweatshirt, looking pale and diminutive, her eyes red from tears. Not caring about the rain streaming down all over her, soaking her to the skin.

"You found me, then?" I asked her.

She nodded. "Your address was on some of the paperwork from your solicitor."

That made sense. I guess I'd never said anything to the lawyer to suggest I was concerned about giving out that kind of information to Heidi.

"Look, I don't want..." she said, a faint tremor in her voice like she was doing her utmost to keep from crying. "... I... I know you don't... you don't want me any more..."

I sighed. My heart was melting for her. And suddenly I was noticing how pretty she was. Funny how I hadn't seen it, ever since the physical desire had petered out between us — I'd thought her quite plain. But here she was, and a little absence had made the heart grow fonder. She was wearing a little make-up, which she'd fallen out of the habit of doing early on in our relationship. She wasn't a catwalk model, but she was a pretty enough girl — she just never did herself any favors in making the most of it.

"Heidi, I'm sorry..." I mumbled, not quite knowing what to say — attempting a kind, pitying tone despite being reluctant to capitulate.

"I... I'm not trying to ask you to take me back..." she said, though the faint wobble in her voice kind of suggested otherwise. "

A sniff.

"I just want... I just want you to help me...tell me..."

I saw the tear slip out, to trickle down her cheek. I felt my insides quietly collapsing. Poor Heidi. I'd gone off and embraced my independence like never before, our long rocky relationship having apparently braced me with a new outlook on life — and Heidi had been dropped right back into the despair she'd been in when we'd started seeing each other.

She sniffed again, wiped her face with her sleeve, trying to appear strong. She said, "I want you... to tell me what's wrong with me."

I was a little taken aback at that. "What's wrong with you?"

She nodded. "You stopped... wanting me," she said, and I could see that while I'd been assuming Heidi would just move on and find someone else to date, in fact she'd probably been wallowing in some desperate attempt to analyze what had gone wrong with us. "You stopped wanting me... and I guess... I guess I'm scared that the same's going to happen with everyone else, too."

"No..." I said, genuinely surprised at the way she was taking this.

"There's something wrong with me," she said, "and unless I figure it out, this is just going to happen again and again and again."

"I — " I said, a little stunned. She'd always been a pessimist, but this took the breath away. "It's not going to happen again."

Yet I looked at her and I did feel so sorry for her, I did feel responsibility for her. I realized she was standing there in the rain getting drenched.

"Look, come in, come in," I said, opening the door fully, grabbing her hand to get her in out of the downpour. "You're going to catch your death out there."

"Thanks," she gave me a weak smile as I closed the door behind her. "Should've brought an umbrella."

I wandered over to call the elevator. "You want some coffee?"

"Please."

On the way up she said, "I swear, I'm not trying to.... you know... get you to take me back..."

I probably could have been fairly cynical, thinking that she might be doing precisely what she'd just sworn she wasn't. But somehow after several months away from her, I had settled into my early disposition toward her, rather than the jaded view I'd affected in the latter phase of our relationship.

Without the pressure to be her husband, somehow, I remembered that I'd once really liked Heidi.

"I know," I replied to her. "But let's talk, huh? We can talk."

She seemed quite relieved. I saw the little tremble in her hands — she was nervous, she was scared, even. She had been very upset at what had transpired. I showed her into the apartment, and she was clearly impressed at how much space I had to play with. That was East London versus North London for you, but also a recent pay rise feeding into my new place. We went into the kitchen and I fixed us both mugs of hot coffee, and for a moment or two it was strangely familiar — and yet familiar with the early stage of our relationship, when we had been on good terms. We small-talked, and Heidi seemed to relax a little.

"How's the orchestra?"

"Oh, you know, the same. We're doing these Bach cantatas with the Baroque Singers and it's just... annoying."

"You never did much like Bach."

"He's okay. I just grew up having it forced down my throat, so..."

Coffee in hands, we went through to the open-plan lounge-diner, and sat at either ends of the couch, holding our coffee mugs as though they were shields against the awkwardness of how this conversation was going to go. They weren't great shields. We sat and silence descended upon us... and it was awkward. How could it not be?

Yet after a moment, she took a deep breath and said, "So, look. I want you to be... you know... brutal... and just tell me, straight... you know... what's wrong with me."

It was as though she'd practiced saying it, over and over in front of a mirror, at length, before coming here. She was still hideously nervous saying it, but she knew she desperately wanted to say it, she needed to get this out there.

"Heidi..." I complained, "there's nothing wrong with you... we just weren't right together."

Okay, so I had various complaints about her, but they all seemed trivial now. And my guilt was telling me firmly that all of them were probably more a reflection on my own flaws.

"I swear, I'm not going to feel bad..." she said, that voice quivering a little, suggesting to me that it wasn't as simple as she claimed. "I just want to know... I... I don't want to meet a really nice guy and then... you know... put him off..."

I sighed, "You're not going to put him off. You'll meet someone who is... you know... better for you. Right for you."

She looked me straight in the eye and said, "You were right for me. We got married, for heaven's sake. But you... lost interest..."

I felt something squeeze my stomach, ruthlessly. Probably justice, or fate, or karma, or something like that. So, was she saying she hadn't lost interest in me? In which case, why had she never said anything?

Well, I didn't know what to say. I searched my empty head for something.

Heidi said, "I think you probably should have called it quits a long time ago. But you didn't want to hurt my feelings, so you just... you know... kept it going."

She was right, of course. But the way she put it did make me sound gallant, rather than cowardly as it had really been. Nevertheless, I was mildly encouraged that she might see me — and how I had acted — in such rosy terms.

"I just..." I said, fumbling for words, "...it just seemed to me you were miserable a lot of the time..."

She nodded, and appeared grateful that I was revealing this little tidbit.

"To begin with I just wanted to cheer you up all the time, but after a while... I don't know... you just kept on being miserable."

She gave another little nod. "I guess I can see that. When I was tired... at the end of a long day..."

I shrugged, "People like to complain about things... bitch about people... but when it's all the time... I don't know, it just gets draining."

"Okay..."

"I mean, I wanted to know how your day was and everything... but it got so much that I dreaded asking about it. You could have told me the bad stuff — sure. But just... not all the time."

She nodded again. "I should have lightened up, huh."

Now I felt bad, that I might have said this to her while we were still going out, and maybe it would have saved a lot of anguish. Maybe it would have made the whole relationship different.

"You did when we were first going out," I said, to show her it wasn't out of the realms of possibility. "You were so... cheerful... so up-beat. I figured after a while... maybe it was me. You were miserable because you were with me."

"No," she shook her head, "it wasn't you at all..."

"Well..."

She took a sip of her coffee. "I think... I think maybe after a while... I was too comfortable with you. I didn't make the effort... it was too easy just to open up about all the BS I was feeling..."

"Opening up is okay..." I said.

"...But just not all the time," she finished the thought, offering me perhaps her warmest smile of the afternoon. She was grateful for this. I felt a little like a fraud.

"Uh-huh," I said, relieved she appeared to be taking it well. "You get so down in the dumps... and when a guy tries to cheer you up..."

She nodded, "He wants to know that it's appreciated, that it helps."

I sipped my coffee. Outside, the rain continued to hammer against the window, made you want to stay indoors, nest in a warm bed. I guess I was kind of dreading that the next thing out of Heidi's mouth would be along the lines of, well I wish I'd known all this a while ago, when we were still going out, so I could have done something about it. I didn't really have an answer to that particular point.

Or maybe she'd promise to lighten up, and suggest maybe we could try going out again, seeing if it would improve matters if she made an effort to see the brighter side of life a little more.

But instead, after a pause, she said, "Well, that's a real help, Joe. Thank you."

She surprised me. I was impressed at how she was dealing with this.

"Uh... sure," I said, not really knowing what to say to that.

She smiled, "Of course, I'm not sure I'll get a guy interested enough in me to put it into practice..."

My heart sank again. Here was a little of the old Heidi slipping out — taking the pessimistic view, willing things in her life to go wrong.

I said, "Of course you will."

"I don't think you lost interest in me just because I was gloomy from time to time," she said. Cutting, sharp, brutally intelligent — something I had come to overlook over the course of our doomed relationship.

I sighed. "But it started off okay, didn't it? We were good together in the beginning. I was interested in you, wasn't I? I had to persuade you to go out with me..."

She laughed. "But you hadn't been with anyone for months. I think your standards had slipped."

"You're very attractive," I insisted, but having to argue the case, rather than casually dropping it as a compliment, did sap the power from what I told her. "Lots of guys would kill to have you."

"If they haven't slept with anyone for months either?" She looked at me directly, and I seriously admired her courage. It was all a bit weird to me, but what Heidi wanted to know was potentially humiliating, but she was gunning for it nonetheless. She seemed to want to do something about her apparent weaknesses.

"You got tired of me," she said now. "I just don't want every guy I meet to sleep with me a couple of times and then never want to see me again."

It was kind of funny giving her tips so she might make a success of a relationship with another guy.

"It won't happen like that," I insisted, but who was I to predict otherwise? The way guys can be.

Silence, for a long while. I sipped my coffee, she sipped hers.

Then, "Am I bad in bed?" she said, blunt, merciless.

"Look... you're fine..." I mumbled.

God. I was a coward. But really, you can't just go out there and tell someone they're bad in bed.

"Tell me," she demanded. "Don't treat me with kid gloves. That won't do me any good."

"Look... it wasn't just you... it was me as well..." It was one of those lines that came straight from the book of relationship clichés, but now that I thought about it... maybe it was me as well. Maybe I didn't make the effort I could have in between the sheets. She'd just laid there, waiting for me to do my thing — but I could have told her to get up, to do something else. I could have bought her some sexy underwear to try. I could have taken things a little more steadily in bed instead of rushing to

get it over with as quickly as possible — which is how it had all evolved before the sex had stopped entirely.

"Tell me," she insisted. But she could see it was difficult for me to be diplomatic and do as she asked. She added, her voice softening, "If you were the kind of guy who would walk away from me after sleeping with me once... maybe twice... why would that be?"

I laughed. "Probably because I was a slime ball."

She smiled. "Okay, but seriously. The kind of guy who would walk away from me... whereas someone else, some sex goddess, say... he might stick around for."

I took a big gulp of coffee. "Don't they have magazine articles to tell you this sort of thing?"

She rolled her eyes, but laughed. "But you know!" she said. "You slept with me, and everything!"

I sighed melodramatically. "You're really putting me on the spot here."

She smiled, "Look, trust me. You're not going to hurt me. I want to know."

Another big gulp of the black stuff. And a deep breath. Then I figured what was the worst that could happen? If I did hurt her feelings then, well, she had asked for it. If she was going to take offense at what I said, and I never saw her again because of it, then compared to how my life was going before this afternoon, I wouldn't have lost anything.

I said, "Okay... well... you can be a little... passive... in bed."

"Passive?"

"You just... kinda lie there. You lie there and wait for it to be over."

"Okay... I guess I can see that..." she said.

"So maybe the guy thinks... you know... you do want it to be over pretty quick... and so it is."

"I never really had much experience..." she said in mitigation. "You know... before you... there was Matt... and maybe only a couple of others..."

"I got lazy too," I said, and that was true enough.

She said, "When you start out dating, you make all that effort to impress a guy... you put on make-up, nice perfume... I guess I just... let things slip."

"Because you had me," I agreed, though I knew I'd let things slip, too.

"I just have to keep making the effort," she nodded.

"And really," I said, "the guy should as well."

She smiled. "You made the effort long enough."

She was being nice to me. Forgiving. She couldn't have been this forgiving when she'd been mourning our lost relationship, though, surely. If she had, then... well, she must have turned to self-loathing, which wasn't good.

"Well," she put her empty mug down on the coffee table. "This has been really helpful," she said, hinting that she ought to be on her way.

"I'm glad it was," I said. I felt a little funny — a little disappointed, perhaps, that she hadn't actually tried to persuade me to take her back.

Now that I'd told her something of the reasons why our relationship broke down — ignoring, it has to be said, my own flaws and problems — I felt a funny flicker of desire for her. She was, if you were looking for it, attractive. She just needed to make more of it.

We rose to our feet, and she came in for a hug. I breathed in her familiar perfume and somehow it didn't irritate me this time. I felt mild regret for losing her — and for making her so upset. I felt some responsibility for her getting back on her feet.

"Look," I said flippantly, "if I took you to a club tonight, I could show you all kinds of guys who'd be interested in you."

She laughed, "Oh right, I bet."

"Seriously. You'd have them eating out of your hand, I swear."

"Seriously," she stepped away from me. "I seriously doubt I could even get a guy to buy me a drink."

I don't know. I don't know where it came from, but something caught my interest in the idea. Be it this innate pessimism slipping out from Heidi's mouth again, or the guilt I felt in leaving her alone and doubting herself, it seemed like a challenge to me.

"Okay," I said, "let's do it."

"What?"

I nodded, decided. "How about next Saturday?" I asked her. "We could do Friday, but my boss has been keeping us in on Fridays."

"Saturday." She just seemed confused, but I didn't want her to meekly decline this particular suggestion.

"Great," I said as though it was mutually agreed. "Here's what we do. Make yourself look good — make-up, perfume, some nice clothes, really do it right. Then I'll come by at say... nine o'clock? We'll go to Johnny's. If it's lousy, we'll try some place else."

"Okay..."

"And I'll show you five guys who'd want to ask you out."

She was laughing, but there was a light in her eyes that I hadn't seen for a very long time.

"Okay," she said, "you can pick me up next Saturday at nine. But if it doesn't work..."

"Then we'll get drunk and have a fun night anyway — and I'll pay," I said. Part of me was silently warning against this, against the risk of getting entangled in Heidi all over again. But it was kind of fascinating to me. I wanted to make her see that if she made the effort, guys would come flocking.

Maybe I even wanted some guy to ask her out, and have her accept.

Yet strangely, it wasn't just so that I could absolve myself of the guilt of dumping her. I thought about Heidi dolling herself up, and of other guys at the nightclub trying to chat her up, and it actually made me feel oddly good about her again.

"Do it," I said, feeling unexpectedly energized, feeling as though I didn't want to take any excuses from this girl now, feeling as though I could control her and show her directly that she could make herself happy in this way. "Saturday evening — take a nice, long shower, shave your legs, put some fancy underwear on, a nice little dress... brush your hair... put on some make-up, perfume..."

"And maybe some shoes, too?" she said, teasing me about this great long list of instructions as she headed for my door.

"If you must," I said, a little stoked by the realization that she actually seemed to be willing to do this, to do exactly as I told her.

"Fancy underwear?" she asked as I opened the door for her.

"Who knows — maybe you'll get lucky," I shrugged. It gave me a weird little buzz to be telling her to wear sexy underwear in the hope of sleeping with some stranger we might meet at Johnny's.

She said, "Okay. Don't be late — I'll just assume you're not coming, so..."

"I won't be late," I declared, and had every intention of keeping my word. I didn't like the hint of sadness that crept back into her voice — the pessimist in her imagining that I wasn't serious about this adventure planned for next week.

I stopped her just as she started walking away toward the elevator.

"Hey," I said, and she looked pleased that I'd stopped her. Pleased and a little hopeful. "Look, if you ever need to talk... you know... if you're feeling crappy... you should just stop by. Any time."

She smiled, grateful. "Maybe," she said. "But I promise not to overdo it on the whole misery thing. This time."

I nodded. "Listen. The code on the door is 6402. If I'm not home and you just need to escape... just drop by, okay?"

"I will. Thanks, Joe. For everything."

She stepped into the elevator, and the doors closed. I suddenly wondered if my last-minute offer might encourage the same kind of relationship as we'd had before — with me acting as merely her therapist, rather than a boyfriend or husband.

But then I figured I just had to be careful — and I had to cheer her up, distract her rather than allow her to wallow in her problems. I had given her Saturday as something to look forward to, and with that kind of light at the end of the tunnel, her mood could be lifted.

Settling down in my apartment again, I was actually excited about the thought of taking her out the following Saturday. And in fact, I couldn't stop thinking about it all week. It wasn't a date, at least between us, and yet I was buzzing as though it was. I honestly didn't plan for it to turn into a second phase for our relationship — I was fascinated by the idea that we could get out there, and I could help her to find her next relationship.

I assumed I must have some cupid genes, some matchmaking aspect to my character that had hitherto gone unnoticed.

And as the following Saturday approached, my manhood was rock hard in my pants at the thought of Heidi showering, dolling herself up, finding her best bra and panties, a nice seductive dress, all for the purposes of finding some new guy who wasn't me.

How bizarre was that?

Chapter Three

The following Saturday, five to nine. I wasn't going to let her get out of this now — I was on time, so she had no excuse not to come out to Johnny's to try this funny little plan of mine.

My heart was pounding, my hands were a little clammy. I was nervous as I stood outside her door — our door, it still felt like — waiting to see how she would respond to my instructions.

Then the door opened, and Heidi was there in a little black dress, her hair nicely straight and flowing down her back, her perfume sweet and not her usual choice, her make-up as if she'd had it professionally done. Her look was so different than anything I'd seen before on her, it made me wonder if she hadn't been reading magazine articles on applying make-up since she'd left my place.

"Wow," I said, and I wasn't just flattering for the sake of it. For the first time in a long time, I was reminded of my crush on her. "Just, wow."

I won't say girl-next-door had become movie star, but staid librarian had certainly become office hottie.

"Okay," she said, "I did my best."

"You look amazing!"

She gave me a twirl. Her dress dropped down to just above her knees, which was short for Heidi. It was flattering on her, though she stood a little awkwardly in it and the high-heeled black shoes she also had on. The thin straps hung from her shoulders as though a few careless glances might cut them and send the dress tumbling to the floor. And she

was wearing a push-up bra, which gave her chest a nice shape under the dress.

She'd never looked like this for me — I might have eaten her up. But now wasn't the time for regrets. I was still fixated on this idea of finding some other guy for her.

"I'm not sure about the fancy underwear," she said, and lifted the hem of her dress until she exposed a pair of black panties that had a little lace here and there, and a little black bow on top, but were otherwise fairly plain. Not exactly what you'd describe as sexy lingerie, but pretty nice for Heidi.

It was kind of a curious thrill for this girl to be showing me her panties, under the pretext of potentially luring another guy to get inside them. I suppose she had been my wife, I was familiar with her. But now that our marriage had been annulled... could I even call her my ex-wife? She was just my ex.

"Very nice," I said. "They'll do for starters."

She blushed faintly, but clutched her little bag and accepted my hand in invitation to step out with me, for the taxi ride over to Johnny's, a bar-nightclub on the river, just down from Temple. Hardly the classiest night out around, but had always seemed fairly safe to me.

Baby steps for Heidi, I thought. This might have to be a gradual process. If I could get her talking to a few guys, that would be a good start. I needed to build her self-confidence to break her out of this rut she'd found herself in.

Not long after nine-thirty was still a little on the early side for Johnny's. Nevertheless, we found ourselves a little table and started on the cocktails, and I think Heidi was just happy enough to be out and spending time socially with someone. Every now and then, I did see guys glance her way. There weren't many to choose from just yet.

"Look, that guy over there."

"You don't have to lie, you know," she said.

"I'm not. I swear, that guy was totally checking you out."

"I think I need a few more drinks."

As ten o'clock rolled on, one blond-haired guy even strolled on over to talk to Heidi. She brightened as she saw him head her way — then the luster faded from her eyes as she appeared to recognize him.

"I thought it was you," he said, beaming brightly.

"You know..." she shrugged.

"You think they'll get Crabtree to conduct next week? I heard he's in town..." I almost rolled my eyes at the guy's approach.

"Could be, could be..."

There was a long, highly awkward pause. It made me feel like this whole project of ours was not going to work so brilliantly if we only found orchestra guys for Heidi to talk to.

"Well... hey, great seeing you."

"You, too."

I was trying not to make obvious expressions at Heidi as this was happening, but as he left, I heaved a huge sigh and said, "Well, he was clearly into you."

Heidi laughed. "He's with the orchestra. There is no way on Earth I am going to sleep with him."

"Okay," I nodded, and checked an invisible name off an invisible list. "So. No orchestra guys."

The place seemed to get busier around 10:30, nicely lively by about eleven. By then, our early start was beginning to pay dividends. All the cocktails that had been flowing through us meant Heidi seemed to be relaxing and loosening up.

We wandered through the crowd to the bar to get some more drinks — abandoning our table, since it seemed to me more of a barrier to guys approaching Heidi than anything — and I did see guys glancing at her. Yet Heidi seemed to be doing her best to hide behind me, keeping close as though we were a couple.

Drinks in hand, I said, "Okay, we're gonna have to separate here. People will think you're taken."

She gave me a nervous smile, understanding, but probably wishing she didn't have to do this.

I turned, said, "Just act as though we're not here together."

"Okay..."

I took a step away, and it seemed as though I was with other people, and Heidi was on her own by the bar. She looked like a young deer separated from her herd — timid, uncertain, vulnerable.

She looked down at her drink, and when a couple of guys along the other end of the bar glanced her way and smiled, she simply shied away from them, turned her head, giving them the cold shoulder.

It happened a few times. It was the pessimist Heidi closing the door on her opportunities before they even really arose. I found myself a little annoyed, but then checked myself. What had I really been expecting? To drop her in the deep end and see her suddenly become some man-eating vamp?

"Okay," I said just loud enough for her to hear, though trying to avoid giving any clues to witnesses that I knew her. "Leave your drink with me. Go over there and stand next to that guy."

"That guy? The guy with the blue shirt?"

"The guy with the blue shirt. Stand next to him like you need to order a drink for yourself."

"And..."

"And if he tries to speak to you, smile and talk back." It was the basics, but Heidi seemed to need a little prod.

She nodded, uncertainly.

I said, a little more firmly — and probably unfairly, too, "There's no point if you're not going to give it a try. I might as well just head home..."

"No — " she interrupted my vague threat. "I'll do it. I just... I need to be ready for it."

She took a big gulp of her drink, and slid the glass along the bar toward me. I don't know... I was a trifle surprised she was so willing to do what I told her like this. I was impressed at her courage, too. But deep down, I realized that the threat of me going home, of ending our little night out before it really got going, hit her hard. If I left, she'd go home too, and her roommates obviously weren't the types to force her to go out and socialize, to break the gloom that had fixed on her since our break-up.

I had a certain power over her in this. I was an odd feeling, but I felt I needed to take advantage of it if I wanted to push Heidi into moving on with her life.

"And smile at him," I told her just before she moved away to embark on her mission. "Smile a lot."

She moved around a few people, then glided into place next to the guy who had been waiting to be served for a while. It took a few moments of her standing forlornly, apparently attempting to catch the eye of the bartender. Then, a little nervous glance at the guy next to her, and for a moment I was thinking what a disaster this could prove to be if the guys in this bar were not going to play ball — if they were as nervous as she was.

But this was Johnny's. It was supposed to be a meat market.

Finally, the guy smiled at her, and Heidi returned his smile.

"Hey, can I get you a drink?"

Now she flashed her eyes at me, mildly astonished, but then immediately turned her gaze back to the short but friendly-looking guy in the blue shirt.

"Oh... uh, sure..." she said. "Margarita?"

He duly procured it for her, and I stepped back to watch as subtly as I possibly could. I was excited for her, and it seemed to me I was sharing in some of the buzz of having someone flirting with her. I'm not quite sure why it felt so good for me.

"So I haven't seen you 'round here before," he said, loudly to be heard over the music from the dance floor. Loud enough that I could hear.

"Oh, I just... I don't usually go out too much."

"Special occasion?"

"I don't know... I just split up with my... my ex..."

He raised his eyebrows. "Seriously? The guy must be insane..."

Heidi blushed, and glanced over at me again. She was loving the attention. And as well as loving being right that guys would be interested in her, I was loving their attention on her as well.

After a while the guy asked if Heidi would like to go find a table, and she politely declined, saying as nicely as she could that she was supposed to be meeting a friend right about now. The guy shrugged his shoulders and nodded, wishing her a good night before fleeing the scene.

"What was that?" I complained as the coast became clear. "He wanted you to go with him, get a table."

"I don't know," she scrunched up her face briefly, but then shot me an ear-to-ear grin. She was delighted at what had happened, even if the guy himself wasn't what she wanted.

"You see? You put a bit of effort in, guys are falling over themselves to talk to you."

"I wouldn't say falling over themselves... Anyway, the bet was that five guys would show interest, right? If I accepted the first invitation that came my way..."

"Okay," I chuckled. "We amend the bet. Five guys hit on you, but if you go for someone before five have come along..."

"Well, I doubt it'll come to that..."

It wasn't long, though, before another fairly short guy came along and tried his luck with her. I suppose Heidi wasn't so tall herself, which gave shorter guys a little hope. Whatever, she was lapping up the interest. It made me feel all warm inside to see her confidence boosted.

And deep inside, I did want her to succeed. I wanted her to get laid. I couldn't explain why, but it was a thrill even to think that it might

happen. Why would such an altruistic approach to Heidi get me all fired up as well? I couldn't understand it.

I was even a little jealous, seeing her all dolled up and flirting with other guys, and as the night wore on, dancing with them. And yet I still wanted one of them to invite her back to his place, and for Heidi to accept.

I think there was something in my perception of Heidi as a fairly quiet type — mild and conservative, not much of a party animal. She had a purity I wanted to see corrupted.

Guy number three danced a couple of numbers with her before she begged off and returned to me. Then guy number four seemed to get very close to her on the dance floor — holding her, his arms encircling her at one point — but then he failed as well, and she was back with me, being teased about losing her bet very soon.

"So wait..." she said, sipping yet another margarita. "What do you get if you win the bet?"

I grinned. "I get the pleasure of seeing you happy for once."

She laughed. "I can be happy! It doesn't take a bunch of guys hitting on me."

"No, but it helps, right? You can see that they really are interested in you."

"It's all this make-up. And probably this bra."

"Who cares? They want you, not just a bunch of make-up and underwear. And pretty soon, I'm sure number five will be coming along..."

"Okay," she beamed. "So what do you want... you know... if you win the bet?"

"Okay..." I thought for a moment or two. Then I felt that odd surge of power flowing through my veins. I said, "When number five comes along... if you find him even the least bit attractive, you have to dance with him and if he seems like he wants to, you have to make out with him."

Heidi laughed. "This seems like kindergarten again, and we're playing kiss chase."

"That's the bet," I insisted, then backed away from her to show the room that she was single and not with me.

She wandered the fringes of the dance floor for all of three minutes before Guy Number Five appeared. And he was, by any objective standards, a good-looking guy; fairly tall, too. Heidi glanced over at me,

perched on a bar stool within easy eye-sight, raised her eyebrows and opened her mouth as though shocked.

I returned some kind of encouraging expression and watched as the athletic-looking guy escorted Heidi out onto the dance floor. She put her arms around his shoulders and began swaying to the slow music, and each time they turned and she was looking over his shoulders at me, she would be catching my eye and it would appear, trying to make me jealous.

I just smiled and applauded, encouraging her. I wanted to see her make out with him, I wanted to see her go home with him. It wasn't just the prospect of my guilt evaporating. The thought of this guy bedding her genuinely seemed to turn me on.

And yet conversely, all this male attention on her, and the idea that she might really do something with this Guy Number 5, made me actually desire her.

They were holding each other close, murmuring into each other's ears. Smiling at each other's jokes. Gazing into each other's eyes. My heart was pounding. I was willing them to do it.

"Hey, would you care to dance?"

I looked up. A pretty blonde in a red dress was standing there offering her arm.

Jesus.

She reminded me of Suzi. Oh, how I would have gone for her if she'd come along a month, a week, even a day ago. I didn't get asked to dance by women, this was not the kind of opportunity a guy should pass up.

And yet my attention was on Heidi, and it seemed more appealing to me to see her getting lucky with Guy #5 than to get the chance to dance — and more — with some random attractive blonde I'd never met before.

"I'm sorry," I smiled as warmly as I could. "I'm waiting for someone."

Blondie nodded and smiled. "You come find me if she doesn't turn up, huh?"

When I turned back to the dance floor, I saw Heidi clasp her hands together behind Number Five's neck and push up on tiptoes to kiss him. Five pulled her close, his arms wrapped around her, and they were making out as though civilization was about to fall.

I was so hard watching them. Watching her, really. It was a trifle confusing how I felt, but the positive overwhelmed the negative. I was

jealous. I was possessive, for God's sake. I looked at her and felt she was mine. And yet I was pleased at her success, I was elated that she was being shown how desirable she was, I was buzzed to think that she was enjoying herself, excited at this new prospect.

I wanted this guy to have her — and yet I wanted her, too, more than I had for a long time. And that was something I really thought I'd never feel again.

Had Heidi pulled something clever, and genuinely made me want her again?

But this had been all my idea. I had ordered her out here to do this. I had encouraged her to talk to guys, to dance with guys — and ultimately, to make out with Number Five. That had been my condition of winning our bet, not hers. Maybe, subconsciously, I did want Heidi.

Anyway, I was also thinking that perhaps all the alcohol had made me feel this way, and by the cold light of morning I'd be back to normal.

The two of them were kissing for a few minutes, it seemed to me, but then it broke up. Number Five pointed to the men's room, and Heidi was nodding, and as he split off, she wandered slowly back to me once more.

"So what's his name?" I asked, offering her a cheesy grin.

"Eric," she said, blushing.

"You like him?"

"He's nice." She looked at me as though she was uncertain whether I was really okay with this. "He's gone to the restroom."

I nodded. "So there you go, huh? Easy as pie."

"I don't think it's normally quite like this," she said.

"How come?"

She shrugged. "I don't know. All the cocktails... and having you here. Making me think it's all some bet."

"What, it's lulled you into a false sense of security?"

"I just think I probably wouldn't normally be this bold."

I laughed. "Sounds like you need a wingman, that's all. Or someone telling you what to do."

She gave me a funny look at that, and I couldn't quite interpret it.

"Another drink?"

"Sure, why not."

We chatted, and tried as best we could to look as though we weren't together. It was like two spies trying to pass messages without anyone noticing. I faced the bar and my drink sitting on the counter, while Heidi leaned up against the bar facing the dance floor, holding her drink in her

hand. And like that, she could keep an eye on the restroom door to see when Eric returned.

Only, he didn't.

Heidi's mood seemed to darken a little, as more and more time ticked by and it became more and more clear that Guy Number Five had given her the slip. I was surprised, I have to say, and realized that I hadn't even conceived of what might happen if Heidi failed to attract any interest, or if things went wrong as they apparently had with Eric.

"What?" she said finally as we accepted that the guy wasn't coming back. "But we were making out. He had his hands all over me."

"Maybe you were too good," I suggested. "He's already with someone, and now he got worried you'd complicate matters."

She scoffed at that. "Everything was okay until we were kissing," she said. "And then he had to suddenly leave."

"Oh, right, but that doesn't mean — "

She turned to me. "Am I a good kisser?"

Okay. We were in a new era of openness and transparency, but I really did not want to answer that question.

My hesitation seemed to answer the question for me.

She said, "Seriously? What's wrong with my kissing?"

I don't know — I was running on alcohol. I'd been watching her flirting with guys all night, and it had been driving me crazy. I wanted her. I knew it was wrong.

I said, "Okay... show me what you were doing with him."

I stood, and she smiled, and put her arms around my neck, clasping her hands together behind my head. She leaned up to me, and then our lips were together. She was kissing me passionately, and I was on fire, my hands spreading over her cute behind, pulling her to me.

It was strange — because she was so familiar, and yet at the same time everything about her was different. She smelled differently, her make-up made her seem different, and the fact that I'd watched her going tongue-to-tongue with another man made me want her like I'd never wanted her before.

I pulled her to me, and her body crushed against my hardness. My God, she was suddenly the most beautiful girl in the room, the most desirable creature.

Only, after a while — as we settled — I did notice that her kissing was a little... forceful. I guess it always had been. When we had slept together, perhaps I'd even learned to avoid it. I started to understand why a normal guy might be put off by someone who kissed like this.

"Wait... wait..." I pulled back from her, breathless.

"What? What is it?" she seemed delighted at where this was going.

"You're a little too... full on," I tried to explain. "You need to ease it back... you know... be gentle, a little more tender."

"Oh, right," she said, either taking it on board or mildly disappointed that I was trying to coach her instead of just kissing her and then taking her home to restart our sexual relationship.

"I'll show you," I said. "Just do as I do."

I brushed her hair back out of her face with my hands, then gently cradled her head as I slowly moved in to touch my lips lightly against hers. She seemed a little nervous, which seemed wrong since we were so familiar, but endearing. I parted my lips slightly and brushed them over hers, before gently kissing her there, without really applying any pressure at all.

Funny how I was supposed to be teaching her, and yet I felt at the same time I was learning, too. Reminding myself how it should be, I guess, because I'd forgotten how hot a simple kiss could be, I'd lost that when the passion between us had faded. The main thing was that we moved incredibly slowly and maybe I even overdid that, but it did seem to build the tension between us and heighten the sensation of soft lips slipping over soft lips.

Heidi moaned quietly as we locked lips and my arms slid around her waist. She was following my every move — seeing what I did and then mirroring it back to me, but showed she could be taught.

After a long while I was lightly running the tip of my tongue between her lips, seeking out the tip of her tongue very gently, before easing back to simply suck gently on her lower lip.

Then, steadily, the intensity of our kiss developed. I brought my hands up to the back of her head, and we were kissing as passionately as we ever had. It was almost as forcefully as Heidi's previous technique had compelled her to be from the start of a kiss, but thanks to the slow build-up and the emphasis on being gentle, she wasn't so rough.

At last, we parted, breathless, and Heidi gazed at me, wide-eyed and astonished.

I felt another little ounce of guilt that we'd never really kissed like that while we'd been actually dating. I'd done it all wrong, I hadn't put my all into it. I'd used Heidi as some kind of quick rebound, wanting to go straight into fourth base and the home run without first thinking about the basics.

Maybe it was one of the pitfalls of the rebound romance. I'd thought I could pick things up with Heidi from where I'd left off from Suzi, without figuring that actually, I ought to have started everything again from scratch.

"Wow," Heidi said at last.

"You see? That's how it should be."

I was praying she didn't come out with the obvious accusation that I'd never done this with her before.

But she said in wonderment, "Nobody really taught me. I never thought..."

She kissed me again, this time taking the lead — starting slowly and lightly, before building up a little more quickly than before, but nevertheless sensually and completely unlike the Heidi of old.

God, it was seriously hot. I was hard as a rock. I had to hold my body a little back from her to make sure she didn't feel it — I didn't want to go there, I was sure of it. Although I seemed to have this renewed crush on her, the way that our relationship had gone, and the way it had finally broken, meant I did not want to get into things again.

But there on the edge of the dance floor, we practiced for a long while, and Heidi was noticeably growing in confidence with every moment.

Finally, we broke apart again, all smiles, and I said, "Don't you want to try it out on somebody else now?"

Her smile faltered for a brief moment, as though for a split second she'd forgotten what tonight was all about — trying to help her cut through the ice in her search for another man.

"Uh... sure," she said, quickly regaining her composure, then added, "just let me take a quick rest stop, and I can try..."

"Sure. But don't walk out on me now," I said, and she smirked at my reference to Eric, her runaway dance partner.

I watched her weave her way to the restrooms for a few moments, then turned to find the bar. Ordering a drink for myself and for Heidi, I found a familiar face approaching me — the blonde from before.

She slipped something into my pocket, then flashed me a mischievous smile. "You're really something," she said. "Why don't you give me a call if... you know... things don't work out with her."

Then she wheeled on her heels and sauntered away into the crowd.

It made me chuckle. I guess attractive women didn't always have it their own way. No doubt the blonde had been watching me kissing Heidi. Perhaps the very fact that I was with another woman made her want me

more than she might have ordinarily. I mean, I knew how I'd felt when I'd watched Heidi with another man. It raised the stakes, it made me value her more. It made me see her as a sensual, sexual being, one to be desired.

"You all right?" Heidi had returned, and I hadn't seen her approach.

"Uh... yeah," I said, handing her a fresh drink, shaking the daze from my face. "Here."

She grinned, and took a huge gulp of her margarita. "Okay, let's do this, right?"

It seemed obvious that she'd gone to the rest room simply to gird herself up for the task at hand, and now she was back out here, she wanted to get it over with, or at least get going.

The crowd in the nightclub was beginning to thin out — and I was surprised to check the clock on my phone and see just how late it was. We'd spent ages getting Heidi flirting with guys, and it seemed we'd also spent ages practicing her kissing.

Still, there was no shortage of single guys around the place, and as I watched Heidi find her way to the dance floor, to dance on her own, she was soon attracting some interest. A tall, dark stranger, no less. She smiled approvingly as he moved in to dance with her, and I felt that little flicker of jealousy — and arousal — as she did so.

She took her time with him, and her steady approach only added to her sense of self-confidence. Eventually, her hands were on his hips, and then slowly moved up until her wrists were perched daintily on his shoulders, her fingers interlocking behind his neck, her eyes locked on his — showing clear interest and an openness for more.

He leant into her, and the two moved in for the kiss, and this time Heidi seemed in control, calmly brushing his lips with hers before pressing her mouth gently to his, to begin kissing him cautiously and yet sensually.

I felt like some Jedi Grand Master watching my apprentice defeat the Dark Side single-handedly.

I also felt a deep desire for Heidi, an arousal that apparently came from the fact that I was watching her kiss yet another man in the same night. She was really getting into this one, now — pressing herself against him, letting him run his hands all over her as their kiss reached passionate heights.

There was something fascinating and thrilling about this quietly conservative girl embracing her sexuality, opening herself up to her lust — even if it wasn't with me.

My body was feeling a clear possessiveness toward Heidi by now — our kissing, no doubt, reminding my subconscious of our long-standing relationship. So, watching her in the arms of another only spurred a kind of primeval desperation in me to take her back and make her mine.

Yet my head told me that such a move would be foolish. It hadn't worked out between us long-term. What was to say it would if we tried again?

My rational part still told me that Heidi would probably do best finding someone else, some other guy who would appreciate her more than I ever had.

I watched her, perched on a bar stool making sure nobody could tell I was sporting a brutal erection, and I really wanted to take her away and make love to her over and over. And at the same time, the strange fascination in me, and the powerful arousal I felt, made me want to see her take this tall, dark lothario away with her instead of me — to go home and ride him until he was a spent force.

I wanted her to fuck someone else. Even the thought of her having done it made me want her more.

It was a rather bizarre state of mind, I could see that. I could blame it on the alcohol, which was a very easy thing to do at the time, but I'd never had thoughts like this before, and I'd had many, many dealings with alcohol.

I found myself slipping into another daze as I considered these strange feelings, and then the next moment there was Heidi again, reaching for her drink, beaming at me ear-to-ear and looking so damn fresh-faced and bushy-tailed, and oh so damn attractive.

"Well, that was really something, huh?" she said, out of breath as though she'd just run around the building a couple times.

I looked up at her and snapped out of my daze. "What happened to him?"

She shrugged. "He's still dancing, I think. He gave me his number."

I chuckled. "You don't want to spend some more time with him?"

She laughed. "I kissed him, didn't I? I tried it out. And he liked it. More than liked it, I'm pretty sure."

"So why don't you... you know... stay with him?"

Another shrug. "I'm a little tired, I guess. I didn't feel like it."

I nodded. Fair enough. It was getting late. I was getting pretty tired, too, and I hadn't been the one doing all the dancing.

"Want to head off?" I asked.

She nodded, and offered me a grateful smile.

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In the taxi back to her place in Camden, Heidi was all chatty and smiley and laughing, it was as though she'd taken something to get high. I don't think I'd seen her like that since we first started dating.

"You know that guy from the orchestra who came over to us earlier?" she was saying at one point.

"Blond guy."

"Donny."

"He was totally into you," I chuckled. "You don't like him?"

She screwed up her face, but her smile told me that she at least liked the fact that I was telling her the guy was into her. "He's a nice guy, but..."

"But?"

She shook her head. "The guys in the viola section are all sleeping with each other... I don't know... it gets really messy. They get into a fight... then they have to sit there for hours on end while we practice. It's not good."

I laughed. "You might not argue with him. And anyway, what does he play?"

"Clarinet."

"So you don't even sit with him."

"I'd have to look across and see him, though. I don't know..."

"The important thing is whether you find him attractive. Now that last guy you were with..."

"He was attractive," Heidi giggled.

"You should call him. Ask him if he wants to... you know... meet up for coffee..."

"Yeah, I suppose..."

I got the sense that she wouldn't. That she would sober up and feel all self-conscious again, her confidence failing. Or... as we walked steadily back to her flat, that Heidi still wanted me, and thought that tonight was still all about us reconnecting.

As our conversation slipped into small talk, I started getting the feeling that she was kind of hoping we might just fall into bed and restart something. I don't know.... Perhaps I was just reading something into it that wasn't there. Perhaps it was the part of me that suddenly found her strangely alluring again.

But at the same time I was sobering up, and I did recognize that if we suddenly got back together, we might quickly lapse into the same problems we faced before we'd split.

And besides... when I thought about what made her so tempting to me right now, it was the thought of what we'd been doing that night that got me going. The thought of me persuading her to go dance with other guys, to make out with other guys, maybe to do more if she wanted.

What got me going was feeling I had the power to move her, to push her to experience what she never would with me alone. To urge her to make the most of her feminine wiles, and to step out of the relative safety of her bashful naivety — to turn from a relatively conservative and inexperienced girl into a ravishing temptress.

It was all kinds of wrong, this new fantasy of mine, but it was the fantasy that seemed to draw me to her now, and it wouldn't have worked if I didn't, deep down, care about Heidi.

We got to her door, and she said quietly, "You want to come in?"

I saw hope in her eyes, and a little tremor in her pale hands as she clutched them in front of her. I knew it would be so easy to accept her invitation, and so easy to end up in her bed, but then it would be easy for her to re-attach herself to me, and be sure our relationship was back on after a simple little glitch.

That wasn't what I wanted. It was wrong of me, but what I wanted was to get Heidi laid, and not with me. I wanted to corrupt the image of this little shy orchestra girl.

The conflicting part of my new fantasy was that I felt I would want to sleep with her once she had been corrupted, once she had slept with someone else — but particularly knowing what kind of a person Heidi was, there was no way that avenue would be open to me once she had gone there. She would likely as not be in another relationship then, moving on.

But at least, in that case, she would be happy, she would move on. That would probably be the healthiest for her.

I said, "Look... I should probably... you know... head back home..."

I saw a glimmer of disappointment in her eyes, but she nodded, trying to hide it from me by suggesting she knew how it really was, that I'd only been trying to be nice, trying to cheer her up, by taking her out with me that night.

That I didn't really want to get back together with her.

Perhaps that I didn't really want to spend time with her, that she was all alone once more, as she had always been since our break-up.

Heidi's negativity was slipping back in.

I said, "But look... I had a lot of fun tonight. We should do it again some time soon."

"Yeah, we should, I had a lot of fun," she smiled, grateful to me, but not really thinking I was being entirely serious.

Heidi, being Heidi, needed something tangible, something real she could hang on to, not just some vague suggestion of a future rendezvous.

And perhaps, she needed a little guidance, or even something stronger... instructions. She'd needed the threat of me walking out on her to get her to actually start flirting with other guys.

"Next Saturday," I said, firmly. Commanding. "I'll come pick you up again. We'll go out, and you can... you know... practice some more."

"Okay," she said, looking up into my eyes again, hope and optimism filling hers. "I mean, sure, I'd like that."

It was only a week away. It was a firm date, something she could cling on to. And I wasn't putting it off until next month, the next time we ran into each other, next year — she had a few days off, and then I'd be back.

"Maybe you'll find a guy you really like. Someone you'll actually call when he gives you his number."

She smiled and blushed like a schoolgirl. Then she looked at me and didn't seem to fully understand why I, of all people, should want to help her move on to the next guy — but she seemed to understand that I was saying we couldn't be back together, but that I wanted to be her friend. We were back to that conversation we were having when I first asked her out — and maybe I was trying to do right by it, at last. To be her friend. To make sure after we broke up that she was happy, and moving on to the next thing rather than wallowing in rejection and self-pity.

"Maybe," she said, nodding. Grateful to me. Perhaps also a little excited that she might find someone new.

"Why don't I come round a little earlier next time?" I suggested, again showing her that this wasn't a chore for me, I liked spending time with her — at least under this strange premise for spending time with her. "We could have a little dinner together before we go out. You know, start things rolling."

"I'd like that," she said, her smile broadening. "That would be really nice."

"Come here," I said, opening my arms wide in offer of a hug. She grinned and stepped into me, closing her arms around me as I closed

mine around her, though our faces came together cheek to cheek, rather than mouth to mouth. A warm, friendly hug.

I said, "You see, we can be friends, can't we?"

She nodded. "Of course."

"Good friends."

"Good friends."

A last little squeeze, and I could hear a faint but clearly contented sigh, as though her mind had been set at ease by my clarification, her ultimate fears of being left alone were abated.

We stepped apart, and I added, "But I am going to get you laid, Heidi."

She giggled, and blushed again, looking oh-so-appealing to me, even with the last of my alcohol fading from my system. "See you on Saturday," she said, stepping inside her door.

"See you Saturday. Seven o'clock?"

"Seven's good."

And she closed her door on me — which, in my eyes, was a very good sign.

Chapter Four

On my way home I put my hands into my pockets and found a little scrap of paper in one of them. I withdrew it, and by the light of the streetlamp saw the number and the name scrawled above it in plainly feminine handwriting. Bella.

I remembered the blonde who'd been watching me kissing Heidi. God, she'd been even prettier than Suzi. Usually I wasn't really the type to have girls approaching me to give me their number. Suzi had been one of those magnificent miracles because we'd always sat together in a sophomore class in which neither of us had much of a clue.

My break-up with Suzi had been so harsh, now that I thought about it, because I'd been so sure I wouldn't ever get another girl so stunning interested in me.

Now here was Bella, who had been quite unbelievably stunning, coming right up to me to give me her number — and strangely, I found myself drawn more to Heidi, and this bizarre little plan of getting her involved with some other guy.

I didn't want to call Bella because it seemed like doing so would distract me from the odd little fantasy I had about a girl who was Suzi's — and Bella's — antithesis.

A fantasy that in all likelihood wouldn't even allow me to have my sordid little encounter with Heidi once she'd been claimed by another.

I was quite plainly insane. Perhaps it was a good thing I didn't intend to call Bella.

For now, though, I had Saturday to look forward to — and I was looking forward to it, very much.

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Another Saturday came around. I'd spent the intervening week as though Heidi had never come back into my life — working hard, drinks after work with friends a couple of nights, but no communication with my ex herself.

That's not to say I didn't think of her plenty of times. My sexual fantasies seemed to revolve exclusively around her now, and the thought of seeing her with another man. Sure, back before I dated her, I had the occasional fantasy about her — but those had related to me seducing her. Now, it was other men doing it, under my watchful gaze.

I was mildly surprised that I didn't hear from her all week, though. I thought I'd get some kind of email or text message here and there, trying to remind me she existed. Trying to ease her way back into my life to the point where I didn't notice we were in a relationship again. There was none of that. It was quite a relief, actually. A breath of fresh air.

I texted her on Saturday morning, asking if she was still okay for 7pm. She replied simply:

>Looking forward to it :-)

And then there was I dressed up in a nice shirt and pants, arriving at Heidi's place on the dot at seven, a little nervous, wondering what she would look like.

She opened the door and I was a little surprised to find her in a bathrobe. She'd put on make-up, she'd done her hair, she smelled really good in yet another new perfume I didn't recognize. But she was wearing white terrycloth.

"You're not ready?"

"I'm so sorry..." she said, seemingly in a state of despair as she let me into her apartment.

"It's okay — we're not late or anything," I said. "What's up?"

"I don't know... none of my outfits are any good..." she complained, closing the door behind me, then skirting past to head into her room. I ducked my head around the corner of the small hallway to check out the lounge and the kitchen — the place was subtly different than when I'd lived here, her roommates' influence I guessed. But it didn't seem like her roommates were home this evening.

"I'm sure you have something..." I said, slipping into her room after her.

There were several dresses laid out on her bed. I'd say some of them looked a little too formal, though I wouldn't claim to be an expert.

"You don't necessarily have to wear a dress," I suggested. "Just whatever makes you feel... you know... confident."

"I don't think anything makes me feel confident."

"The one you wore last week?"

She shook her head. "Needs to be dry-cleaned."

"You have something like it?"

She paused, then grabbed something on the bed. A blue dress, a little longer than the black dress she'd worn last time. All the dresses on the bed were a little longer, it seemed. She held the blue one up to her, but wrinkled her nose.

"They're all... well... really they're all intended for concerts," she explained. "I don't tend to buy them for... well... going out."

"You could wear jeans and a t-shirt," I said. "Whatever makes you feel comfortable. But..."

"I want to do this properly," she said. Her bathrobe accidentally hung open, and underneath I caught a glimpse of her panties. They were pink with white spots. Not particularly sexy — she could do much, much better — though the way my sexual fantasies had turned recently, I naturally liked looking.

She noticed me see her, then held open her bathrobe purposefully for me. "I don't really own any fancy underwear," she admitted.

I thought for a moment. It would be classic Heidi just to admit defeat, to concede that she just wasn't equipped to do this. But at least she was telling me now, at seven o'clock, rather than at nine or ten o'clock when it was too late.

"Why don't we go out and look for something?" I said.

"Uh... okay..." she said with considered uncertainty.

That timid look in her eyes made me figure she needed me to be a little more firm in my view.

"Come on," I said. "Put something easy on for now — we'll go shop for something."

"Shopping?"

I laughed. "We've got time."

"But dinner?"

"We can grab a sandwich or something. Come on — this is much more important than dinner."

With Heidi in a pair of jeans and a jacket, we hailed an Uber car to take us down to Oxford Circus, which wasn't too far away and the stores

were open for another good couple of hours. Heidi actually seemed relieved at our new plan, her positivity bubbling up into conversation about how she never really paid much attention to what she wore before, except for when the orchestra put on their concerts.

"And that's hardly the same," she said. "If you wear something too racy... well, you'd probably show up the soloists."

"And you'd distract the audience," I pointed out.

She laughed. "Right."

"But right now, that's exactly what you want to achieve."

"I suppose so!"

I'll admit, this wasn't something I had been expecting at all, and I wasn't usually a big fan of shopping. But there was a strange fascination and excitement about traipsing around Oxford Street looking for something for Heidi to wear to wow other guys.

We hit the department stores, and to begin with, we looked at dresses. Heidi was initially drawn to items that were on the more conservative side. She'd pull something off the racks and hold it up to her body, and I could see why she might go for something like that — but it was a little too close to the dresses she already owned, the ones for the concert. Dresses that might be more appropriate at a wedding.

She could see almost instantly from my expressions that they weren't what we were looking for.

I held up something much shorter, tighter, and Heidi's eyes widened in disbelief.

"At least try it on," I said holding up the little red dress. "It might look really good on you."

"I'll try it," she agreed, her tone heavily laced with doubt.

"Come on."

I was learning that being a little firm with her paid off. We went into a changing booth, and I perched on the bench to watch her peel off her jeans and her shirt. I enjoyed the show, even with the underwear she was wearing. I think she enjoyed showing me, too — the sexual tension in that changing booth was noticeable. Jesus, it was more sexual tension than we'd ever had when we'd been dating, let alone when we were married. I think it probably spurred on the whole tension that we were shopping for an outfit for her to impress other guys. And at the same time she was trying to impress me, and I was suddenly interested in her again like I hadn't been for months and months.

She squeezed into the dress and pulled it into place. It did look good. Clinging to her body, it ended high on her thighs, while the

neckline plunged enough to get a guy interested in her cleavage, even if she wasn't possessed of large breasts.

"What do you think?" she said, turning this way and that to check herself out in the mirror, constantly pulling the tight material this way and that to try for a better fit.

"It looks amazing," I said. "You look fantastic in it."

She turned to me, her face illuminated with delight. At the same time, she bashfully covered her breasts with her arms, then tried pulling the dress down a little further on her hips.

"It's a little... short..." she said.

I nodded. "Short is good, though, right?"

She looked doubtful.

"You look wonderful in it, Heidi," I stressed. Firmness, that was the key to this girl, I was thinking. I added, "And remember it'll be a nightclub, so it'll be pretty dark in there."

"I suppose so."

"It's not like being on a stage in the orchestra with all those lights beaming down on you."

"Right," she said, and gave another little twirl for the benefit of the mirror.

Actually I thought the dress was too short for her. Not in how it fitted or how it looked — I didn't lie, she really did look sensational in it — but in how Heidi might accept or reject it. I had purposefully chosen one a little on the extreme side, hoping that if we eventually settled for something a little more modest, it would still end up being on the racy side. Only here we were, and she was indicating that she would accept my original choice.

I was playing psychology, I guess. Heidi, more than most, needed a little psychology.

"I'm not sure I like the color..." she said, and I was surprised that had been what displeased her about the dress. It was a positive sign in my eyes.

"No problem — we'll find something in a much better color," I said confidently.

She changed quickly back into her jeans, but then we headed out of that particular store and into another one where the selection of shorter dresses had been a little more extensive.

"See anything?" I said after a while.

"I'm not sure..." she said, and I suspected her modesty was kicking in again, her reluctance to push the boundary.

I took a gamble. "What if I pick out a few to try..."

She smiled. "Sure."

I felt a little burst of heat inside my chest. Well, if she was going to let me pick out some options... I chose three dresses, all at least as racy as the red one we'd tried in the previous store.

She seemed to catch her breath each time I picked something out, looking as though she was close to yelling at me to stop being so ridiculous. But she didn't stop me. She looked at what I picked out, all wide-eyed and open-mouthed, and then when I was done with my selection, dutifully followed me into the changing rooms.

I watched her strip off her clothes, then don a dark blue dress, a black dress and a purple dress — all of them the kind of dresses I would never have conceived of Heidi wearing.

"I don't know... it seems really short to me."

"No, it's great. You look incredible."

She seemed to like modeling for me, enjoying how my eyes swept all over her, and the reaction on my face. I'm fairly sure it made her want to wear the tiny dresses that barely covered her underwear.

We went into two other stores to try on similar dresses, and eventually decided on a burgundy dress that made Heidi look like a goddess. Though she'd always been a little on the slender side, its satiny finish with a hint of lace here and there seemed to cling to her while accentuating the curves she did have, somehow lending her a natural poise and grace I'd never really seen in her before.

"Well, I'm not sure..."

I say 'we' eventually decided, but really it was me making the decision here. However, it didn't take a lot to persuade her.

"You look so good in it. You'll have guys lining up to buy you a drink."

"I like the color."

"It is nice."

"Bit of a VPL, though."

I laughed. "If we buy you some fancy underwear, that won't be a problem, will it?"

Even stripping out of the dress in front of me, she blushed. But her pride was unwilling to let her flinch from what had to be done. "Right," she said.

After buying the dress, we headed for a lingerie store — Intimissimi. If the buzz I experienced shopping for a dress for Heidi to impress other guys was strange, then it was much more significant as we

toured the racks full of lace and silk and satin. Buying a dress was one thing — but bras, panties, for some other guy to see her in? Wow.

I don't think Heidi could quite believe it, either, but then she was a little staggered by just what we were seeing in that store. I was guessing she'd never been in a place like this.

She held up something for me to check out, her jaw dropping in astonishment that something so ridiculous might be on sale.

I said, "Great — you can try it."

"Uh... what?"

I laughed. "It'll look great on you."

Her eyes widened. But she didn't put the g-string back on the rack.

After that it seemed that all bets were off, so Heidi was reluctant to draw my attention to the particularly scandalous items — and it seemed that she was hesitant to pick out anything at all.

I held up a black lace bra and thong set, and Heidi caught her breath for the umpteenth time — but once again, she didn't say 'no'. As I added it to our line-up, she seemed happy for me to choose.

With various items in hand, we found ourselves a changing booth and I perched on the seat to watch Heidi strip off once again. Only this time, she was stripping off her underwear, too. She did hesitate once she'd pulled off her jeans and her shirt — even though I'd seen it all before, I was no longer her husband, no longer her anything really. But you know, we were in a lingerie store and she was trying on underwear. What else was she going to do?

But then she peeled off her bra and panties, and saw me watching her in the mirror, and from her expression seemed to enjoy the exposure. She actually turned to give me a better view, and took her time in deciding what to try on first.

I guess it had been a while since I'd gotten laid. But absence did make the heart grow fonder, and the tension that had built between us thanks to this new game of trying to set her up with another guy made me lust after her.

I had to hide my hardness as I sat there, inches away from her naked body.

At the same time, I could tell she was enjoying herself. Her hard little nipples, her flushed cheeks, her pupils dilated — hungry eyes. And the longer she spent in front of me, parading her naked body, slipping on this pair of panties or that pair of panties, this bra or that bra, the more she appeared to be giving me a show rather than simply trying on underwear. Her movements became more graceful, her hands spending

more time sweeping all over her curves as she checked herself out in the mirror or asked my opinion.

"God, you look good."

"Hmm... I'm not so sure about these."

"Any guy's going to want to tear those off, soon as he sees them."

My words spurred her on, and I wasn't telling her white lies just to feed her confidence, either. With the right choices she did look hot. And as her nerve firmed up, she even took delight in trying the tiniest little g-strings — though her healthy bush ruled out purchase of those.

"You know you could trim it back a little," I suggested at one point, surprising myself with my boldness — I'd never had the tenacity to talk about things like pubic hair while we'd been together.

"Trim it back?"

"You know, so it doesn't... escape... when you're wearing naughty underwear."

"Oh, right," she said as though she'd never considered such a thing before.

"A lot of girls do these days," I said. I felt a little awkward. I actually liked women with a flourish of fur between their legs, but Heidi's was a little on the sprawling side.

"You think most guys would prefer it like that?" she asked, and I couldn't be sure whether she was using the pretense of "most guys" to refer to what I really liked but had hitherto been unable to explicitly state.

"Especially if you wear that kind of thing," I said.

Fingers hooked in the waistband, she stretched the g-string she'd been trying on up over her hips, the small triangle of black satin pressing against her mound and her pussy, her soft brown pubic hair slipping out around the edges.

I don't know — there was definitely something hot about all this. Discussing her underwear, her pussy hair. Talking about what other guys would like.

"You think I should go do something about it now?" she asked, slipping on a different g-string to compare.

"Not tonight," I said, wary of the time. "You'll be okay tonight. Here, try these..."

Some of the thongs were a little more forgiving of her bush, and yet still sexy. High-cut over her hips, they gave her a gorgeous shape she didn't seem to have when she wore more of her old boy-short type of underwear.

She chose a pair of black lace thongs and bra to go with the burgundy dress — but as we went back out into the store, I was surprised that she also purchased some of the other underwear, including three g-strings.

"I can wear them next time," she smiled as she saw me notice. "When I'm... you know... ready."

The way she said "next time" seemed to be dropping the hint that after tonight, we should continue this game no matter what happened. I was pleased with that — this little game of ours was a lot of fun.

We came out of the store and it was only eight-thirty.

"You hungry?" I asked.

"Only eight-thirty?" Heidi laughed. "Shopping is a lot faster when you're here telling me what to get."

"Hey," I said, "I thought you decided on what to get."

"Heavily influenced. But... I don't know... I quite like you telling me what to wear."

Interesting.

"Maybe you should help me rethink my wardrobe."

"We have time before we need to go out."

"You're not sick of shopping?" she asked. "We could just try Selfridges..."

So dinner was put off, and we went to look for clothes in Selfridges before it closed at nine — only this time, Heidi was only willing to consider items if I told her she had to try them on. It was like some kind of game. I tried to pick out the most scandalous-looking dresses or short skirts, and the most wicked lingerie I could find — and she was perfectly willing to take me into the changing booths and try on whatever I told her to.

I was getting bolder watching her, too. I didn't always just sit there — I stood behind her as she looked at herself in the mirror, and it wasn't just her hands sweeping all over her body to check out how the items fit.

As the two of us moved around each other in the close confines of that changing booth, I swear I could detect the faint musk of female arousal in the air. It was difficult to resist the temptation to just take hold of her, kiss her, perhaps bury my face between her thighs... I hadn't felt this way about Heidi for such a long time, and I had never thought I'd ever come to feel this way again, either.

But I managed to keep control of myself. The overwhelming drive for me was still the thought of getting her laid — with some other guy. Of corrupting her.

By the end, Heidi came out with handfuls of shopping bags, which I had to help her carry.

"That wasn't so bad," I said, glancing at the clock on my phone.

"Much quicker with you telling me what to do," she grinned. "I... I kind of like it..."

She gave me a funny look, which I couldn't quite read, but I said, half-joking, "Maybe we should try that some more tonight while we're looking for guys."

And she said, quite seriously, "We could try..."

We took a taxi back to Heidi's place for her to drop off her shopping bags and change into the burgundy dress and her new lingerie. With a quick check of her make-up, another spritz of perfume, Heidi looked genuinely stunning.

With that, we went out.

Chapter Five

I took her to a different place this time. Adonis. It was buried in a basement in the center of the City. Darker than Johnny's, the music was thumping a house beat and inside we had to press our mouths to each other's ears and bellow just to be heard.

At a fraction past ten o'clock, it was probably half-full. We handed our jackets and Heidi's bag in at the cloakroom and headed for the bar — and at that time, we got served quickly, and were able to make the most of happy hour to loosen up a little.

Then it came time for me to order Heidi out onto the dance floor.

"There's a few single guys out there, you could see if you like any of them, you know, dance with them," I said.

She nodded, and gave me a little mischievous smile, then turned on her heels to venture out onto the dance floor, no questions asked. It was still fairly early for a club night, and while the dance floor was filling up, the space gave Heidi the opportunity to draw the attention of the guys.

From the safety of a bar stool, I watched her subtly moving around assessing the prospects. But she didn't really move in for the kill — she was more submissive, waiting for them to come for her. I guess Heidi had always been a little docile. The way she responded to me telling her what to do in the mall... well... perhaps that was just who she was.

I had to admit, my less-than-secret agenda was to manipulate her into finding another guy. She'd essentially asked for my help in doing so, so it wasn't entirely selfish curiosity on my part. But if she wanted me to tell her what to do, I could probably do that.

So, a guy moved in and started dancing next to her — then, slowly it evolved so that he was dancing with her — and Heidi glanced across at me as though seeking permission. I gave her a subtle nod, and she danced with the guy. The guy was clearly taken with her, but if anything he seemed too cautious to take advantage of her available state. Heidi murmured some quiet apology to him and drifted off the dance floor, back to me.

"Didn't like him?" I asked her.

She leaned into me, filling my chest with her new perfume, and giving me a nice view down her dress. She had a faint sheen of perspiration on her upper chest from the dancing — and because the temperature in this club was on the high side — but it only made her seem more alluring to me.

"He was nice..." she said into my ear, "but... you know..."

I nodded, and spoke into her ear, "It's okay. You need to find someone you're interested in."

She smiled, took a hefty swig of her margarita, and then seemed ready for more.

"Go on then," I said, signaling for her to head back out onto the dance floor. "This time find someone you'd like to be a little closer with."

She nodded compliance, then turned and did as I told her. On the increasingly crowded dance floor, I had to stand in order to watch her at times, but I could just about monitor her progress. She had interest from two guys before ultimately accepting the advances of a third.

He wasn't much taller than her, though that didn't seem to matter. Perhaps a year or two older, he had close-cropped sandy hair and wore a plain blue shirt that gave him the air of a finance worker.

I watched Heidi dancing close with him, and then finally put her arms over his shoulders, pulling him to her. She looked over to me for a moment, and I gave her an approving nod.

Did I feel a little envious of the guy with her? Perhaps. It was more complicated than that, though. The overwhelming feeling was of hope, that she would like this guy, that something would happen.

I wanted her to make out with him — and then, not so long later, she was. It was both shocking and heart-warming, arousing and faintly nerve-wracking. I was overwhelmingly turned on by the prospect of Heidi getting lucky, and yet at the same time jealous and a little concerned I might completely lose her to him.

I wasn't just the kind ex who wanted Heidi to find happiness with someone else now. I had enjoyed our game so far — getting Heidi out

there, pushing her to have a little fun flirting with the opposite sex; leading her into various stores and telling her what kind of sexy clothes and underwear to buy.

She was kissing him for a fair while, her hands sliding over his back, and I recognized how she was putting into practice what I'd shown her last time — taking her time, playing things gently, tenderly, before slowly ramping it up. I thought it was going really well — and then something seemed to spook her.

Heidi gave the guy some other line, apology or excuse or whatever, and again wound her way back to the bar next to me. The loudness of the music meant we couldn't do our act of pretending we didn't know each other. But the darkness of the club — and the fullness of the crowd — meant we were fairly sure no one would really see her talking to me there at the bar.

"What happened?" I laughed. "It was going so well."

"It was... then I felt his... thing... kind of pressing against me..." she said.

I laughed harder. "That's good, isn't it? Shows he really wanted you."

She looked suddenly unnerved, not expecting me to respond in such a way — but then the moment passed, and she seemed intrigued.

"Go find him again," I said, leaning into her ear. "Or someone else. And this time if he responds to you like that... enjoy it."

"Enjoy it?"

I smiled. "You know... press yourself up against him. Enjoy the fact that he obviously wants you so badly."

She nodded, looking a little fearful and yet captivated by the idea.

"Go on! Let him do what he wants with you."

She did as I instructed. Her previous dance partner was gone — perhaps a little embarrassed by Heidi's sudden exit. But it didn't take her long, looking the way she did, to attract someone else. This guy was taller, dark-haired, a more impressive specimen. She had to look up at him as they danced together, but I could see the fire in her eyes, the thrill of drawing such a guy to her.

I found myself debating with myself whether I would get cold feet if it did eventually seem as though Heidi was going to go home with someone else. I still felt that urge to see her corrupted — and yet with all the tension that had been building all night, I kind of wanted her for myself now, too.

Soon she was dancing close with this new partner, her arms moving around him, and it wasn't so long before she drew his head to her for a kiss.

If I was honest, he didn't look like relationship material. He looked like a one night stand kind of guy. But Heidi had never talked about finding a guy for a long-term relationship, she had talked about her worries that she couldn't get guys to be interested in her.

Heidi was enjoying herself, that was the main thing. And I was really turned on seeing her enjoying herself. I saw her pulling him to her, pressing herself against him, and it made me certain she could feel his hardness through his clothes — she was doing precisely what I'd told her to.

She turned her back to him, and now he was holding her hips, grinding with her in time with the thumping bass. Heidi glanced over at me, and I gave her a subtle nod, encouraging her. With that, she took hold of his hands, sliding them over her body — her waist, her hips, her thighs, even up to her breasts.

I was so hard watching her put his hands on her thighs, allowing him to slide them up, pushing her dress up a little further as they went. I had to move a little to see properly, but Heidi had also brought herself and her partner closer to me, nearer to the edge of the dance floor. He was rubbing against her body, feeling up her breasts, or carefully easing up her dress a little further.

Again she looked across at me for approval, and again I gave it to her while trying to avoid her new friend catching me communicating with her.

I saw her grab one of his hands in hers, and pull it down between her thighs. Now he was pressing his hand to her panties, stroking her there, as she leaned back into him and reached up to interlock her fingers behind his neck.

She looked over at me and bit her lip as he continued rubbing her pussy through her black lace underwear. She was writhing gently against him, and it wasn't because she was dancing. I saw her flushed cheeks, and I saw her open her mouth to groan. I saw the shiver running through her body as he made her come.

And as she came, she looked me directly in the face.

My hardness throbbed in my pants. The way she looked at me, it was as though I'd made her come, not the guy she was dancing with.

For a moment, she went with the feelings, but then as I watched, she seemed to come to, snap out of her orgasmic daze, and look up at her

partner, a little startled. She murmured something to him and he gave her a broad, easy smile. Then she was scurrying away — back to me.

"What?" I said. "What's going on?"

She reached for her drink, seemed a little shaken up.

"Did you see what he did?" she said, a complete mixture of excitement and horror. "And I let him!"

I laughed. "You loved it!"

She slurped her drink again. "He had his finger... inside me."

I brought her in for a hug. "You okay? I thought you were having a good time."

She nodded. "I was... I just... it kind of hit me. What I let him do."

"We don't have to do it this way," I said into her ear. "I was just showing you... guys like you. Guys want you."

"Yes."

"And now you know... we don't have to stay. You'll be okay from here on."

She looked at me and it seemed she was afraid that all this would stop. "Oh, we don't have to stop," she said. "I'm having a good time. It's just... I don't know... unexpected."

I nodded. "You could just wait and... maybe you'll meet a new guy at work... or while you're at the supermarket... or at a party somewhere."

She shook her head. "I don't meet people."

"You could try online dating."

"This is okay," she said, taking another sip of her margarita. "I just... I need to toughen up."

"Okay..." I said. I didn't want to push her into doing something she didn't want to do. She seemed to like being led into this, but I felt like I couldn't take that for granted. Particularly if I had a hidden agenda — the fact that I found it a thrill to get her to do things with other guys.

"What should I do?" she asked me.

"You like him?" She nodded. "So go back out there and dance with him some more. Maybe he'll see if you want to go somewhere with him."

"You think he would?"

"Or you could tell him it's getting late. Ask him to walk you home."

There was fear in her eyes, a dose of uncertainty, but also the flicker of excitement and lust. She wanted the guy on the dance floor, I could see that, but she also seemed to be hanging onto the thread of possibly getting back together with me. She was concerned that if she went off with that other guy, things with me would be ended for good.

Was I taking advantage of her, for wanting to reunite with me? Perhaps. But I wasn't entirely ruling it out, either. Only, right now I wanted her to play the field a little, if I could get her to.

"Okay," she said, making her decision, figuring that if she flaked out now, this little project of ours might be over — and then I'd go off and just be an ex to her. If we didn't have this project, why would she need to see me?

"You can do this, Heidi."

She turned and took a deep breath, before heading back out to the dance floor.

I felt a strong sense that I was losing her — and there was an odd sharpness that I'd never felt even when we'd broken up. But there was also something deeply thrilling about it, too. Heidi had only ever slept with three guys before, and one of those had been nothing more than a few fumbles in college. I wanted to show her the world, give her the experience she should probably have had in college.

And the thought of her having that experience, losing her good girl sheen, made her seem just that much more interesting to me.

I watched her wade out into the dance floor again, but I couldn't see her guy any more. Heidi disappeared in the crowd, and for a few minutes I debated moving from my warm bar stool, which I'd never get back as soon as I vacated it.

Then she came back, looking somewhat crestfallen.

"He's dancing with someone else," she said.

"Oh."

"Some dumb blonde."

I turned to order another margarita for her, which by now I could do simply by catching the bar tender's eye and pointing to Heidi's empty glass.

"Some guys are just like that," I told her. "You can't take it personally — he could have been dancing with Cara Delevingne and would have found someone else if she went off to get a drink."

"But he was kissing me..." she protested. "He was... touching me..."

"You're better off finding someone else," I said. "Trust me."

I handed over her drink, and she gratefully received it and took a large slurp. A glance at my phone told me it was actually beginning to get late. Not bachelor party late, but at least a respectable hour for leaving a nightclub. We'd had a good time — Heidi had gotten frisky with a couple of guys.

One of them had made her come, for heaven's sake.

Maybe it was time to celebrate our victories and call it a night. Heidi's glum silence beside me made me suspect she was thinking the same thing.

Then purely by chance I caught a glimpse of a familiar face. It was the sandy-haired guy Heidi had danced with earlier. The guy who had freaked her out because she'd felt his erection pressing against her through his pants while they'd been making out.

"Hey, isn't that your friend from before?" I asked her, pointing him out.

"Uh... yeah..." she agreed. "Nathan."

"You liked him, didn't you?"

"He was nice."

"And you know he liked you." I looked into her eyes and she broke out into a mischievous smile.

"He did..."

She was wavering, a classic old-school Heidi trait. I felt she needed one more little pick-me-up before we called it a night. She needed to go out on a high. To do that, though, she would need a little compulsion.

"Right," I said. "I want you to go up to him and say sorry about before, you suddenly really needed a drink or something... See if he'd like another dance."

"Okay..."

"Then if it seems like he likes you again... take things further."

"I'll try," she said, putting her glass back on the bar.

"Do or do not, there is no try," I said, quoting Yoda. Okay, so Heidi had never been much of a Star Wars fan, but even that one I thought she'd get. She didn't, though, didn't even smile at it. She took it literally — as me ordering her to go for that guy.

Well, I wasn't going to clarify. It seemed to have the right effect: she gave a curt nod, then complied with my request. I watched her sidle up to the sandy-haired guy, Nathan, and greet him somewhat apologetically. He seemed delighted and surprised to see her again, and from the way he looked at her, it seemed she'd averted offense.

Then they were dancing, and I felt the slow spread of warm hope inside me, along with the flicker of darkness — that this guy might actually take Heidi home, maybe even fuck her.

They got into it more quickly this time — already attuned to each other. They were dancing close, and then they were making out again, nervously like a couple of virgins, before warming to each other. I saw

Heidi pressing herself to him, and could tell she could feel his response to her.

This time I watched Heidi put into practice what she'd gained from the previous guy, guiding Nathan's hands over her body, allowing him to touch her breasts, her behind, maybe even slip his hands up her dress. Nathan wasn't as bold as the previous guy, but I took that as a positive sign. Heidi didn't need a walking hard-on like that. She needed someone who would appreciate her and build her confidence.

Then Heidi was giggling at something Nathan had said, and apologizing as she pulled her mobile phone out from God knew where.

What was going on? The two of them looked great together. Was she going to flake out on this one, too?

My phone buzzed in my pocket, and retrieving it I found a text message from Heidi:

>He wants to go somewhere. What should I do?

I laughed, and felt a nervous bolt of energy shoot through my heart. Jesus. Was I really going to let some guy take her home? The throbbing in my pants said 'yes'.

I replied:

>Tell him it's late, maybe he'd like to walk you home? You'll feel safer at your place — and I'll know where you are.

I figured she didn't want to just agree to go with him wherever he wanted, but if he took her home she'd have more time to get to know him and decide whether she wanted to invite him into her place or not.

>Okay. Thanks xx

She stashed her phone again, and said something to him, smiling and nodding. Then, Nathan escorted her off the dance floor and over to the cloakroom. My heart rate picked up considerably. I followed them at a discreet distance, and as Heidi was putting on her coat, she turned her head to find me and subtly seek out my confirmation, my approval for this to happen.

I gave her my blessing with a subtle nod, and then she turned away from me and left the club with Nathan.

I watched them leave, I watched them flag down a taxi and jump inside. The turbulence I felt inside... I was seriously turned on and yet already haunted by my decision.

Chapter Six

I took a taxi myself, back to my place. The journey started off on a high, but the further we went through the City, the more my energy levels seemed to fade.

I think I just kind of accepted that life was going to return to normal. I'd had my quirky little fun with Heidi, but now she was finally getting it on with her next boyfriend, and had to be over her self-confidence crisis, in part thanks to my advice about making herself attractive again.

I could quietly feel satisfied that I'd righted a wrong from our own split, and that I'd probably influenced Heidi to take a different approach to her relationships — which would, in turn, help to minimize the risk of future break-ups, though it could never prevent them.

Meanwhile, maybe Heidi and I could have the occasional drink together as platonic friends, but maybe I would just be quietly forgotten, phased out, left behind.

And then as I was heading past Whitechapel in my taxi, I received a text from Heidi:

>We're nearly back at my place. Been making out the whole way. He thinks I'm texting my best girlfriend so she knows I'm okay.

I sat in the back of my taxi and broke out into a big smile. It was a bit of a surprise. I wasn't sure why she was keeping me informed, but I liked it. It started up those warm feelings inside me again, the ones that came from thinking about Heidi being naughty with other guys.

I replied:

> *That's great! I'm headed home myself. You can text me whenever you need.*

I didn't know what else to say. I might have gotten her into this, but I suddenly didn't feel it was my place to interfere in what she was doing with Nathan.

Only, then she texted:

> *What should I do when we get to my place?*

I couldn't quite work out her angle. Was she asking my advice because she was genuinely clueless? She'd done okay at the start of our relationship, I seemed to recall. She had only been in two proper relationships, though. Was she trying to keep me involved because she was somehow trying to tempt me into getting back together with her? Perhaps I was merely imagining that because I'd become so much more interested in her recently.

I didn't mind coaching her, though. It was strangely fun.

> *Invite him in for coffee, then while the kettle boils start making out with him again. Just like on the dance floor, only this time let things go as far as you like.*

She replied:

> *And then?*

I felt my heart thudding against the wall of my chest again, my cock thick and hard in my pants. My hand trembled a little as I clutched my phone, but I typed:

> *Sleep with him. Enjoy yourself. He's obviously into you.*

A moment passed, and I found myself wondering what were the chances that she would actually sleep with him. If she was the one pushing for it, they had to be high. A guy offered easy sex was hardly going to turn it down if he fancied the girl offering it.

Heidi sent me another text:

> *He actually thinks I'm a bit of a man-eater! Said he doesn't normally go out with girls who are so forward, but he likes it.*

I replied:

> *Okay, so go get him. Let me know how it goes afterwards.*

I hovered over the send button, debating with myself whether to include that last part of the message. What if she didn't want to come back to me and say how it went, with a new relationship underway? She might prefer to just move on, and that would probably be the healthiest thing. What if I couldn't handle the thought of her actually sleeping with the guy? Either it would make me angry at her, or make me completely lose interest.

Well, I hit the send button. I did want to know what happened. The way I was feeling, I couldn't conceive of losing interest because she actually slept with the guy — in fact, it seemed more likely I'd go the other way, and become even more fascinated in her.

I'd seen the clean, conservative Heidi. I'd dated her for months, married her, and the interest had fizzled. I was getting hooked on this new Heidi — the adventurous Heidi, the hot-looking Heidi. The slutty Heidi.

I arrived home and it was 1am. I couldn't sleep — I kept thinking about what Heidi might be up to now. I slumped in front of the TV with a glass of red wine, not really watching the first thing I clicked on my Netflix list.

I actually regretted breaking up with Heidi, I decided. Well, there was a turn-up for the books. I was sitting there wishing we'd stayed together. And yet at the same time, I could not work out how I could have possibly come up with the idea of giving her a make-over and pushing her to see other guys while continuing to sleep with me.

This was what drew her to me now: she was like some pliable doll who would do my bidding, and my bidding was to make her promiscuous for my own amusement. It wasn't a particularly politically correct view of a relationship, but that was how my fantasy had emerged. I could see no conceivable way our relationship could have moved that way had I remained with Heidi. I'd had to split up with her and then have her come to me asking for help moving on, in order to discover this fantasy in the first place.

But now she had found another guy, I was afraid to lose her.

It was some kind of catch-22. I couldn't corrupt her and keep her, I felt certain. But I didn't want to keep her unless I had corrupted her.

If I'd known then what I knew now, while we'd been dating, before we'd gotten married, I could have suddenly said to Heidi, maybe you need to have a little more experience... of guys... of sex... of life... before we think about taking the next step and actually settle down together. But she probably would have taken that as me wanting to split up with her, even if it was amicable.

Sitting there on the couch, I was hard as I thought about her. And every tick of the clock made me more certain things were going well, and that Nathan had become the fourth guy ever to thrust his cock inside her. Four guys. Funny how that made me still think of Heidi as inexperienced, a virtual virgin. A generation ago, that would have had her labeled a harlot.

1:45am. They had to have fucked by now. She'd probably fallen asleep in his arms. I found myself thinking about what it might be like to see Heidi again, have coffee with her. I'd be thinking: you just had some other guy inside you, fucking you, filling your tight pussy with his hard cock. I'd be wanting her, badly, and I wouldn't be able to have her. Things would have to remain platonic. Maybe I'd refuse to have coffee with her. I was an asshole.

Then my phone buzzed. I thought at first it must be a text message, and I strongly hoped she would share at least enough detail with me to confirm that he had, indeed, fucked her.

But as I struggled to pull the damn thing out of my pocket, it kept on buzzing. Not a text message, then. She was calling me.

I picked up.

"Hello? Heidi?"

At first, I couldn't understand what I was hearing. Deep breathing, maybe a quiet cry. For a very brief moment I thought she might have called me by mistake in the middle of some marathon sex session.

But then she sniffed.

"I'm... I'm sorry... for calling so late..."

She was upset, in tears. I felt some cold claw grab my insides. What if something terrible had happened to her?

"Heidi? Are you okay? Is everything all right?"

Another sniff, then, "I'm okay. He's... he's gone now."

"What happened? Did he...? What did he...?"

She was too upset to quite get the words out. She might have said she was okay, but I was suddenly regretting allowing her to take a strange man home alone.

"Did he hurt you?" I demanded to know.

"No — no, nothing like that," she forced herself to say. "He... I... I don't know what happened."

Whatever had happened, I wasn't going to get it out of her over the phone, I could tell that easily enough. Whatever he'd done to her, I didn't like the thought that it could so easily spoil the self-confidence we'd put so much effort into building up.

"You want me to come over?"

And besides, I wanted to see her. Whether to tease myself further, or revel in how far she had gone before it had turned upsetting, or to give in to temptation and just take her for myself, I couldn't entirely tell until I got there.

But since I'd broke up with her, I guess I did miss having a close companion around.

"Is that... okay?" she sniffed.

"Of course it is. Stay put. I'll be there in two ticks."

Uber had me in a minicab in no time, and with the complete lack of traffic at that time of night, I was quickly clambering out and buzzing at the front door of Heidi's building. She let me in almost immediately.

Upstairs, she opened her front door and leapt into my arms. At least she wasn't crying any more. She held me tight. She was still wearing her dress, just the same as when I'd seen her last, but her mascara had run from where she'd been crying, and where she'd rubbed her eyes — and her lipstick was smeared. I could smell her perfume, and as I pressed my cheek to hers, I thought I could detect the faint lingering traces of a man's cologne.

"What happened?" I said as she finally loosened her grip on me, and we were able to get inside her place and close the front door.

"Your flatmates..." I suddenly asked her, concerned we might not have privacy.

"They're both with their boyfriends," Heidi said.

She led me into the small sitting room. I sat in the armchair across from her as she sank down on the couch.

"So what happened?" I asked her.

She looked uneasy, but I gave her the kind of look that told her that if she wasn't going to open up, there was no point my being there.

She said, "It was nice... to begin with... I did what you said. We were... kissing. Touching. We went into my bedroom..."

"And?"

She looked slightly surprised that I wanted to know. After a moment, though, she said sheepishly, "I... pulled down his jeans and..."

"And?"

"You know... I... I went down on him."

My Heidi had sucked on another man's cock. Even that was enough to quicken my pulse and thicken my manhood. Her smeared lipstick was explained, and provided sweet evidence to her story.

"You liked it?"

She looked awkward. "He... it... kind of went soft," she said quietly. A little humiliated to be telling me this, but she felt she had to. What was the point in having me over otherwise? And I, selfishly, wanted to know.

"I couldn't get it hard again," she went on, her resolve building a little in telling me. "He got kind of embarrassed, I think. He said he had

to get up early in the morning for something... for a meeting..."

"What, so he left?"

She nodded, eyes downcast.

"Well that's a load of BS. If he had to get up so early for something, he would never have gone to a club tonight. And meetings on a Sunday morning? Is he on crack?"

Heidi smiled weakly at my gentle outrage. I pulled her in for another hug. She wrapped her arms around my waist and squeezed me, grateful for my being there.

"There is something wrong with me, isn't there?" she said quietly.

"There's nothing wrong with you."

"He was nice... but... I wasn't good enough..."

"Nonsense. He just couldn't get it up. His problem."

"I don't think... I don't think he liked what I was doing..."

I sighed. I knew, deep down, that Heidi had never been the greatest between the sheets. But it took two to tango. A guy could always show her what he wanted, lead her. I guess I hadn't, though, during our relationship.

"Show me," I said, not entirely clear on what I was demanding of her. I knew I needed more information on her about what happened, if I was to determine how she should bounce back. I added, "Show me what you did with him."

She took another deep breath, nodded. She stood, and I saw her tremble a little — totter a little on her feet. Had I really just asked her to go down on me, right here, now? I suppose she might have decided to go fetch a bottle and show me what she'd done with Nathan, but there was a new hunger in her eyes that suggested she wanted more than that.

I waited in that armchair a moment, not quite sure what she was thinking, what she was going to do. Then she held out her hands, offering to help me up.

"We were in the kitchen, to begin with," she said quietly. I reached forward to take hold of her hands, but used my own power to launch myself up onto my feet.

She kept hold of one of my hands and led me out to the kitchen.

"I was going to make us some coffee, just like you said," she said, indicating the kettle and the two mugs that remained on the kitchen counter, complete with coffee granules in the bottom, though never filled.

"But you kissed him instead?" I said.

She nodded and smiled, then pulled me to her, her hands moving to the back of my head, tilting my face down so that she could touch my lips with hers.

I let her lead the kiss. It was a little like the last time we'd kissed, when I'd taught her to be gentle back in Johnny's — only since then, my desire for her had grown further still. Her make-up, her dress, her perfume all emphasized her femininity to me, and the fact that she'd made the effort to look good, her new attitude to dating. And the fact was she'd taken another guy home for sex — and had used these lips on him, on his mouth, on his cock.

Knowing what she'd done with her mouth, I felt certain I shouldn't be kissing her — and yet that feeling of wrongness only made me want her more. As her kiss became more passionate, I matched her passion — sucking on her lips, delving my tongue inside her mouth, pulling her body to mine.

She moaned as she felt my hardness against her.

I broke apart, a little breathless, concerned that we might be getting away from our purpose. Much as I wanted her physically, I wasn't there just to sleep with her. I didn't want to coach her on dating merely to slip back in place as her long-term boyfriend. It seemed like a waste.

"It was like that?" I asked her.

She nodded. "He wasn't as good as you, but... yes, it was like that," she said, smiling up at me. "Then he was touching me, just like when we were dancing..."

She took hold of my hands in hers, and drew them up to her breasts, urging me to touch her there. I did, feeling her small mounds, the lace of her bra apparent through her thin dress, her stiff nipples pressing through both layers.

She kissed me again, and I didn't stop her. I wanted to know how it had been for her, I wanted her to show me. She moaned quietly as I grazed her stiff nipples through her clothes with the tips of my fingers and my nails. Creative license, you might say.

After a while — and it was a while: I felt certain she was dragging this out, taking much more time with me than she had during her feverish pursuit of Nathan — she guided my hands to her behind, and I allowed her to lead me, to squeeze the pleasing roundness of her buttocks, and pull her body to mine, pressing her against my hardness.

More kissing, her breathing becoming deep, and eventually her hands were on mine again, reaching behind her back to move them down, and then up again underneath her dress.

It took me a moment or two enjoying the warm softness of her bare behind to realize she had lost her panties.

"What happened... to your underwear?" I asked her.

She shrugged, "He put them in his pocket."

"And took them?"

"As far as I know."

She took hold of one of my hands, and brought it up the inside her thighs, up under her dress. To feel the soft hair between her legs, the heat of her sex, the wetness of her lips.

"He touched you like this?" I asked her, slipping a finger inside her.

She nodded.

She was very wet. I stirred my finger inside her, feeling the oily slippery slickness, and in the close confines of that small kitchen, I could smell the spicy musk of her arousal.

Heidi moaned as I slid my whole finger into her tight pussy, and pulled me back into a deep kiss. I held her around the waist with my other arm, and felt a subtle trembling as I touched her.

It was a thrill to touch her there — even more so than when we'd been together, because now I had the impression she ought to be off limits. She was my ex. She was dating other people now, we weren't getting back together. It turned me on all the more, because I shouldn't have been touching her.

Heidi finally broke off, needing air, and said, "The guy before Nathan... back in the club..."

"You don't need to worry about him," I said.

"He was touching me like this... and then he found some other girl..."

"Some guys are just like that. Don't worry about it."

"But... d'you think he would have preferred... you know..."

She was tiptoeing around the subject of her pubic hair, and though it didn't bother me now — and wouldn't ever have bothered me, I believe, had she kept it a little more under control — I suddenly thought about how it might be to have her change her style down there for the benefit of guys she might want to date.

It seemed hot to me to get her to make that kind of change in order to attract other guys.

"Maybe," I said. "Look, maybe next time we can try something, right?"

She smiled, nodded. "Next time."

She liked that idea, of 'next time'.

"So what happened next?" I asked her.

"We went into my room," she said.

"Show me."

Again she took my hand and led me, this time through to her room. Though her flatmates were gone for the night, she made sure to close her bedroom door to seal us inside. Then she turned, and looked at me uncertainly.

"How do you want me to..." she said.

"Show me how it was with him," I said. "Show me what happened."

I could see her thinking it over for a moment, asking herself silently whether I really meant for her to go down on me as she had Nathan. Worried that if she did the obvious, I might laugh at her because I'd meant all along for her to demonstrate on a hairbrush or a bottle or some other device.

But she knew I wasn't the type to laugh at her.

Then she stepped up to me, tilted her head up to me to reach for a soft kiss — sweet, warm, tender but brief — before she sank to her knees in front of me, her hands fixing on my fly button, tugging it open before she dragged down my pants and underwear, allowing my hard cock to spring up before her.

She seemed a touch taken aback at how hard I was, but then took hold of my shaft in one hand, guided my tip to her lips, then enveloped me in the heat of her mouth.

For a moment, I could look down on her and enjoy the sight of my obscene phallus protruding from her face, while looking down on her beautiful form in that dress, and to know that this had been how it was with that other guy, with my Heidi, thrilled me immensely.

Then came her teeth.

It was her style to sink straight onto my shaft, and squeeze as much of it into her mouth as was physically possible without making her sick. It was too sudden, too forceful, and the way she did it brought her teeth into contact with my sensitive flesh. The meat grinder. I could take it for a little while — and while we'd been lovers, I'd taken it a few times so as not to hurt her feelings, before subtly encouraging her to move on to other things.

I'd been wrong not to stop her and say something about it. Now, though, I put my hands carefully on her head and urged her back from me.

"Wait, wait, wait," I said.

She looked up at me, confused. "You don't like it?"

"Be careful of your teeth," I said. "It hurts."

She leaned in again, and took me inside her mouth. This time it felt better, but she was finding it difficult to keep her teeth away from me.

I pulled her back again.

"It's... too big..." she complained, breathless.

I nodded, and stroked her cheek with my fingers. "Was he too big? Nathan?"

She paused a moment, then nodded. "I hurt him?"

"Maybe. Probably why he went soft, right?"

It seemed to make sense to her. She was almost relieved to know why it had happened. "When we were together..." she said, "you never said anything."

"I didn't want to hurt your feelings," I said, smiling, and now stroked the head of my cock lazily over her soft cheek. It seemed lewd, wrong — and yet I liked how powerful it made me feel, how it made me feel I possessed her, like I was marking her as my territory even though I was coaching her on how to seduce other guys.

She smiled up at me, apparently liking it, too. "You should have said," she insisted.

"I know that now."

Her hands moved up to my shaft, but for now she only took hold of it, and brought her nose down to gently touch it, before inhaling a deep chestful of air, drawing in the scent of a man, I guess. She closed her eyes and her body gave a slight shiver.

When she opened her eyes again, she said, "Tell me what to do. Tell me how to do it."

I sat on the edge of the bed, parted my legs. "Get comfortable," I flicked my eyes to indicate that she should kneel. She did as I directed her, sinking to her knees, looking up at me with gratitude and devotion, the model pupil.

"Just take things slowly," I said. "Very slowly. You remember how I said you should kiss a guy?"

She nodded, her hands now sweeping up my thighs.

"So then... don't go straight into top gear, right? You need to build up to that."

She took hold of my cock, looking at it as though she'd never really seen one properly before.

"Look at it," I encouraged her, "touch it, explore it... kiss it lightly, if you like..."

She closed the fingers of one hand around my shaft, but this time she wasn't squeezing it. She examined my cock — fascinated, now that I was giving her the time, now that there was no rush, no desperate need to keep a guy interested in her. She peered at it, stroked it very softly with the tips of her fingers, held it in her palms to gauge its shape, its size, its weight.

She traced the tip of one thumb around its bulbous head, trying to hide her surprise at the drop of clear pre-come that seeped out, before gently touching it, spreading it around my tip.

She looked up at me, and ducked down to kiss my tip, softly, then swirl her tongue around it, tasting my small measure of wetness.

She gave me a naughty smile, loving this opportunity to simply become a little more familiar with my anatomy. Then she took the whole tip of my cock inside her mouth, just leaving it there for a moment or two, feeling it between her cheeks, against her tongue.

She sucked, but gently, and she didn't try to force more of it into her mouth.

I moaned. "That's it... not too much..."

She withdrew it from her mouth, but then slipped her lips over it again, taking it back in. Again and again she took it into her mouth, then withdrew. Blowjob-writ-small. After a short while, she removed it completely from her mouth, then gave me a long leisurely lick from the base of my shaft to the tip of my cock — her face poised in a broad smile as she did so.

She was enjoying this, enjoying having a hard cock in her hands and being allowed to play with it.

"That's it," I said, moaning again. "Mix it up... that's nice..."

Now she interspersed her little trick with my tip with her long, sensual licks around and along my length, only as she progressed, she brought her hands more into play, to touch me and stroke me.

"Build it up a little..." I said, feeling so strange to be coaching her, even though what she was doing felt divine.

Her fingers tightened around my shaft, and this time as she took my tip into her mouth, she sank a little deeper onto it, accepting an additional inch or so inside her hot, wet mouth.

"You don't... have to take... too much in at once," I said, my breathing deepening. "Not if it gets uncomfortable."

I wasn't going to attempt to teach her how to open her throat for me, to take me to the root. I've seen it a couple times in pornography. I don't

know if it feels good — but it looks terrible. Deeply unsexy. I had no idea how to show her, I had no desire to show her.

I said, "You can use your hands... to help if you can't... get much more inside..."

But she was doing it already, getting the hang of it. If she didn't force too much inside her mouth, she no longer had the problem of her teeth digging into me.

As she periodically pulled away, to lick me rather than take me inside her mouth, she saw how she could use her mouth to stroke my shaft from the side, rubbing her lips up and down my length.

She still felt able to pull away completely and just tend to me with her hands, gazing intently at my stiff cock to indulge in the sight of the thing, in her own hands, so upright and throbbing from her touch — she was all smiles, so plainly delighted, occasionally flicking her dark hair back over her shoulder, and the fact that she was obviously so elated added fuel to my fire.

She took her time and tried things; using both hands on me, taking my balls into her mouth, stroking my glistening tip around her mouth and over her velvety cheeks.

I showed her how it might be for me to place my hands on her head, to guide her rhythm, to take some control, and, ultimately, to fuck her face. She seemed to like it. She seemed to like everything.

It was the longest blowjob in history, or at least so it seemed to me. Neither of us were feeling pressure to move on to the next thing — I was only, in my mind, showing her how to go down on a guy; I wasn't even sure if it was right to take things to the next step. She was diligently learning how to pleasure a man with her mouth and her hands, keen to simply increase her flying time with me, take advantage of the chance to just play with my cock.

She had definitely improved, and she was, in my humble opinion, becoming quite sensational. I had to hold myself back, urge her to go easy for a little while, here and there.

Then, at last, there was no way I was going to hold back.

"I'm going to come..." I warned her.

She pulled back, and her hands on my shaft slowed to a gentle stroke. "What should I... what's the best..."

"It's your choice," I said, trying to force myself to take deep breaths, slow the inevitable climax. "Feel comfortable swallowing? Guys like that."

"Okay..."

"Or you could let him... finish on your body."

"I could do that."

"Perhaps if you didn't have your dress on."

She grinned, and now slipped off the straps of her dress, standing up to allow it to slink down her body to the floor. She remained on her feet briefly, to remove her bra, and there was her pussy right in front of me. She was so wet, her juices had trickled a little way down one thigh.

It was so tempting. I could smell the alluring spice of her arousal, and it made me quiver with desire. But now didn't seem like the time to go there. Heidi was going to make me come with her mouth, and she seemed resolute to do so.

"You could just use a tissue," I said as she knelt down again, took me back in her hands, offering me her sweet smiles between kisses on the tip of my cock.

"A tissue?" She wrinkled her nose. "Like, spit it out?"

"If you want to."

It surprised me she'd never come to this particular choice. But my guess was that if I'd always been keen to encourage her to move on from oral sex, the two other guys she'd been with had probably done similar — to avoid the pain.

I felt pleased, though, that she was against the idea of spitting. I wouldn't have minded, but thinking about my growing kink of knowing Heidi would sleep with another guy, it seemed hotter to me imagining her taking his come in her mouth, or all over her soft skin.

Now, though, she licked the length of my hardness, then bobbed down on my shaft, her fingers squeezing and pumping my cock, a dark intent in her eyes as she gazed directly into mine. Her nipples were hard, the air was thick with the scent of her pussy — it seemed as though she was almost as turned on by this as I was.

She brushed stray strands of her dark hair back behind her ear and took as much of my length into her mouth as she could, without risking it descending into her old agonizing style.

"How will I... know... when you're... going to come?" she said, pulling off me to gasp for breath.

"I might tell you..." I groaned, "Or you might be able to tell... from how I'm... responding to you..."

She had to know I was close. The way I was moaning, the way I sat on the edge of that bed, my body gripped by the tension of my oncoming orgasm.

"But it could come any time, right?" she smiled, and rubbed the tip of my cock over her cheeks again, reveling in the depravity.

"Any time..." I groaned.

She continued to pump my shaft and direct my cock towards her, and I couldn't tell if she wanted it in her mouth or not.

Then I grunted as I felt the twinge down below, the trigger firing, and that was all the warning she got. I shot a stream all over her face, another on her mouth and chin, another on her chest and her neck. There was something degrading about it, which meant I'd never have been able to do such a thing while I'd actually been dating Heidi. Yet now she was my ex, and I wasn't intent on persuading her to date me, I felt more liberated to behave in such a way.

She did seem to like it, though. Heidi broke out into a bright smile, her face and upper chest sticky with my cream, and now slipped the tip of my cock back inside her mouth even as I continued to fire off streams of come.

"There it is," she was laughing as my shooting party subsided.

"Uh-huh," I said, out of breath, mildly surprised that Heidi continued to hold my cock in her hands, and now ducked down to lash her tongue around my tip, cleaning me. "I tried to warn you."

"Oh, I like it," she said, wiping some of it off her cheeks, slipping her finger in her mouth. "Makes me feel like such a bad girl..."

She giggled and it was such a wonderful sound coming from Heidi after all those months being so downbeat.

"Maybe I should just swallow in future. Seems like it would be a little less... messy..." she said with a wicked glint in her eye. "Although... I kinda like having your hot come all over my face... my breasts... my hair..."

I just groaned, coming down from my high. Heidi rose to her feet and turned to find the towel hanging on the hook on the back of her door, and wipe her face. I shuffled forward on the edge of the bed and grabbed my pants, pulling them back up as I stood, before fastening my fly.

"So that was better, right?" she asked me.

"Fantastic. But you'll have to keep working at it."

"I like the thought of that. Practice makes perfect, huh?"

"You know about that better than most," I said. Well, she was a musician. "You might have to use a bottle...or perhaps we should get you a toy to use."

Heidi's eyes flashed at the very idea. Sex toys — definitely not something for the old Heidi. I'd order her something online. It was so

easy these days, perfectly confidential.

But for now, I was spent. I could probably have stayed. I probably could have waited until I was ready to go again and then slept with Heidi properly. But that didn't feel right. I had my strange little fantasy and it involved keeping her as my ex. The way Heidi looked at me, I suspected she had some kind of fantasy, too, which currently appeared to involve playing along with whatever I was doing.

She didn't seem at all put out as I straightened my clothes, and made it clear I was preparing to leave. She put on a bathrobe, opened her bedroom door.

Said, "Do you want a drink or anything?"

I shook my head. "I should probably get going," I said. "If you're... okay now?"

She smiled. "I think I'm over him, now."

She gave me a hug before letting me out her front door, squeezing me, saying, "Thank you, Joe."

I said, "Get some sleep, huh? Maybe we can do this again soon."

It had been a fairly intense night, I had to offer her a breather. But she said, "Next week some time?"

I nodded, smiled, pleased she was so keen. "Saturday?"

"Can't wait."

*

That night I went online to order Heidi a toy.

God, I'd never done anything like this before. And the old me would never have done this, for the old Heidi or any of my other exes. But I liked the idea of compelling her to practice her sex skills, as she practiced her cello. It was further corruption for her. Heidi had never owned a sex toy before. Now she would have a realistic eight-inch dildo of her very own, to practice stretching her lips around.

It was easy to order, the website promising speedy delivery and discreet packaging.

Afterwards, it was fun to imagine how Heidi might react upon opening her parcel. How she might make use of the toy.

Chapter Seven

Monday evening. As I was just getting home I received a phone call from Heidi.

Since she hadn't turned out to be the type to beg me to take her back, or complain at me for ending our relationship, or generally turn into a stalker ex, I was actually pleased to see her name and number pop up on my phone.

Add to that the fact that we'd actually been having a weird kind of fun since she'd come back into my life, and that for reasons I did not entirely understand she had become my number one sexual fantasy all of a sudden, I might even say I was thrilled she called.

"Hey, Heidi, how's things?"

"Oh, you know," she said, and for a moment I thought she might launch into an Old Heidi-style protest about all the heinous things going on in her life. But instead she said, "Getting through a fairly drab week until you come pick me up to play on Saturday."

I laughed. "I'm looking forward to it, too," I said, and I wasn't just being nice to an ex. "So... what's up?"

I heard her take a deep breath. Something heavy?

She said, "Are you somewhere... you can talk?"

"Yeah, I just got home." Holding the phone to my ear, I unlocked my front door and entered the apartment. I glanced around, but everything seemed quiet. "Doesn't look like my roommates are home yet."

"I've been... doing some research..." she said, her tone suggesting she was unsure of quite how to put what was on her mind.

"Research, huh? Sounds dangerous," I joked, wandering into my room and closing the door behind me. "What about?"

"Well... you know... some guys prefer things a little... more open... down there."

"More open?"

"Less hair."

"Ahhh." Slumping down on my bed, I couldn't help but smile. Heidi really had been thinking about Saturday night already, on a Monday.

"So I was thinking... maybe... I should do something about mine."

God. While I'd been going out with her, I had thought her bush a little excessive. And I did generally like some hair down there. But now I felt a tiny bit guilty for talking to her about it, making her feel pressure to change it. It was part of a woman's identity, after all — and her choice.

I said, "It's only some guys that prefer it differently," I said. "Not all of them."

Heidi said, "I've been reading articles, and it's probably a lot of men. And even if it's driven by the way women are in the media — or porn — if that's the way it is now..."

"It's not all men," I said.

"There are other arguments for it, too," she went on. "But... anyway... I just want to try something different."

"Okay..." I said, not quite sure what she was asking me.

I heard Heidi take another deep breath, then say, "I've looked at the various options... and I think I'm best off getting it done professionally."

"Professionally?"

"Well, you know there are all these kits you can do it at home, but I never did it before..."

"Wait, what're we talking about here?" I felt dim, but I had assumed Heidi had been talking about wanting to shave her pussy.

"Waxing it," she said, and I was surprised. "I mean, I know it'll probably hurt, but it's probably easier in the long-term..."

"Wow," I said, a little taken aback that this was what she had decided, and the fact that she was telling me about it at all.

"So I was just wondering..." she said, "...if you wouldn't mind coming with me... when I get it done?"

I caught my breath, and had to keep myself from laughing. I didn't want her to think I was laughing at her — it was just so unexpected, what she'd asked.

"You want... me... to go with you?"

"I don't know... I just feel... braver... when you're around."

She was my ex. She wouldn't be showing me anything I hadn't seen before. But it did seem like a strange request. I suppose I had touched her there the other night... and she had gone down on me. But even so...

"Are you sure?"

"I mean, if you really don't want to... or if you're busy..."

"No," I said, "I mean... if you want me there..."

That strange sexual fantasy was kicking in again, stirring things in my loins. The thought of preparing Heidi so she could sleep with another man, the thought of corrupting her, of turning her from a fairly wholesome girl-next-door into a sexual vixen.

It did appeal to me, the thought of watching her prepare her pussy for sex with someone else.

"I have a late appointment booked for Thursday night," she said. "I can probably change it if you can't do Thursday..."

"No, Thursday's fine," I said.

"Great. You want to come by my place... 7pm?"

"Sounds great."

"See you then."

We ended the call, and I felt a little stunned. Heidi was really taking this little game of ours quite seriously. But was she on the level? Did she genuinely want me to guide her in finding a nice guy to become her next boyfriend? Or was she trying to set herself up as my ideal, to unobtrusively win me back by finding out how she needed to change in order to make me want her again?

Or was she simply teasing me, showing me what I could have had if I'd stayed together with her but had just told her how she could be better in our relationship?

I wasn't sure. I figured if she did, ultimately, want me back, I'd just have to let her down gently when it came to it. Or if I wanted her back... and if she would have me again, I'd just have to make sure the terms of our relationship were not and never would be the same as they had been.

But somehow, though I was enjoying spending time with Heidi and enjoying the frisson of the sexual nature of our little project, I still could not see myself in a long-term monogamous relationship with her again. Even if I fantasized about sleeping with her, that fantasy revolved around the idea that she was newly liberated — and sleeping with other people as well.

Anyway, I went to bed that night imagining how Heidi might have looked in my bed having waxed her bikini line, and how it might be for her to feel how hard guys got when they saw her like that in future, imagining her excitement from being so desired, so wanted.

By Thursday evening, I could see why Heidi wanted to take the course she was. It was about having a different mindset, taking a completely different approach to dating. Leaving her old self behind.

She hugged me tightly after opening her door to me at 7pm. She smelled freshly showered, and was dressed in tight jeans and a skin-tight pink tank top that looked casual enough — and yet for Heidi, seemed unusually sexy. It didn't even look like she was wearing a bra; there was nothing visible strap-wise underneath the top. She had make-up on, too, and I wouldn't have said the old Heidi would have put make-up on at all for a simple salon appointment.

"Come on," she said, grabbing a coat, "the taxi should be downstairs by now."

In the cool air of the taxi I saw the bumps through her tank top where her nipples were pushing up. She wasn't wearing a bra. For her, it was a sexy look. But it had to be deliberate — she wasn't the type to accidentally forget to put one on.

It made me think Heidi had been doing research on more than just what the latest trends were in pubic hair.

"So how's your week been?"

"Oh, you know. Fairly busy building up to the new season."

"What's on the schedule this year?"

"A mix. Elgar, Sibelius, Mussorgsky. All kinds of things."

Small talk in the taxi disguised her nerves and my sense that this was all a little unreal. The salon she'd chosen was a five-minute taxi ride away, and looked like a sophisticated place in a fairly sophisticated part of town. Still, I felt more than a little self-conscious going in there with her. Reminded me of how I felt going into a family planning clinic as a teenager for my then-girlfriend to request the pill. A fish out of water, you might say, in a place decorated in pastel pinks and yellows, populated entirely by women.

"Have a seat, Jerry will be along promptly," the receptionist said, indicating a small seating area at the front of the salon. "Can we get you a drink? Some tea, coffee?"

Jerry, huh? Or perhaps Geri.

But when Jerry emerged, he did turn out to be a man.

"Hello, hello, very nice to meet you," he shook both of our hands as though we were about to buy a house from him. He had a hint of an Australian accent. "Come through, come through..."

Heidi was suitably smiley and didn't seem put out that her waxer — whatever he called himself — was a big, stubbly guy. She did seem relieved, however, as Jerry showed us through to the back of the salon, to a windowless and nicely discreet private room. Made me imagine she'd been worried the appointment would all be carried out in the main part of the salon where various women were having their hair or their nails done.

"So," said Jerry once we were successfully inside. "I'll just give you a minute or two to get yourself ready. If you'd like to slip off your jeans and... if you're comfortable with it, all your clothes below your waist... you can cover yourself with that towel if you need to. Then hop up onto the table for me... that would be fantastic."

"Sure," Heidi said, seeming surprisingly calm.

"Can I get you guys a drink?"

"No, thanks," we both said as one, and Jerry slipped out of the room.

I found myself a seat in the corner of the room, and Heidi slipped off her shoes before turning to me with a kind of nervous smirk on her face.

"You don't have to, you know," I said.

She laughed. "You're supposed to be here so that I do," she said, unfastening her belt and her fly button.

"Okay, but just so you know... it's your choice."

She looked at me intently, then pulled her jeans and her black panties down her thighs, past her knees, then stepped out of them altogether.

"No use beating about the bush, huh?" she joked. "He's going to see everything anyway."

Naked other than her pink top and a pair of white socks, Heidi leaned back against the massage table and lifted her behind up onto it, not at all concerned with showing me the goods. Her nipples were pretty stiff against her top. Was she enjoying this exposure?

She lay on her back on the table, and didn't concern herself with the towel Jerry had offered to cover her.

"You okay?" I asked her.

"Uh-huh. Just a little... you know... nervous... about how much pain it'll be..."

"They must do this all the time," I said. "They'll know what they're doing."

"Oh, I'm sure they will. If I was trying to do this at home it would probably be unbelievable agony."

We only had to wait a moment or two and then Jerry returned, seeming pleased to find Heidi on the table as requested.

"So what can I do for you today?" he asked, offering Heidi a warm smile as he pulled on a pair of latex gloves.

"Uh...well..." Heidi said, not quite knowing where to start. "I wanted to try it on the edges..."

"Right, so your bikini line?"

"And maybe if it's not too unbearable... some more as well."

"I see. First time, huh? I don't see a problem with that."

"Okay..." Heidi whined, but semi-joking.

"Hey, I've done this thousands of times. Trust me — you'll be okay. So, lie down."

She laughed nervously and lay back flat against the table, squeezing my hand. "Is it going to hurt?" she asked him.

He reached behind, to retrieve something from his counter — a set of electric clippers.

"The way we do it, it's a minimum of discomfort," he said. "Okay, first thing we need to do is trim the hair a little..."

He sprinkled talcum powder over her bush, and flicked on the clippers. "This part might tickle a little."

Then he was running the thing down over her mound, rapidly cutting back her dark hair, and Heidi was looking up at me with a nervous smile, silently telling me how plain crazy this all was.

Heidi was blushing away as he touched her pussy to trim around it, even if he was wearing latex gloves. I found myself wondering how this guy got the job, and at what point he decided that this kind of thing was his vocation.

Even with a simple trim, Heidi looked instantly tidier down there. It wasn't exactly the feminist move, but if Heidi was looking to impress potential lovers in this day and age, she might well have been onto something.

Jerry said, Now, we'll start back here..."

Heidi made another semi-joking nervous whine.

"Okay. I want you to straighten this leg... and bend the other one, and turn onto your side."

He helped position her, then asked her to put one hand around her raised leg, under her knee, and pull it up to really reveal herself to him, and pull her flesh taut.

"It's going to hurt..." she whined quietly.

"No, honey, it's not going to hurt."

"No..."

He turned away from her, briefly, and when he returned, he parted her buttocks and began spreading hot wax over a portion of her behind with a spatula. Then he placed a strip of white cloth over it, paused for next to no time, then said, "You ready?"

He tore off the strip with a sharp tug, before even finishing asking her the question, and Heidi yelped as the thing came off.

Lying there on her side, she was red-faced but laughing about it, and I couldn't tell if it was hurting her, or tickling her, or what.

But then he had her turn over, to lie on her other side, and she did as he asked without seeming to be in agony. Perhaps she was just brave. The process did seem to leave her skin quite pink afterwards.

"Oww!"

Okay, she did cry out as he was pulling the strips off her, but I was impressed. I was also buzzing with that strange energy again, turned on and frightened and totally fascinated. This thing seemed so extreme, but so hot that she was doing it in the name of seducing someone.

Did I wish she'd done this for me when we'd been dating? It would have been interesting. But in some ways, the way I felt now, I wanted her to do this for our little project.

Now he had her lie on her back again, and without any real warning he was smearing the wax onto her, along the edges of her bush, applying the strips of paper and then tearing them off incredibly quickly. She was flinching with each one, but hardly had time to take in what was happening before the next one was done.

"You're doing very well," he said, "Especially for a first timer."

"Very well," I added, squeezing her hand.

She looked up at me, smiling that isn't-it-crazy smile again, trying not to laugh, and said to the guy, "Does it get easier?"

Jerry grinned. "It does. The more you get it done, the more you get used to it."

"Okay..."

"And the hair grows back softer, too. So... here we are. You want to call it quits?"

Heidi looked slightly surprised that he'd finished her bikini line already. She looked at me, and I felt she was looking for someone to lead her, and to let her know it would be okay.

"Go for it," I said, sensing that this was precisely what she wanted me to say.

"Okay..." she nodded, and told Jerry, "Go on. Take the rest. I want to know what it's like."

I looked down at her, surprised. She raised her eyes to mine, silently asking if she was doing the right thing.

I said, "You could leave a small patch... you know... I think that would be hot."

Heidi nodded, and said to Jerry, "You can do that?"

Jerry smiled, "The Brazilian. A very popular choice. Here we go..."

He was so quick, that was what was most unexpected. Dabbing on the wax, quietly stroking on the paper strips, then ripping them away so fast his hands were a blur.

And lying there with her legs apart, less concerned about her modesty now, Heidi looked so different between her thighs — it was really something, even if her skin was all pink. It made her giggle, though, especially as he touched her pussy lips, pulling them this way and that to ensure her flesh was taut for the waxing around there.

I watched Jerry cleaning her and applying moisturizer, and found myself trying to picture him as a lover, his attention lustful and affectionate rather than practical and professional. Trying to quietly determine in I could really handle the sight of some other guy sleeping with Heidi.

Heidi was just breathing and sighing and murmuring, "Oh my God," concerning what had just happened — but she didn't seem to be in any real pain.

"No, it was painful," she said as it came time for her to put her clothes back on, and Jerry left the room. "Only, it didn't really last. Just a couple of seconds while he was pulling the strips off."

As we left, Heidi seemed to have an extra bounce in her step. She was all smiles, seeming elated at what she'd done — and that I'd borne witness to it. Was she teasing me, enjoying showing me what I could have had if I'd stayed with her? But the feeling I got with her was that, if I wanted her, I could have her. Waxed pussy and all. No, it seemed to me that she had enjoyed displaying herself to me, enjoyed having me paying attention to her, especially so intimately.

"Quick drink while we're out?" I asked her.

"That would be nice," she beamed.

"Might take the edge off... you know..."

She laughed. "It's not actually too sore. Well, maybe a little..."

There was a bar just across the road from the salon, and it looked inviting enough. It wasn't too full at that time of night, even though Thursday nights were getting almost as busy as Friday nights in London these days.

"What will you have?" I asked her.

"No, let me get them," she said. "As a thank you."

I chuckled. "I haven't exactly done much..."

She smiled. "You didn't have to come out tonight. And anyway, I've got more to thank you for than just tonight."

I saw a few guys around the bar, not least the bartender, checking out Heidi's top — her nipples were still fairly prominent, and her entire bearing just seemed kind of sexy, and she wasn't even boosted by a push-up bra. I amused myself with the thought that while they were checking out her breasts, I knew what she was now concealing in her jeans.

I was impressed at how Heidi had transformed herself, and it hadn't been that long since she'd first come to me to ask for help.

I took my beer from her, and she settled up with the bartender and grabbed her glass of white wine before we drifted over to an empty table toward the back of the place. I guess I still felt a little uncertain in her company — trying to work out her agenda, I suppose. But as I'd thought, she definitely needed a drink after her salon appointment.

"Sore?" I asked her.

She shrugged. "It's okay. So... where are you taking me on Saturday?"

I smiled. "You know, I was thinking we could try Johnny's again. It was okay in there."

"I liked it."

"It seemed a little more chilled out."

"Chilled out is good."

"We'll find you a nice guy to get your lips around," I said, smiling as though I was cracking a joke, though in reality I was sounding her out — checking that she was still of the inclination that we were looking for her next boyfriend, rather than flirting around the possibility of starting up our own relationship again.

"I do have some new skills to put into practice," she said, playing ball.

"You certainly do," I agreed, and seeing her involuntarily lick her lips reminded me of how good they'd felt around my shaft, made me think how hot it would be to know she was stretching them around some new man's hardness instead.

Heidi took a swig of her wine, then said, "You think I should go further this time? I mean, if I meet the right guy..."

I raised my eyebrows. "You nearly did last time, didn't you? You took the guy home."

"I don't know. I think I intended to... you know... go down on him... but then I thought he'd finish up, maybe we'd call it a night."

"And if he'd insisted on staying?"

"I would've probably let him." She looked at me as though she was sounding me out again, assessing my opinion of her if she'd gone all the way with that guy.

I nodded. "So this time you can invite him to stay, right? If he's the right guy..."

"Is that what you want me to do?" she asked.

I said, "Does it matter what I want you to do?"

"It matters," she nodded.

I took a sip of beer. I felt a touch awkward, I guess. I said, "If you feel you want to spend some more time with him, then invite him to stay. If that seems fun to you."

"I want you to tell me what to do," she said bluntly. "That's what seems fun to me."

"Okay..." I said warily, feeling out this little request she'd made. Was that the penny dropping? Was Heidi revealing her agenda? She wanted me to tell her what to do. Did she expect me to tell her to sleep with me?

How far was she going to go with this?

If she wanted me to tell her what to do... then I felt like I needed to test her. I didn't want her thinking that we were back together. I was still primarily aiming to get her laid, to boost her self-confidence, to help her move on from what had happened to us. If I got sexual satisfaction from seeing her transformation, watching her hooking up with guys, knowing she was sleeping with someone else, perhaps someone she would call boyfriend after a few dates... well, that was my own reward for helping her.

"Okay," I said again. "What I want... first of all... is to get you laid."

"Okay," she nodded, a touch nervous now, but apparently delighted I was telling her what I wanted.

"I want you to find a guy you like at Johnny's, and when you feel up to it, invite him back to your place."

"Sure."

"And if you still like him... I want you to show him a good time."

I was blushing a little and hid my face with my glass of beer for a moment or two as it sank in what I'd told her.

Only, she didn't shoot it down. She said, "Show him a good time?"

I sighed, and glanced around the bar to make sure we weren't overheard by any eavesdroppers. Then I said under my breath, "I want you to sleep with him, okay?"

She giggled. "Sleep with him?"

Another sigh from yours truly. She was winding me up, but it was kind of hot to be telling her what I wanted her to do. I took the bait, and said, "Okay... I want you to take him into your bedroom, and slowly strip for him... show him your sexy underwear... show him how incredible you look after your little visit to the salon... "

"Uh-huh?" her cheeks were a little flushed, but she was lapping up what I was telling her.

"Then you drop to your knees and go down on him," I said, taking another sip of beer as though I needed it to cool me down. "But you don't take him all the way... then assuming he still wants to..."

"Yes?"

"Let him fuck you."

Heidi was blushing like a schoolgirl now, but she'd pushed me to say what I'd just said. After a brief hesitation to let it sink in, she looked me in the eyes and said, "Okay, I can do that. Sure." Accepting the challenge, assured in her ability to match up to the demand.

She added, "And what then? What happens once I've fucked him?"

The f-word seemed so wrong, and yet so exciting in her mouth. We were talking about some other guy actually sliding his big, hard cock inside her freshly-waxed pussy. So bizarre, but so hot.

"What would you want to do?"

"Oh no," she shook her head. "You tell me, remember? What should I do after I've fucked him?"

"You could..." I said, as pondered the issue. I wanted her to have a good time. I wanted her to find a boyfriend. How could I know what she should do after they'd fucked?

But she interrupted, "Not 'could'. Tell me what I do after he's finished fucking me. What you want me to do — not what you think I want to do."

I looked at her sitting across the table from me, her small breasts squeezed into that top, her nipples showing through as though this was some wet t-shirt contest and she'd had water tipped all down her front. I looked at her, and thought about her fucking some other guy at her apartment, with that beautifully smooth pussy of hers...

And I said, "Once you've finished with him, you need to ask him to leave. Then you take a taxi to my place and tell me exactly what happened."

I saw a faint smile flicker across her face in the moment before she remembered to hide her emotions from me. As though she'd been silently delighted at me for such an order. Because I still wanted to be involved in this strange new dating game of hers, even once she'd actually slept with another guy.

"I can do that," she said. "What if... you know... things don't go so well?"

"Then you come tell me anyway," I said. She was happy at that, too, though she did her best to conceal her reaction. "But I think if you get him home with you, he's not going to hold out on you."

She nodded.

"It might get kinda late," she warned me. "If I have time to shower, change..."

I shook my head. Felt the power. If I was telling her what to do, then I wanted to revel in the depravity of my telling her to fuck another man. "No. You're to put your clothes back on and come straight over to me," I said. "I want to see you as he leaves you."

"Oh, okay," she said, and I got the impression she'd taken my hidden agenda to be something slightly different.

"You can shower at my place if you like," I said.

"I'll do whatever you want me to do."

The way she said that made it seem that this was her bottom line requirement, her overall agenda: to make me own her, to make herself my possession, even if we hadn't said we were going out, and I certainly hadn't labeled her my girlfriend.

I looked at her for a long moment, underlining the seriousness of what she'd just said. I said, "Whatever I want you to do? You mean on Saturday, at the end of the night... or generally?"

She paused, considering what I was asking, and what she was saying. Then she said, "Generally."

I breathed in, slowly, deeply, still looking in her eyes. "What right do I have to tell you what to do?"

"Maybe I'd like it if you had the right," she said, seeming gravely serious, yet avoiding telling me anything involving me once being her husband. It was as though she'd thought about this at length.

I nodded, thoughtfully, and took a sip of beer. My manhood was thickening up in my pants but rationally I felt such a response was irresponsible. In my heart I was curious to see what it would be like to possess Heidi, but in my head I was still concerned it would lead to the kind of relationship we'd had before — Heidi miserable and me tired of her.

Hardly very gallant — in my eyes, I wasn't the right person to be handed the responsibility to tell her what to do.

I said, "Objectively, I don't believe I'm the right person for you, Heidi. I don't believe we should get back together. You can do better than me."

She said, quietly, "You might not be the right person for me, but we wouldn't be getting back together. Not unless you decided we were."

"In my eyes, your best bet for happiness would be for me to help you find Mr Right."

She nodded. "And you can do that if you want to," she said. "I will do whatever you want me to do."

Another contemplative nod. I said, "Heidi, if you keep doing whatever I want to do... well, let's just say there's a danger that my own personal agenda might... get in the way."

"Your own personal agenda?"

"I may not like a guy who is actually your Mr Right. Ultimately, you should decide independently."

She said, "If you don't like a guy and you tell me that, then I stop seeing him."

I sighed. "You see... that kind of sets you up... as mine. My possession."

She nodded. "Perhaps."

"But I've said, I don't think we should get back together. You need somebody else."

"We don't have to get back together," Heidi said again, and I guessed that society's idea of a man possessing a woman was basically marriage, or at least a very paternalistic version of marriage — but what Heidi was saying was that it didn't need to be a form of marriage. "If you wanted me to have someone else, I would have someone else."

"But what, I'd supersede him?" I said, not quite believing what she was getting at.

"Always," she said.

I raised an eyebrow. "And on your wedding day, if I tell you to sleep with the best man...?"

"I'd sleep with the best man," she said.

Somehow, I was getting a little intimidated by her zeal. Heidi wasn't being a stalker ex, she was being something else entirely. Obsessed.

I said, "And if I told you never to see me again, if I told you I was no longer... going to tell you what to do?"

"Then I'd never see you again," she said. "And you'd never tell me what to do again."

I sighed, held my head in my hands, elbows on the table in front of me. I said, "Heidi... I'm sure I'm not the right person for this. What if you met someone better, someone who really could... tell you what to do... and do what's right for you?"

She laughed. "It would depend if you wanted me to see him."

"I'm selfish," I said. "I'm self-centered. I'd tell you to do things... because they make me feel good, not because they make you feel good."

"I want to make you feel good," she said. How had I ever earned this kind of devotion? Our relationship had been a flop, in any sense of the word. And right now she was looking at me as though I was the leader of some mesmerizing cult. "More than anything."

I went for another sip of beer and my glass was empty.

I pulled on my jacket, and made it clear it was time to leave. "We'd better call it a night," I said, and naturally Heidi nodded her agreement, and pulled on her own coat. She looked a touch disappointed, perhaps that I hadn't definitively agreed to be this dominant figure for her.

I said, "Heidi, if we do this..."

Her eyes seemed to light up, her face filled with hope. "Yes?"

"I want you to have the power of final veto."

"Final veto?"

"If anything happens that makes you uncomfortable, for whatever reason... if I do ask you to sleep with the best man on your wedding night and you desperately don't want to betray your new husband... you give me some kind of agreed signal."

"Signal? Like, a safe word?"

"A safe word," I nodded. "And we stop, no questions asked."

"Okay," she agreed, buttoning her coat. "And what would the safe word be?"

I paused, trying to think of some word that wouldn't be used accidentally between us. "Existential," I said. "You say it, and everything

stops. We re-group."

"Fine. Only, you know what? The wedding thing... I wouldn't use a safe word in that situation."

"No?" I laughed.

She smiled. "But if I was marrying someone... I probably wouldn't want to keep secrets from them."

"Right."

"So he'd have to know that even though he was marrying me, you still had control over me."

I raised my eyebrows at that. "You know how crazy you sound?" She laughed at that.

Outside, we grabbed a taxi, and I had the driver drop Heidi off at her place before taking me on to mine. As I got home, it wasn't all that late. I nodded a quick hello to my two roommates camped out on the living room couch on my way through to my room, but then I ended up collapsing on my bed, ready for sleep.

I just kept thinking about Heidi's desire to submit to me, of all people, wondering whether it was really a good idea. That dark, hidden part of me that had struck up the fantasy of having Heidi debauch herself and then shower me with all the details... that part of me loved the idea of possessing her. Oh how much I would enjoy having her sleep with other men, then later relive the experience for my benefit, recounting all the minutia of her pleasure.

And as I settled down for the night, and switched out the light, I did find myself imagining how it might be if she did meet her Mr Right, her Perfect Prince Charming, and after they fully consummated their relationship, I demanded to sleep with Heidi myself. She would probably enjoy it, I surmised. I got the feeling she didn't just want me to dominate her, but to pay attention to her physically.

I had to admit, if this was something Heidi wanted so badly, it might be fun to try it.

I was beginning to believe that if we did this, there could be no return to the way our relationship was.

Chapter Eight

Saturday. I arrived at Heidi's place at 6:30pm, looking respectable in a blue shirt and dark pants.

"I thought you were picking me up at seven," she said as she opened her door to me.

She was wearing a tight white t-shirt and some small shorts that looked like men's boxers, and though she seemed to have only recently tumbled out of bed, there was a poise to her body that gave her a grace that hadn't been there while we'd been dating. Almost like a ballet dancer, though I knew Heidi had never taken ballet.

"Still in your PJs?" I chuckled as she stepped back to invite me in.

"I wasn't doing much today," she protested. "Just practicing. I don't need to put on clothes to play the cello."

"I suppose not."

"And anyway, I wasn't expecting you this early."

"Just keeping you on your toes," I smirked.

In reality, I'd spent Saturday doing even less than Heidi — a lie-in, a late breakfast at the cafe just down the street from my apartment, then knocking around my place watching football. I'd been counting the minutes until it was time to take Heidi out for another round of our little adventure, and when it got to six I'd figured it couldn't harm to get to her place early.

"Roommates around?" I asked as I followed her through her apartment to her room.

"Monica's in Paris with her boyfriend and Sally's surfing in Cornwall."

"Wow. Cue the life envy," I said.

Heidi peeled off her t-shirt and said, "I don't know... I'm quite enjoying my life right now."

She wasn't wearing a bra underneath. Her small breasts were pert, her pink nipples hard, noticeable in a way they'd never been when we were together. Something in the way she stood, in the way she stepped around her bedroom — a more arched back, perhaps, but that wasn't all of it — just emphasized her femininity in a way that gave her a completely different look somehow, even though she hadn't prepared herself for going out yet.

That poise — it was confidence, I realized, as she draped her t-shirt over her small wooden desk chair, flicked her long hair out of the way of her face, then slipped off her shorts to leave herself completely nude.

"You don't mind waiting while I shower?" she asked.

She was proud of herself, proud of her body, proud of the way I looked at her, and it reflected in a new beauty that she projected without need of make-up or perfume or fancy clothes.

"Of course not," I said. "Keep you company?"

She grabbed a towel and smiled, "That's up to you, isn't it?"

I tried to keep my eyes on hers, but damn she looked good. And there was the breathtaking sight of her pussy, looking immaculate with its tiny patch of dark hair, all the redness from Thursday's waxing session gone, leaving only smooth, clear skin around her sex.

"Come on," I said. She led me to the bathroom, handed me her towel with another little sweet smile, then stepped into the shower to grab the shower head and run the water until the temperature was just right.

"So how've you been?" I asked her as she started running the water all over her body, giving me a nice show as she did so.

"Not so bad," she smiled.

"You're still enjoying playing with the Philharmonic, then?" I was silently impressed with my multi-tasking, holding a conversation with her while I watched her hands sweep all over her curves, soaping her arms, her breasts, her stomach, her behind, her thighs, between her legs.

"Uh-huh. And I've started giving lessons to a few kids in Holland Park."

"Holland Park? Nice." She laughed, "There's a rumor going around the orchestra that I had a boob job."

That made me laugh, too. "Seriously?"

"I know, right?" she arched her back and pushed out her breasts as much as she could. They were perfect for her, and with her new confidence, sexy as hell. But not really the kind of breasts someone would get cosmetic surgery to own.

"You okay about it?" I asked her. "I mean, you know who's been saying it, you could probably lodge a complaint, right? Sexual harassment, wouldn't you say?"

She shrugged. "I don't really mind it. I think it's because... I don't know... I've been feeling better about myself recently."

"Well, that's good."

She grinned, "I think I kind of like the guys... you know... checking me out to see if I have had a boob job."

"Even the guys in the orchestra?" I laughed.

"Some of them are okay. And I don't need to feel like I can sleep with them to enjoy it when they notice me."

I felt a nice, warm sensation in my chest — I was improving Heidi's life, all this was having an effect beyond the nights out and all the making out with strangers on the dance floor.

"Well, that's great," I said, watching her washing her hair, enjoying the free rein my eyes had all over her bare body.

"I went shopping for a few clothes on Thursday night," she said, working the conditioner into her hair. "Well, more than a few clothes."

"Thursday? After we had drinks?"

"The Westfield's open until ten." She began rinsing — her hair, her body. "I suppose... after my appointment... and a glass of wine... I was feeling good about myself."

"So you should," I said.

Heidi lifted one foot, her toes holding it still on a crack between tiles on the wall, and for a moment gave me a stunning view of her freshly-waxed pussy. I was strongly tempted just to kneel down before her and worship it, and to hell with my clothes getting wet in the shower. Then she was stroking it under the pretense of rinsing it in the shower, feeling once again just how different it was to the Old Heidi.

"On Friday I wore this tight top to orchestra... and a skirt that only came down above my knees," she laughed. "Even the conductor was checking me out."

She shut off the water and stepped out of the shower, and I handed her the towel. I liked this new Heidi. And I liked to think that she wanted

me to possess her, even while showing herself off to guys in the orchestra — and dressing up to meet strangers in nightclubs.

"Are you going to pick out something for me to wear?" she asked, making me envious of that towel for a moment or two.

"Sure," I said, realizing that my lack of expertise in being a dominant male was probably showing. I stepped out of the bathroom and headed back to her room, hearing her start up a hairdryer now that I was gone.

In her bedroom, I opened a few drawers and her wardrobe to get the lay of the land, and found a whole host of tops, dresses, shoes and underwear I didn't recognize. Hot stuff, too. Heidi had gone out to get herself a whole new look.

There were two magazines on her bedside table, Cosmopolitan and Glamour. I picked one up and was flicking through it, and it struck me how unlike the Heidi I'd dated this kind of thing was. "16 Genius NASCAR Tips From Michelle Keegan". "The 5 Best Matte Foundations". "Kylie Jenner Has A New Hairstyle". "Places You Never Thought of Wearing Your Perfume". "11 Things Every Eyebrow Obsessive Knows To Be True". Numbers were a big thing for magazine headlines.

"I told you I was doing research, didn't I?" Heidi said as she came back from the bathroom wearing her towel, her hair now dry and brushed.

"You mentioned something."

"Found something for me to wear?" she closed the bedroom door and hung the towel up on the hook behind it, leaving herself completely bare again.

"Uh... not yet."

Tearing my eyes away from those stiff little nipples of hers, I opened her underwear drawer and sifted through some of the contents. Did she have any of her old-style underwear still? All her panties appeared to be thongs or g-strings.

I handed her something small, black and white, which had a lot of loose black strings it seemed to me. Heidi took it, stepped into it and pulled it up her legs, and into position. A g-string in black satin and white lace. She had to tie black strings together over her hips, which I was guessing made it easy to remove. There was only a tiny triangle of material covering her pussy, and almost nothing in back.

I found her a matching bra easily enough, and some high-heeled black shoes in the bottom of the wardrobe. Finding a suitable dress

wasn't quite so easy, since a few I picked out for her made her underwear visible underneath.

At last, we had a viable contender, a black dress with white up the sides, very short on her thighs and offering a nice view of cleavage. After a little consideration, Heidi decided to put on some black nylons, and the whole effect made her look seriously sexy.

"What do you think?" she smiled, giving me a twirl.

"You look stunning," I said, sitting on the edge of the mattress. She looked thrilled at my response. Then I said, "You are getting laid tonight, young lady."

Heidi blushed furiously, but at the same time she was all giddy with excitement. I was throbbing between my thighs just to think of her actually going through with it, actually sleeping with someone.

She gazed at herself in the mirror and did another twirl, lifting the hem of her dress to expose her underwear — for me, it seemed.

"You feel ready?" I asked.

"Uh-huh," she smiled at me via the mirror. "I've been practicing."

That made me feel warm inside. "You got my present, then?"

"Uh-huh. On Tuesday evening," she giggled. "Nearly opened it right in front of my roommates — until I remembered you'd said you'd send something."

I parted my legs as I sat there on the edge of the bed, and said, "Care for one last practice before we head out?"

Heidi turned and stepped my way, then sank to her knees in front of me, her hands moving to the bulge in my pants. I kept my own hands by my side, giving her access, letting her do as she pleased. She pulled open my belt, my fly, freed my hardness, her face brightening to see how aroused I was.

She lifted my stiff shaft with a single finger and began to lick slowly from base to tip.

"I think I'm getting better," she said, stroking the head of my cock with her lower lip, flicking her tongue around it. She moaned quietly, then slipped my tip inside her hot mouth.

I groaned as she sank slowly down on my hard cock, stroking me with her lips, pressing her tongue against my length, sucking on me gently.

"Mind you don't mess up your make-up," I warned her as she traced the tip of my cock over her velvet cheeks.

"I don't care," she smiled, "I can always reapply it."

As she slid my cock inside her mouth, then withdrew to explore it with little licks and kisses, it seemed to me that she was enjoying herself much more than she ever had when her technique was so brutal. This was no longer some desperate attempt to satisfy a guy, it was more like teasing me, reveling in her chance to play with my cock, to hold it, to feel it, to taste it.

And the look in her eye seemed to suggest to me that later tonight this was exactly how she'd be treating some other guy.

Chapter Nine

Johnny's seemed kind of familiar to us now, though it was only our second time there. The crowd seemed slightly easier to deal with, the music somehow wasn't quite as harsh.

Heidi was eager to get going, and I soon found myself alone at the bar, watching her take to the dance floor and the way she looked in that dress had all the single guys in the place gravitating her way. She was soon having a whale of a time, teasing the men around her before finally choosing one to dance with, her confidence blooming, her desirability surging with every smile, every flash of her eyes, every jink of her hips.

I saw her dancing with two guys, and pressing herself up to them as she did so, before she seemed to settle on a third. It struck me how quickly and how completely Heidi had changed, blossoming into a first rate flirt, a knock-out tease.

The man she settled with was tall, dark-haired, a little pale but suitably handsome. He made me realize that the Heidi who had shown up on my doorstep asking for help to move on from our marriage would never have been brave enough to approach someone like this. And now she was pressing herself up to him, holding him, touching him, laughing at the jokes he told to try to impress her — flirting like crazy.

I was hard as a board watching her. Thinking all the time: was this the man to sleep with her? The first man to do so since we'd gotten married. Was I bothered by the thought of losing her to him? I'm not sure. I was more interested in the lust I felt, the thought of Heidi being so

wicked, sleeping with a stranger — and how it might be when she came back to me afterward.

"Well, hello again."

I turned on hearing a familiar voice, and there was Bella, the blonde girl who had watched Heidi and I kissing the last time we'd come to Johnny's. I had been teaching Heidi how to kiss, and when Heidi went to the restrooms to get ready to go back out on the dance floor, Bella had slipped a scrap of paper with her name and number on it into my pocket.

"Hello," I said warily.

"You never called me," she said, not seeming particularly angry at me. Mildly surprised, perhaps.

"No, I didn't."

She gave me a curt nod. "So you're here with the brunette again," she said, glancing over at the dance floor. "But she's making out with someone else on the dance floor."

"Uh-huh." I was kind of amused that this blonde was somehow taking an interest, but I wasn't entirely sure about her agenda. Was she out to ridicule me, or merely interested in what was going on between Heidi and me?

Clutching a champagne flute filled with a greenish opalescent cocktail, which looked like a failed chemistry experiment, she appeared to be a few years younger than Heidi and myself. Early twenties, perhaps. And yet the sharp intelligence in her voice, in her dazzling blue eyes, seemed to add a year or two.

"And you like to watch, is that it?"

I gave a nonchalant shrug, wanting a little more time to decipher her angle.

She said, "Let me guess, you're either some kind of gay best friend trying to get her laid, or... you're a kinky guy itching for a threesome."

I laughed at that.

"And the way you were kissing her last time... there's no way you're gay. Bisexual, maybe, a little. But not gay."

"No," I smiled.

"So what is it?"

She put a hand on her hip, which seemed like some kind of semi-unconscious attempt to get me to look at her figure in that dress. She was wearing a white dress with gold trim that clung to her body and drew the eye easily over her slender curves. Daring, sexy, but it made me wonder what Heidi would look like wearing it.

"You're hoping for a threesome with another guy?"

"Nope."

"Don't tell me you're some kind of platonic straight best friend happy to sit back while she flirts with other guys."

I laughed again. I kind of liked driving her crazy. There was something appealing about not giving her what she wanted, teasing her because she was so attractive she was probably used to always getting what she desired.

"I'm not sure I'd say platonic," I said.

"So you are with her?" she asked. "What, you're poly?"

I shrugged.

"But guys in polyamorous relationships don't watch their girlfriends dance with other guys."

"I wouldn't know."

"I've been watching you," she said.

"Training to be a stalker?"

She smiled. "I just want to work you out. You obviously enjoy watching her when she's dancing with other guys."

Another shrug from yours truly. Although, it was more to tease her now, because I could sense a frisson of excitement in her that suggested she was interested in what Heidi and I had going on, and not that she wanted to expose me and humiliate me.

"And would that be a problem, if I like watching?"

There was a flicker of delight in her eyes, that she was working me out.

"When you watch her, how far does she take it?"

"As far as she wants."

"And if it was up to you? Would you let her go home with somebody?"

"Of course."

She seemed to catch her breath at that, though attempting to conceal her reaction from me. "Impressive," she said. "But if she goes home with somebody... you can't watch her any more, can you?"

"No."

"So what's the appeal?"

I turned to signal to the bartender for another drink — or at least, to wait for a bartender to serve me — and was surprised that the guy was suddenly there. I took it as a fringe benefit of talking to a highly attractive blonde.

"What're you drinking?" I asked Bella.

"Death in the Afternoon."

"Charming," I said, then to the bartender, "Two of those, please."

When I turned back to Bella, she said, "Why would a guy just let his girlfriend go home with some other guy?"

I said, "Firstly, she's not really my girlfriend. More like an ex."

"An ex with benefits. But you get off on watching her with other men. And you actively want her to go off and sleep with someone else."

The bartender handed over our drinks, and I handed him my credit card before passing one of the powerful concoctions to Bella. When I took a sip of my own, its strength took me a little by surprise.

"Uh... what's in this?" I wheezed.

Bella smiled. "Absinthe and Champagne. So what's in it for you, if she sleeps with someone else?"

I tried another sip of the cocktail. I'd never been a huge absinthe fan. Come to think of it, I'd never been particularly enamored of Champagne, either, but it gave me a moment or two to think of what to say to her.

I said, "Well okay, Veronica Mars... What's in it for me?... It's seeing her all aflutter because some guy wants to sleep with her."

Bella raised one of her eyebrows. "But you don't figure that seeing her all aflutter because you wanted to sleep with her is enough?"

I chuckled. "You know," I said, feeling a little more chilled out about explaining everything to her now that the absinthe was warming me up inside, "we were married once."

"Seriously?"

"For a few months. It didn't work out. I don't think she gets quite the same flutters from me wanting to sleep with her."

"I don't know, the way she looks at you," Bella said.

I shrugged. "It's not the same look I see when she's flirting with someone else. Wanting someone else."

"Doesn't it hurt a little, too?"

"I don't know. Maybe a little. Only as much as this cocktail hurts. But then you get to experience the sweetness of her having so much fun, of her being so excited."

"And after she's slept with him?"

"I don't know..." I said, not entirely knowing how to describe what I felt. "It only makes me more interested in her."

Bella's eyes flashed. "Wow. I thought guys all wanted women to be virgins, purer than pure."

"I guess not all of us."

The pretty blonde gazed at me for a moment, then nodded. Something distracted her, put her off. She said, "I guess I'll be seeing you

round, then. Thanks for the drink."

"Sure, no problem."

She managed to avoid looking as though she was fleeing the scene, as though this was the natural end of our brief conversation. But then Heidi was returning to me from the dance floor, looking a touch flushed with a hint of perspiration on her brow — a good look for her, it seemed to me.

"Hey," she said.

"Taking a break?"

"Patrick needs a cigarette."

I nodded at that. "Cigarette, huh?" Not Heidi's usual kind of guy, I thought.

"Who was that you were talking to?" Heidi asked me, but there wasn't really jealousy in her voice, as far as I could tell.

"Bella," I said, not feeling like I had anything really to hide. "I ran into her last time we were here."

"You like her?" Heidi asked, and again, somehow didn't seem put out that I might.

I said, "She's nice enough."

Heidi nodded. It seemed faintly interesting to me that she would assume I might be on the lookout for another woman. But then as far as she was concerned, we weren't really an item, though she was professing to have me control her social life. She was free to see other guys, I guess in her mind I was free to see other women.

"You should ask her out," Heidi smiled. "She's pretty."

I shrugged and handed Heidi a margarita. "Not really my type. So anyway, Patrick."

"Yes, Patrick." She grinned, like a giddy schoolgirl.

"You like him?"

"Mmm-hmm."

"What were you guys getting up to?"

She shrugged nervously. "A little kissing... some touching..."

"You want to take him home?"

"If you want me to," she said, perfectly submissive, though apparently hopeful I might grant her this Patrick.

"But does he... turn you on?"

She looked at me in the eye, then gave a curt nod. Then she glanced this way and that as though checking we weren't being watched, grabbed my hand, and slid it up the inside of her thighs, under her dress. Her panties were soaking. I tucked a finger or two under the satin and lace,

feeling out the warm, the softness of her flesh and the slickness of her wetness.

"He touched you here?" I said. The sense of risk at touching her like this, right by the bar — in public even though nobody was looking down so that they might see — only made my hard cock throb all the more, and seemed to quicken her breathing by the by.

"Uh-huh," she said, letting out a small moan as a finger of mine slipped inside her.

"Time in the salon wasn't wasted then?"

She smiled. "He already suggested that we go somewhere," she said. "I said I'd think about it."

I nodded. "Okay, so when he comes back from his cigarette break, you tell him he can take you home if he wants."

There were flames in Heidi's eyes. She knew this was another step for us. This was her sleeping with another guy, not merely making out on the dance floor with him. Not merely going down on him.

"Okay."

"Be careful," I told her.

"I will."

"If it doesn't turn out the way you hoped, you don't have to sleep with him."

"I know."

"If you get in any trouble, call me. If you can't call, text."

"Okay."

"And if you're in an emergency situation and you don't have time to write a whole word to text me, just send me a single character."

Suddenly, after all this, I was nervous at the risks Heidi was taking in sleeping with a stranger.

"I'll be okay," she said, but I could tell she was pleased with my hint of concern.

"Good."

She glanced toward the entrance of the club, and we both saw Patrick coming back in, heading toward her last position.

"And afterwards?" she asked me. "After it's happened?"

I felt my stomach squeezed by the nerves, the excitement of the prospect of Heidi — my Heidi — going through with this, actually fucking this man, Patrick.

I said, "You can come tell me how it went if you like."

She smiled, nodded, but then had to distance herself from me, make it look as though we didn't know each other, as if we hadn't been talking

to each other while Patrick had been away. She was just waiting for him, and she'd gotten herself another drink to keep company while he'd been away.

"Hi," he said, stepping up to her right in front of me. Jesus, I could smell his cologne.

"Hey," she smiled, completely blanking me now, Patrick none the wiser that she knew me. She stepped up and slung an arm around his neck before kissing him right there a few feet from me, conspicuously sliding her tongue into his mouth as she did so.

"Are we stopping for another drink?" Patrick asked her, glancing at her half-drunk cocktail.

Heidi flashed him a coquettish smile, and said, "I've had enough to drink, don't you think? I was rather hoping you'd take me home."

"Whatever the lady desires," Patrick returned her smile and took her arm in his. Then they were walking away, fetching their coats at the cloakroom, leaving the club — and I was stunned by it, though the sight of her so clearly thrilled by snagging him left me rock hard between the thighs.

I took a sip of my own drink and tried to breathe deeply, to calm down my racing heart.

"So that's it, huh?"

A familiar voice next to me again. Bella.

"You just watch them walk off into the sunset, right?"

"Uh-huh," I nodded.

"And she's going to sleep with him?"

"I would say so."

"And what happens after that?" There was a twinkle in her eyes — she was stirred by the idea of me actively allowing Heidi, my Heidi, to go off and fuck Patrick. By the reality of it actually happening.

"You never slept with anybody before?" I asked, joked.

"But the way she looks at you," Bella said. "She's hoping to sleep with you, afterwards, right?"

"Is it any of your business?"

She took another sip of that lethal absinthe cocktail of hers and slumped down on the barstool next to me. I wondered how many she'd had tonight. There had to be an easy risk of overdose. "Probably not," she said, "but it's pretty interesting if it's true."

I laughed. "Don't tell me you write for the Daily Mail?"

"No, I'm just a student."

I was surprised by that. She was precocious for a student. Perhaps she was a postgrad.

"So if you're poly," she said, turning to me and crossing her legs to offer me a wonderful view up her dress, "do you get to see other girls?"

"I have no need," I said. Okay, she was attractive — very much so. But just then I really didn't need the complication of a date coming along for the ride. I wanted Heidi, or at least Heidi after she'd had her fun with Patrick.

"Doesn't seem fair," Bella said, jostling her foot a little, as though subtly trying to get me to notice her shapely legs.

"I just don't need anyone else right now," I shrugged.

"She's lucky. But I think if it was me... I probably wouldn't want you to see other girls."

"But you want to sleep with me, knowing I'm sleeping with her?" I said, the alcohol making me so bold to jump to that conclusion.

Bella actually blushed. It was a good look on her, but I was willing to bet not something that happened very often.

"Maybe I'm just interested in trying something... a little more open-minded," she said, trying to regain her composure. I was thinking about how Heidi had actually suggested that I ask Bella out, that I date her. How would she react if she turned up at my apartment to find me with her?

I couldn't guarantee how Heidi would really react. And right now, I didn't want to spoil a good thing. Bella was too much of a distraction.

"I'm sorry I can't really help you," I said to her.

She gave a single nod. "Too bad."

I glanced at my phone. It was getting on for midnight — not an embarrassing time to leave a nightclub alone.

Bella said, "Your brunette..."

"Heidi?"

"What if she really likes him? If she wants to see him again?"

I shrugged.

"Aren't you worried you'll lose her to him?"

"Not really."

"Because you think she could never run off with someone else? Because you let her see other guys, and he wouldn't."

"I want her to find someone else."

"You want to lose her?"

I smiled. "We're not right for each other. I told you, didn't I? Someone else will be better for her."

"Better than you letting her sleep around? Seriously?"

"If this is what she wants... well..."

Bella said, "What if she falls in love with somebody else?"

I sipped my drink. "That would be the whole aim of all this."

"And you'd still want to sleep with her?"

"That would depend on her. On the guy she was with, I suppose."

"But you'd really want it that way, if you had the choice?"

"I think so."

"Seriously. Wow. Kind of intense."

I chuckled. "You should try it."

She nodded. "I should."

"Probably even more intense if she's really into the guy," I said, joking really, because when you thought about it, this whole situation was just a touch bizarre. "Instead of just having random flings."

Bella nodded. "Where does she work? You should get her to ask out a colleague," she said. "That might give you something more than a fling."

I thought of Heidi instantly dismissing the blond guy who had first approached us here when we'd started out, refusing to consider him because he was part of the orchestra.

"She plays for the Philharmonic," I said.

"So get her to ask out the fit clarinet player."

"Clarinet?"

Bella laughed. "There's always a fit clarinet player, isn't there?" Then she was stepping back from me, indicating that it was time for her to leave.

"Well... see you around," I said.

She smiled. "I have to find my own bed for the night... if yours'll be occupied later..."

The pretty blonde adjusted her dress right in front of me, tugging on the neckline so more of her cleavage was on display — as though she needed to do such a thing to attract any guy. I couldn't quite believe I was passing up the opportunity to take her home with me. Yet since Heidi had set us on this strange path, even this gorgeous blonde student was unable to quite meet the appeal of my lowly ex seducing another man before returning to me to share the details.

I watched Bella disappear back into the crowd on the dance floor, and found that if I thought of her as mine, as someone I should be with, and now she was going out to find someone else... well, it did make her seem more interesting, somehow. I guess I was just messed up in the

head. There was just something stunningly desirable about a sexually active woman — a promiscuous woman.

Slowly I sauntered out of the nightclub, glancing at the clock above the cloakroom as I grabbed my coat. Was Heidi home already? The journey in a taxi wouldn't take long. Perhaps she was already making out with Patrick. Taking him to her bed.

On the way back to my place I was in a constant state of arousal. Buzzing about what was going on. Letting myself into my apartment was as easy as tapping a code into a keypad next to my front door, but I fumbled with it twice, nearly locked myself out. Waiting shouldn't have been anxious for me. Heidi wasn't mine any more, I'd given her up — and I'd been at peace with that. I had no intention of taking her back, and every intention that she should find someone better than me with whom to settle down.

And yet I so wanted to see her defiled and enjoy witnessing her afterwards. I was nervous that tonight's encounter with Patrick would go too well and that she wouldn't come back to me once he was done.

At a little past 1am, I found myself at my computer, scrolling through digital photos I'd taken while Heidi and I had been together — mostly from the early stages of our relationship, since toward the latter stages I'd apparently lost interest in taking pictures. She did look happy when we'd first been together. So had I, come to think of it.

Seeing her back then, when we'd first started dating, it was remarkable how much more attractive she was, how the prettiness of her face was more apparent when she was happy, smiling, laughing. Suddenly I felt myself becoming more possessive of her and the dull throb at the bottom of my chest, which I'd hardly realized was there, abruptly intensified.

Along with the general state of arousal, I was suddenly feeling pain at the thought of my Heidi being taken by another man. It was very odd.

Perhaps it was only so apparent because I was under-occupied, merely waiting around, and in the meantime I hadn't heard back from her.

It was half past one when my phone buzzed to announce a text message. I scrambled to pull it out of my pocket, and there was something from Heidi.

>Put my training into practice. Think he enjoyed it. Maybe a little too much ;-)

My semi-erect cock jumped into full hardness at the mental image of Heidi going down on her new lover, particularly since I'd been so

involved in attempting to improve her technique. But had she merely gone down on him? Her text was too vague.

I replied:

>Where are you? Still with him?

Heidi's reply came quickly:

>He's returning the favor, you might say. I guess it means he appreciates my salon visit :-P

I felt my hardness throbbing as I thought of her lying there, a stranger between her thighs, lapping away at her beautifully groomed pussy.

>Does he know you're texting me right now?

>Thinks I'm texting a girl friend to let her know I'm okay. He's a little too busy to worry anyway.

She wasn't going to be able to text me for much longer, though, if she was only meant to be telling her girl friend she was safe and sound.

I sent her one last text:

>Hope you're having a great time. Come see me after, if you want.

And she replied:

>Definitely xx

*

For a few moments I contemplated taking a cold shower, if only to attempt to calm down, and dislodge the image of Heidi lying there with another man eating her out.

Then my phone buzzed again, and this time it wasn't just a text message. Heidi was calling me.

"Hey."

I picked it up with a hint of trepidation. What if Patrick had busted her? If he'd read her texts, knew she was texting a guy friend, not a girl friend, perhaps it angered him. I pressed the green button onscreen to accept the call — but then simply put the phone to my ear to wait and see what the deal was.

There was no "hello" on the other end. No one said anything, neither Patrick nor Heidi. I only heard what I thought to be someone breathing.

It took me a moment or two to figure out what I was hearing.

Two people were breathing heavily, sighing, quietly moaning. After a while I could recognize Heidi. There were the wet sounds of kissing, the silky sweep of skin moving against skin.

Heidi was letting me listen to him as he took her.

I was rock hard to realize it.

Difficult to picture exactly how they were, but I heard Heidi catch her breath, and then the tone of her moans, the slight hitch in her sighs, told me that he was inside her. He was fucking her.

The sound of him thrusting into her, and of Heidi and Patrick moaning at the sensations sweeping over them, quickly grew to the point that there could be no doubt he was fucking her. A stranger was fucking my Heidi. Her moans were more like cries — and though it was a trifle cutting for me to hear her with another man, it was such a turn-on and I received a warm feeling inside that seemed to stem from knowing I was allowing her this wonderful experience.

It was so hot to hear her. Heidi, who had always been a good girl, fucking some other guy. I felt a strong urge to go to her, to steal her away, to take her for myself.

How incredible to hear her. After a while, the sounds changed, in rhythm and pitch, she was moaning more leisurely as he fucked her more slowly, presumably in some other position. They were kissing again, breathlessly — and that seemed to hurt me more than the knowledge

they were fucking. There was something more intimate in the kissing, somehow. Fucking was just fucking, detached from affection. I had to stop myself feeling that way, consciously. It was good for her to be affectionate with him. Perhaps she wanted to date him, perhaps he was a keeper.

She was panting and moaning now, her moans more like gasps. Then it stopped, and I knew they were changing position. When it restarted I could hear the quiet thudding of his body hitting hers, as he pounded into her again and again.

I don't know how long they lasted. Forever and a day, it seemed like. Patrick clearly had stamina. I stroked my own hardness through my pants as my focus latched onto a picture of Heidi on my computer screen, while listening to someone else thrusting his cock into her.

I nearly lost it when her cries rose to an undoubted climax and Patrick was groaning and grunting, almost certainly coming powerfully before their moans subsided, tailing off into mere heavy breathing again. Heavy breathing and kisses.

They were kissing, and they were lying together, and I felt a surge of jealousy — not unbearable, but tangible. My conscious thought overrode the feelings in my heart to know that there was nothing to it, I wasn't losing Heidi here. And even if I did lose Heidi... it was probably for the best, I told myself.

For a long while I heard nothing through the phone. Their breathing turned to normal, and they weren't kissing any more.

Then I heard Heidi say, "It's late. You should get going soon."

Patrick said, "We have plenty of time."

"Hmm... I don't know... I really have to get up early in the morning." Heidi was lying through her teeth, but I approved one hundred percent.

"My parents are expecting me for Sunday lunch, prompt."

Patrick chuckled. "Maybe next time."

Then Heidi hung up on me.

It wasn't long before she texted me:

> *Mission accomplished. Still okay for me to come see you right now?*

I was shaking a little as I replied:

> *Of course.*

Chapter Ten

I opened the door, and there she was, looking as she had when I'd left her, stunning in her black-and-white dress, although perhaps her hair was a touch disheveled. Her coat seemed awfully thin considering the temperature outside.

I said, stepping back to invite her in, "Jesus, you must be freezing."

"The taxi was warm," she said, then smiled. "And I think I'm buzzing so much, I don't notice."

"So you enjoyed it, then?" I asked. "You... like him?"

"Uh-huh."

I led her into the living room, not quite knowing what to do now that she was here. If I possessed her, I could do anything I wanted with her. But it felt strange to me — and I didn't know how she still felt about that arrangement after bedding her new man.

"You could have stayed with him," I said. "If you'd wanted."

"You wanted me to sleep with him, and then come to see you," she said, sitting on the couch.

"But if you liked him..."

She shook her head. "I have his number. If you want me to see him again."

"You want to see him again?"

"If you want me to."

I sighed as I sat in the chair opposite her. I was going to have to get used to this authority stuff. She seemed totally at ease with the idea of me running her life — or at least, her dating life. But if I possessed her, I

could enjoy her, too. I was curious to see how she would react to that idea.

"So... you had fun with him?"

"Uh-huh." She held her knees, seeming pleased with herself for carrying out her instructions.

"You slept with him."

"I did."

I felt a surge of heat inside me at that. Heidi — my Heidi — had just slept with someone else. He'd been all over her — inside her.

"Was he good?" I asked, feeling the flicker of dark lust inside me, a deep wickedness at asking her such intimate questions. "Did he make you come?"

"He was, and he did," she said, sitting there so primly, like this was a job interview for the position of governess to some rich children.

I hesitated a moment or two, just taking in the fact that Heidi had been intimate with another man just minutes before. Mulling over the feelings inside me, and the strong desire I felt for her — stronger than ever before. There was something devilish in her now, and it was irresistible to me.

I said, "Did he bring condoms?"

She shook her head.

"But you didn't have any, either, and you still let him fuck you?"

She said, "He pulled out before he finished."

"Risky," I said. "But I should have made sure you had condoms. How did he finish?"

"In my mouth, over my breasts."

I nodded. My cock was so hard inside my pants, throbbing away. How could I feel so differently about this girl, after months spent with her when we were both so miserable? I sat back in my chair, legs apart, not concerned if she saw how hard I was for her. Her eyes fell on my lap, and couldn't fail to make out what I was stowing there. She tried to hide her response, but didn't entirely manage it.

"You asked him to leave?" I said.

"I said I had get up early in the morning to go visit my parents," she said. "He was okay about it."

"And you were okay about it? With having him leave?"

She nodded, trying hard to keep her eyes on mine. "I wanted to come here and see you."

My God, I wanted her. But I was torn between my powerful desire and the original purpose of my seeing her — to improve her self-

confidence, to help set her up in a new relationship with a guy who would be better for her. And yet she wanted me to possess her. That didn't just mean me being some kind of agony uncle or amateur relationship counselor.

She was mine.

I said, "Did he have a big... prick?"

"Big enough."

"It felt good when he was inside you?"

"Very good."

I nodded. My decision was coming down in favor of enjoying her — even if it came with risks that she would believe it meant we were back together.

"What was his name again?" As if I would forget.

"Patrick."

"Patrick didn't take your underwear like the other one did?"

"No," she shook her head.

"Show me."

Without a hint of outrage, she parted her legs a little wider, then peeled the hem of her black and white dress up, revealing more of her thighs — and the racy black and white g-string just about covering her pussy.

"Give them to me," I said, my throat suddenly feeling somewhat dry.

She continued to comply with what I told her, lifting her dress further, until a narrow band of her stomach was visible above her g-string, before slipping her fingers in its waistband and lifting her hips on the couch so she could peel it down over her thighs, past her knees, her ankles, her feet.

Holding them stretched between both hands, she peered at them for a brief moment before folding them, and handing them to me. I pressed them to my face, feeling the warm dampness on the satin material, inhaling the thick scent of female arousal. Of sex.

I lost myself in my desire for her for a moment. When I looked up, Heidi gazed directly back at me, fire in her eyes.

I said, "Show me what happened. Show me how it went."

"He said he didn't want any coffee. Only me," she said. "So I took him into my room."

I rose to my feet, held out my hands to help Heidi up from the couch, then led her through to my room.

"We kissed, and he took my dress off," she said as my door closed behind us. I stepped up to her, put my hands up to cradle her face, and I kissed her. But I wasn't merely mimicking her previous lover. I was enjoying her for myself. I was kissing a woman who had just made love to another man.

I could smell him on her. I could taste something different about her. I could see the faint trace of perspiration on her skin, in her hair. I could see how her lipstick had smeared as she had taken him into her mouth.

It seemed like I ought to be disgusted with her, or that I should have forced her into the shower at once. But it was such a turn-on, seeing her as this sexual being, ripe, fertile, and taken by another man. Used for his pleasure, and for hers. Breathing her in, tasting her, my senses firing with the evidence of her sexual encounter.

I kissed her, tenderly exploring her mouth with mine, with my lips, my tongue, and my fingers slipped under the straps of her dress, sliding them over her shoulders, then off them. Allowing the thing to slip down, and with a little assistance, fall to the floor.

"What happened next?" I asked her, as though this was the only reason I had been kissing her, to find out what had gone on.

She stepped back, sat on the bed, then pulled herself back, her feet up off the floor without removing her high-heeled shoes. "I lay back on the bed," she said, "and he just stood and watched for a while, and I was just... kinda touching myself..."

I watched her sitting there, looking seductively at me, sweeping her hands over her breasts, cupping them, fondling them. She leaned back, moving one leg so that her thighs were parted, her exquisite flower on display for me. She stroked it, tracing its contours with her fingers, as though trying to sell me on it. The first time she'd done it, with Patrick, she would have had her panties on still.

As he must have, I paused a while and appreciated the sight of her. There was something not quite right about this — it wasn't the way women would normally behave, particularly when inviting a man into their bedroom for the first time. I expected Heidi to kiss him, fumble with his clothes, pull him back into her bed for some more kissing, some rolling around on the bedsheets, ultimately taking him in her mouth or in her sex.

This was altogether more of a performance. Her come-hither eyes, her displayed body, her intimate touching. It made me imagine that Heidi's research had progressed beyond *Cosmopolitan* or *Glamour* magazine, to the pornography so prevalent and easy to find on the web.

"I had to pull him over to me, too," she said, scooching forward on the bed, sitting on the edge of the mattress, reaching for me. She put her hands on my chest, feeling out the shape of my pectoral muscles through my thin blue shirt.

"And then?" I asked her.

"I pulled him onto the bed with me," she said, doing exactly that with me, beaming from ear to ear at the growing sense that she was going to get to replicate what she'd done with Patrick with me.

I went with her onto the bed, crawling over her as she lay back, propped up on one arm, pulling me by the shirt with the other.

"Then he was kissing me," she said. "All over."

I kissed her sweet lips again, briefly, but then moved down the soft skin of her neck, breathing her perfume, her underlying personal smell, and the subtle scent of her lover. I kissed my way down her chest, bringing one hand up to cup her breast through her bra as I kissed my way over it, Heidi tilting her head back and moaning.

"He kissed you down here?" I asked her.

"Uh-huh," she moaned.

I slipped down her bra, revealing her sweet little breasts, those pink nipples so stiff, I kissed her there, flicking my tongue around her little buds, taking them into my mouth to suck on them hungrily.

"And he kissed you here?"

"Uh-huh."

Off came her bra entirely, and now she lay back on the bed, and now I kissed my way down the soft, pale flesh of her stomach, tasting the slight saltiness on her skin, breathing in that strange scent of another man as well as Heidi's own.

"And down here?" I asked her.

"Oh, yes."

I kissed and licked my way gently over her mound, past that little patch of dark hair left behind during her waxing session, and then I was personally experiencing the smoothness of her skin around her pussy, marveling up close how she looked.

The strong smell of sex made me feel a little light-headed, seriously aroused. I stroked her pussy gently with the back of my fingers, feeling her wetness, her stickiness, wondering at the redness of her pussy lips, the state of her sex after taking another man inside it.

"He kissed you like this?" I said, and nudged my tongue against her groove, tasting her tangy juices, sucking on her lips.

"Oh... yes... oh... please..." she moaned.

She just lay back, arms folded behind her head, trying to look down at what I was doing, but ultimately having to tilt her head back, close her eyes and deal with the blissful feelings surging through her. I appreciated the view up her body, her flat stomach and the small but beautiful mounds of her breasts, her hard nipples, her chest rising and falling with her deep breathing and her moaning, and the way her facial expressions responded to the pleasure I was giving her.

I feasted on her like I'd never done before, adoring her flavor, tickled by the curious thought that she'd only just fucked someone else. Lapping at her juices, sucking her lips into my mouth, swirling my tongue through her slippery groove, she raised her hips up as though to press herself more firmly against my mouth.

I'm not even sure how long I went down on her. It was an age. I took my time and enjoyed every moment. Then she was crying out and laughing, shaking a little, her toes curling as she came, and I noticed a good deal more wetness for me to lap up as her orgasm struck.

Her broad smile, her giggling, made me smile as well. "He kissed you like that?" I asked.

"Not quite like that," she said, breathless, still smiling ear-to-ear.

"He made you come like that?"

"No, just you."

"So what happened next?"

"Oh, wait, I got it wrong," she said. "Before all that happened, before he went down on me, I went down on him." She seemed proud of herself, pleased that her latest attempt at oral sex had not ended things.

"Show me."

"He pulled off my panties and my shoes," she said, raising her knees up under her chin so she could reach her shoes, and pull them off. "Then I had him lie on the bed..."

She urged me down, now, onto my back, and straddled me. She opened my shirt, sweeping her hands over my exposed chest, kissing her way down until she was in position to unfasten my belt and my pants. She didn't need to pull my pants far down my thigh to release my hard cock. It sprang free before being surrounded by her fingers. Heidi looked elated at how hard I was for her.

She licked my shaft, and slipped the tip of my cock in her mouth, gazing up at me as she sucked on me, showing me once again how incredible she could be with a little simple guidance to improve her method.

"You sucked on him like this?" I asked her.

"Uh-huh."

"He must've enjoyed it."

"Uh-huh."

"And you enjoyed it?"

"Not as much as this," she said, swirling her tongue around my tip, ecstatic at being allowed to play with my manhood, it seemed.

I stroked her hair, but otherwise let her do as she pleased. Eventually, though, she withdrew, moving off me before attempting to pull my pants and my underwear off down my legs. I had to help her take them off, but then she was straddling me again and reaching to pull off my shirt, my hard cock gently brushing against her soft skin.

"This is how it was?" I asked her, my hands gliding over her thighs, her hips, her stomach, her back, reveling in the softness of her skin.

"Yes," she said, lifting herself up slightly before reaching behind her to take hold of my cock. She lined up my hardness, touching my tip to the slick heat of her pussy, then sank down slightly, easing my tip inside her. She was so tight, it took her a few moments to take my length inside her, easing it in, coating it in her juices. Had she been this tight when we were dating? I suppose it had been a while since we'd had sex.

She held her breath as I filled her, her eyes widening, her mouth opening.

"It was like this with him?" I asked her.

She flicked her long, dark hair behind and over her shoulder, and began to move her hips, rocking gently over my hardness. "This is better," she said. "You're bigger. It feels better."

I placed my hands on the pleasing roundness of her behind, and helped to guide her motion on me. After a while she sat up, tossing her hair back over her shoulder again, riding me harder, my hands moving to cover her breasts.

I looked at her beaming smile, and couldn't help but smile in return. This was clearly her reward for doing whatever I asked of her. But at the same time, being able to appreciate her immediately after her liaison with another man was my twisted reward for helping her with her confidence, and get her back on the dating ladder.

But was she really dating me again, or was this simply a friends with benefits arrangement?

I wasn't sure I cared in that moment, as she rode me like a stallion, and quite clearly came again as she did so. Had she been this easy to orgasm before? I couldn't remember it.

"He made you come like this?" I asked her.

"Yes," she said, breathless. "But I was imagining... telling you about it, about how he was fucking me."

"You were imagining how I might want you to show me?" I gave her a wry grin.

"Something like that."

"And then?"

She rolled off me, onto her back, saying, "He tried going on top..." as I did likewise, only she said, "but he didn't last long."

"He pulled out, right?"

"Uh-huh. He told me he was close, so I stopped him," she said. "I knelt on the floor, and he sat on the bed, and I was sucking on him again..."

"Show me."

I moved to the edge of the bed, and Heidi jumped off the bed herself, to take up position between my knees on the floor. She took hold of my shaft in her hands, and began pumping it again, before slipping the tip into her mouth.

I could have lasted longer, but I wanted it to be the way it had been with Patrick. I reveled in the sight of her doing this, kneeling, naked, waiting for a stranger to come in her mouth.

"And he came just like this?" I asked, breathless myself.

"Uh-huh."

I let fly, and my orgasm was a strong one. I groaned as I felt the hot come welling up, jetting into her mouth, Heidi looking elated as it pumped into her, moaning as she swallowed, almost purring. She didn't quite contain all of it, some escaping to drip down her chin, onto her breasts, her stomach. I wasn't going to criticize her: it was a hot sight to behold.

She cleaned me, gently, swirling her tongue around my tip, sucking a little as though to make sure she wasn't missing out on anything.

"That was incredible," I said. "Patrick must have enjoyed it."

She smiled. "I think so."

"You want to see him again?"

She shrugged. "I could."

"Or?"

"You could find me someone else."

*

After that, she freshened up in my en suite, and when she emerged she went to pick up her clothes. It struck me as particularly submissive that she did not make the assumption that she was staying the night with me.

"You want to spend the night?" I asked her.

"You want me to?"

"Stay," I ordered her, and patted the mattress beside me.

She smiled and approached the bed.

"Lose the clothes," I added, and she laughed, complying so that I could run my eyes all over her bare body.

"So you're really mine," I said.

"I really am."

"But you're not my wife."

"No. Do I need to be?"

I shook my head, and placed my hand gently on her stomach, feeling the smooth skin. "No. I think it's better this way."

"I'm yours," she said. "That's all that matters."

"Okay." I was stroking her mound, and her pussy, gently. "Do you hate me for what I did?" I asked her. "For ending our marriage?"

"No," she said, quietly sighing as my fingers found her slit, one dipping slightly inside to find her wet there. "It wasn't working. Something had to happen."

"I still want you to be with someone else. You'd be happier. Does that bother you?"

"No. I want what you want."

"Does it bother you that I find it... exciting... when you're with someone else? And when you come back to me afterwards?"

"No... I... I like it, too."

I rolled over onto my front, and ducked down between her legs. "I want to see you enjoying sex," I said, stretching apart her pussy lips with my hands, appreciating the view of her smooth flesh, her pink petals. "I want to see you enjoying other guys... I want you to know how much they want you... I want to know how much you want them..."

She moaned as I slipped my tongue inside her and tasted her again.

"Oh... yes... oh God..." she panted.

I could get used to this.

Chapter Eleven

I woke up alone in the bed, Heidi gone already. I glanced across the empty half of the bed, and saw the open door to my en suite, and that the petite brunette was in there, leaning over the sink. Even this far away from the bathroom, I could tell from the dampness in the air and the slight scent of shampoo — my shampoo — that she'd taken a shower, even if she wasn't standing there with a towel around her waist.

"You don't have a hair dryer around here, I suppose?" she asked. She looked at me, and I saw that she'd put on a touch of make-up. Make-up? For the morning after? It wasn't quite the full effect, but it was still a little startling, since I was used to a Heidi who wouldn't bother with make-up even if she attended a wedding.

"Uh-huh," I said. "Sorry, it's all gone a bit bachelor mode around here."

"Well, I'll survive." She shook out her long dark hair, and it wasn't too wet.

I sighed. Last night had been intense. Now certain details were returning to mind, my blood flow was quickening a little, and things were thickening between my thighs, hidden by the bedsheets.

"You're leaving?" I asked as she dropped the other towel, and stooped to pick up her forsaken underwear. "You could stay for breakfast, at least?"

She smiled, delighted that I was inviting her to stay. "If you want me to," she said. "But I have to get back to practice."

I watched her slipping her black and white g-string up past her knees, and over her thighs, I recalled how she'd looked the previous night when she came back to me. My Heidi, used. Spoiled. Corrupted. My Heidi, a naughty nymph, fresh off an incredible adventure that had ended in sex with another man.

I wanted her again. There was just something so hot about thinking of her that way, a promiscuous devil. I wanted to pull her to me, suck her hard little nipples into my mouth, dump her onto the bed and devour that sweet hairless pussy of hers. I had the power to keep her here.

At the same time, I knew how important it was for her to practice her cello. It was her profession these days.

"You should practice," I nodded. She put on her matching bra, reaching behind her back to fasten the catch. I asked, "When's the next concert?"

"Thursday," she said. "Just a kids' thing. Easy music — Saint-Saëns, that kind of thing. But fun."

As she was pulling on that black dress with the white sides, I was reminded of what Bella had suggested to me in the club the previous night. Heidi flirting with her orchestra friends.

"Orchestra's practicing tomorrow?"

A nod. "In the afternoon. Full days Tuesday and Wednesday, though."

The sight of her in that dress made my heart skip a beat. She was clean after her shower, but her clothes were still from the previous night, the night of her debauchery. There was something deeply sexy about that. I chuckled at myself. I'd turned into such a pervert.

She walked out of the bedroom, but before I could wonder what she was up to, she returned bearing her coat, which she now slipped on over her dress, pulling it tight as she could to attempt to hide her nightwear, no doubt to minimize the obvious judgment while she was on her way home that she was doing a Walk of Shame.

"I'll see you Saturday?" she asked.

I felt my hardness stir. It was nice to have something to look forward to. I might have had plans to see my guy friends the following Saturday, but it was nothing I couldn't get out of. I'd prefer to see Heidi again, to lead her on another merry chase. To get her laid and then take her back for myself.

"Yes," I said. "That would be good."

She looked jubilant at that. The thought of meeting up again. The promise of fucking her, right after she'd been taken by someone else.

That she would go home with another man, but that I ultimately owned her.

I stretched open my legs, enjoying the space on my bed — the freedom, I guess, of not having a wife, even though I received some of the benefits from one. The sheets moved and tautened over the hardness that now pressed to my stomach, and I saw Heidi's eyes grow wide recognizing the shape. I feigned accidentally yawning and stretching out my limbs further, so that the sheets fell away to expose my hard cock. I just wanted to startle her a little, make her react.

But she was mine, to do as I wished. I could get more than just the appeal of flashing my manhood in front of her.

I said, "You could get a little practice in before you go."

She hesitated a moment, and I guess it wasn't like me — the old me — to demand a blowjob from her at a moment's notice. But then she was tearing off her coat, telling me simply, "sure", and clambering onto the bed, a hungry look on her face.

Kneeling between my thighs, she thrust her butt in the air and ducked down to run her tongue up the length of my hard cock, from base to tip — smiling ear-to-ear as she did so. Then with her hands planted either side of my hips to support her body, she used only her mouth to pick up my cock by the tip, stretching her lips around it, sinking down to engulf my length in warmth.

I groaned as she bobbed down on me, her damp hair trailing over my skin as she did so. She wiggled her hips, changing position a little so she could free up her hands to grab a hold of my shaft.

My God, she'd gotten good impressively quickly. But as good as it felt to have her tongue swirling around my cock, to have her stroking me with the inside her cheeks, while squeezing and pumping my shaft in her hands, the hottest thing was just how much she smiled as her eyes connected with mine. Showing that she wanted this as much as I did.

There was definitely a big part of the whole Heidi-sharing kink revolving around my feelings about making her happy. It probably made me seem a little less altruistic to reveal that I was physically turned on by her cheerfulness, by gifting her this new sexual satisfaction, but it was undeniable.

Her lipstick smeared a little, but she didn't seem concerned about it, about any of her make-up. She reveled in stroking my hard cock all over her cheeks, her face.

And when it came time to finish up, she cheerfully took my shots of creamy goodness inside her mouth, and allowed a couple of jets to streak

over her chin and her upper chest.

"You're getting very good at that," I said, and her smile broadened, if that was possible.

"I have a good teacher," she said, wiping a little cream from the corner of her mouth before licking her finger clean.

I laughed. "You know, it might be time to take the next step."

"Next step?" she asked, seeming a touch confused as she reversed off the bed, and reached for her coat again.

"I think you should try dating someone," I said. "You know, more long-term than just a random hook-up from a nightclub."

"Okay," she said, pulling her coat tightly around her again. "Like who?"

"I don't know," I said. "My guess is... it should probably be someone from your orchestra."

I heard her catch her breath. "Is that... wise?"

I could see in her eyes she knew I remembered what she'd said before, about that blond guy in Johnny's. She didn't want to get into entanglements at work.

I said, "I think you should be more open to it. If it doesn't work, it doesn't work and you move on — but maybe if it's someone from the orchestra, you'd have... well, more to talk about."

She nodded, but there was a hint of fear in her eyes. I was ready to accept it if she refused, of course. But this new Heidi wasn't someone to refuse me, it seemed. She said, "I suppose if it's someone in another section, it wouldn't be so bad."

I pulled the bedsheets over my softening manhood. "Great. I think you should at least start considering the options, maybe get talking to a few guys there you find attractive... you know... sound them out."

She nodded, and somehow I started feeling as nervous as she obviously was.

*

An hour or two later, I'd calmed down, having thought it all through countless times. It came back to my original motivation: to help Heidi move on. I was enjoying being with Heidi for controlled periods of time at the moment, I was enjoying the wicked game we were playing, and I was loving the whole sex thing, which I had never thought would happen with Heidi again.

But what if one, or either, or both of us tired of the whole thing? Maybe Heidi would get sick of hooking up with random guys merely to please my little kink. Maybe I'd come to my senses and realize that hey, it's just plain weird to want someone else to come in and fuck your woman before you do — especially when she isn't really your woman, but your ex.

Two, three, four months might pass and the renewed passion might fizzle again from our relationship, leaving us in exactly the same place we were in before.

No, Heidi needed someone else, she needed a new long-term boyfriend, or even a new husband. Bella had been right to suggest that if I was serious about taking this to its full conclusion, Heidi had to start dating properly, not just enjoying the one night stands. The orchestra was simply a natural catchment area for her to find someone. Google told me that a full orchestra had 70-100 people playing, there had to be someone Heidi might go for.

I was resolved to start Heidi down that route, even while I was looking forward to Saturday and another night out with my ex with the intention of getting her laid again with someone stranger. I didn't want the one night stand thing to get tired before the dating thing got going, I didn't want Heidi feeling demotivated.

Just before lunch time, I found myself thinking about Heidi again, and whether she would do as I'd asked and start chatting up orchestra guys she thought attractive. I supposed that I'd never actively told her to chat them up, just talk to them. Maybe I should have been clearer.

Lying on my couch watching TV, I saw my phone on the coffee table in front of me, and a little idea was born.

I grabbed it and wrote a text message to Heidi:

> *What's the dress code for orchestra practice?*

Her reply wasn't long in coming — I knew Heidi well enough to figure she was most likely simply sitting watching TV like I was, this

time on a Sunday.

> *Nothing much — we can wear what we like. Why?*

I texted her:

> *What are you planning on wearing?*

This time I had to wait five minutes. Was she trying to figure out some smart response? But now she sent through a photo. It showed her bed, with an outfit laid out on the mattress — a pair of jeans, a gray woolen top, white blouse. She even laid out some underwear — a white bra and thong set, which was fairly plain but was still a million times sexier than any underwear she'd owned while we were together.

I liked that she was wearing thongs even to work these days. But those jeans, and that top, were not particularly striking.

I texted back:

> *I want you to wear something a little more exciting. A little more daring.*

She replied:

> *Can't be too outrageous, it's still a workplace ;-)*

I told her:

> *But you can wear something casual that's still sexy.*

Heidi sent me another photograph, this time offering a black skirt in place of the jeans, and no woolen top. It was better than the jeans, but the skirt was fairly long.

> *Better, but still not quite what I had in mind.*

Heidi came back with:

> *Shopping expedition this afternoon?*

That made me laugh, because it totally wasn't what I was thinking of — I honestly thought Heidi might have something suitable.

> *Sure. Give me an hour and I'll be with you.*

I wasn't going to complain at the imposition, though. I didn't have much better to do that afternoon. Watching Heidi stripping and parading before me in various outfits would be far more entertaining.

So there we were, grabbing a taxi to Oxford Street this time, to dip into the big department stores and sift through the various options available. Shopping had never been this fun before, and I'd been a few times with Heidi while we were married. She'd never been a big fan of shopping either, but now we had a different agenda — to make her look Sexy As Hell. To buy the kind of clothes that would push the boundaries at orchestra practice and draw the male attention.

Once again I got to suggest outfits to her and she might adjust my choice here and there owing to the fact that I had no real expertise in

women's fashion, but she didn't reject my choices on the bases of something being a little too daring.

Then I'd sit in the changing rooms as she pulled off her clothes, and as she modeled new outfits. We found a long-sleeve blue denim "mini shirt dress" that basically looked like a shirt that was a little overly long, only it clung to her curves nicely with a brown belt around the waist, and fell down to mid-thigh. And not only did it ride up while she was sitting down — and would be devastating when she was playing her cello — you could also undo a few buttons quite subtly to show a little more cleavage.

There was a short, casual long-sleeve dress made of faded purple cotton, which we paired with a pair of knee-length brown boots.

There was a gray pencil skirt which we put with a black sleeveless chiffon top that emphasized her shape nicely.

"I'm noticing a lot of skirts and dresses here," she point out wryly while we were looking at something that was so short there was no way she'd be able to sit down in it and not show the world her underwear.

"You do remember I play the cello?"

"How could I forget?" I laughed. "Hottest instrument there is for a woman."

"I'll need more dark underwear."

So just to be sure, we shopped for a little more dark underwear. We also figured out, thanks to a mannequin in Selfridges, that Heidi would look good in skin-tight leggings and short dresses, in fact the leggings meant the dresses could almost be so short they were more like tops.

By the close of play that afternoon, Heidi once again had a mountain of shopping bags, and I found myself sitting in a shady corner somewhere in the Debenhams department store, hidden by a clothing rack, receiving an impromptu lap dance from Heidi, before she sank to her knees in front of me and ended the day very much as it had begun, only this time she swallowed every drop.

*

The next day I sent Heidi a text in the afternoon asking what she was wearing to orchestra practice, and a little later I received back a selfie taken in a bathroom stall showing Heidi in her very short new denim mini shirt dress, her legs parted as though she were playing the cello, and a view up her thighs to reveal her black thong.

She texted me:

>Already had a lot of guys trying to subtly check me out :-)

I replied:

>Excellent! So pick some that you like and get flirting!

Chapter Twelve

The rest of the week, I had an update every day to show me what Heidi was wearing to orchestra, although on Thursday it was more of a conservative dress since it was concert day — and for kids at that.

I was looking forward to Saturday on so many levels, but it came as a huge crashing disappointment that work ended up getting in the way. We had a major IT failure at our office, and though all the finances involved were protected, all the work we'd achieved was lost and with deadlines looming my boss was pleading with us all to stay a little late.

At first I refused outright, but when it came to providing a reason why, and when colleagues around me were agreeing to the extra hours even though it was taking them away from their children, and so on, it didn't quite seem right that my urgent reason for not contributing was that I wanted to go out to a club.

So, in the end, I had to do it. All I could do was apologize to Heidi and suggest we could do it another time.

Heidi, however, had other ideas. She texted:

>What if I just went out anyway?

I liked the sound of that.

>Fine with me :-)

She replied:

>I could still dance with guys... and maybe take one home... then come see you later, right? How long would you be at the office?

I said:

>Not sure. Maybe past midnight, but not all through the night.

Heidi came back:

> You can just text me when you're done, so I can see you after xx

I managed to put it all out of my mind for a while, but that was only possible for so long. Then in came a text message bearing a selfie from Heidi showing how she looked before going out.

> What do you think? ;-)

She was wearing a leopard print dress that was not merely a little risqué, it was downright slutty. Did she buy that on one of our shopping trips? I remembered something similar... but couldn't remember that we'd bought it. In her picture she was holding up the hem of her dress to show me her white lace thong. I accidentally opened the image at my desk — and had to suddenly hide it away before someone saw it, then sneak away to the bathroom to appreciate it fully.

> You look stunning. Have fun! Xx

I felt a little strange including kisses after my text message, but then again we were sleeping together. We did more than just kiss. My chest felt as though it was filled with butterflies to see Heidi like that. The way she was dressed made it seem almost guaranteed that she'd meet someone, and succeed in dragging him home. Then again, with her new attitude, almost any outfit was going to lead to success of a certain kind.

I had to put the thoughts out of my mind to focus on my work, which really seemed mind-numbingly dull compared to what was going on in Johnny's. And it didn't help that Heidi kept texting me updates.

Heidi: The guys seem better looking tonight, somehow. You're missing out!

Joe: Your self-confidence is probably just making you think more of the guys are available to you.

Heidi: Maybe. I'm not sure I'll last all night at this rate!

It was hot to receive tidbits about how her night was going, and actually helped me get through the tedium of countless spreadsheets. Later on, it got hotter and hotter.

Heidi: Two guys were almost fighting over me!

Joe: Impressive! See how far you've come.

Heidi: I ended up dancing with both of them, and both were trying to get their hands under my dress. Not a bad feeling ;-)

And:

Heidi: Was dancing with a hot black guy and he made me come in the middle of the crowded dance floor :-P

Joe: Jesus. You should try and reciprocate!

Then around midnight, I found myself watching a video shot on Heidi's camera phone. It was filmed in incredibly bad light — but after a few moments I could understand what I was looking at: Heidi on her knees in a dark corner of the nightclub, sucking on a black guy's large cock.

Jesus. She was crazy.

It didn't last too long — maybe a few minutes at most. I'm not even sure if the guy in question ended up coming. The video cut off too early.

The question I had, though, was more related to production.

I texted her:

>Who the hell was filming you?

After a little while, Heidi texted back:

>Your friend Bella. You didn't know she was here? She's been keeping me company all night.

Now I had another text message come in, this time from a number my phone didn't recognize.

>Hi Joe, hope you're not too bored at the office xx

I assumed this was from Bella, so I saved the number to my phone so it would appear with some kind of recognizable moniker. I texted her:

>Thanks for keeping Heidi company.

She replied:

>It's no problem. Keeps me entertained. That ex of yours is a slut ;-)

I laughed out loud at that one. I had to come up with some little white lie to explain to my colleagues in the office why I was suddenly bursting out into guffaws while doing nothing but processing numbers on a screen.

"I think maybe I'm going nuts," I suggested, blustering my way out of an explanation.

"Better watch out guys," warned my co-worker Will Matthews.

"One day he'll come back to the office with a gun..."

I had to follow Bella's texts more secretly. Nevertheless, it was a great way to pass the time. And it was mostly Bella's texts after that. Heidi was otherwise occupied. Bella attempted to send me pictures of my ex on the dance floor, or even at the bar with various guys. The light levels weren't great, so it was difficult to see anything much, but what I could make out gave me a hard-on I had to work hard to conceal.

And occasionally, I was able to text replies to her.

Bella: You know what the great thing is? I get to choose who she goes home with, since you're not here.

Joe: Choose well. If you don't, you're fired.

Bella: Oh I will! But there are a lot of gorgeous guys here, so chances are she's going to get someone hot ;-)

And:

Bella: She tells me she's getting on well stirring the interest of guys in the orchestra.

Joe: I think you're right about her needing to date somebody.

Bella: You know when I got here, she was talking to one of them. A blond guy I think I've seen in here before. Donny, she said he was called.

Joe: I think we've run into him before.

Bella: You know she seems to really like him. The way they were talking. She said to me he's not her type, though.

Joe: What do you think of him?

Bella: He's cute. But needs work. If he has to compete with the kind of guys Heidi can take home nowadays...

Joe: But maybe he's the right kind of guy for a long-term thing.

Bella: Maybe. But needs work.

Anyway. Thankfully, midnight came along and our boss decided to be nice, offering us the chance to go home and sleep if we'd only promise to go back into the office the next day — Sunday — for a few more hours. We were all willing to strike that deal, so time was called until 11am.

I fired off text messages to both Heidi and Bella to let them know I was done at the office.

I had a reply from Bella:

>Okay. You'd better head home. I've decided who gets to have Heidi tonight :-P

I did as she told me, though I was supposed to be the dominant male in this whole relationship. There was certainly no point in going over to Johnny's if Heidi had already taken her one night stand back home with her. I got home as quickly as I could, since Bella hadn't actually told me when Heidi had left the club — there was every possibility she would be left out in the cold waiting for me if I got back. Remembering that she'd been at my place before, and that she knew the code to get in the electronic lock at least made me relax a little on the way home.

As it happened, though, I got home and Heidi wasn't there just yet. I got to use the bathroom and find a glass of wine to help me relax. Then I received a strange text from Bella:

>You might want to get out of sight. My advice: hide somewhere in the bedroom.

My heart started beating uncontrollably. What was going on?

Then I heard somebody entering the four-digit number into the electronic keypad outside my front door. I scurried for the bedroom as fast as humanly possible, my socked feet slipping a little on the wooden floors.

I managed to get out of sight only just in time.

Heidi had brought her new lover to my place.

Chapter Thirteen

"Your ex doesn't mind you... being in his apartment?"

"He hasn't changed the code, has he?"

From where I stood behind the curtains in my bedroom, I could see all the way through the door, and across the rest of the open plan apartment to the front door, in which Heidi led her tall, dark-haired lover.

My God, she looked breathtaking in that tight leopard print dress. Were my eyes deceiving me, or was it even slightly sheer? Jesus. I could make out the white lace of her underwear faintly under the fabric of the dress.

"And you're sure he's out tonight?"

"Pretty sure."

She kissed him, and it seemed nervous — not just the nerves of a kiss with a stranger, either, because I'd seen Heidi doing that before. These were the nerves of knowing she was intending to sleep with this guy, and I would be watching. But they were good together. They kissed, tenderly, and their chemistry made me feel envy and a touch of jealousy, but also warm arousal. Heidi sucked gently on his lips, dipped her tongue into his mouth, and he did likewise, her hand on his chest, his spare hand cradling her head, running through her hair.

"What's the worst that could happen?" Heidi said, smiling broadly as she pulled back from their kiss.

"Uh... he could have a gun someplace," the guy replied.

Heidi laughed. "I'm just teasing you. I know he's not going to be here. Not while we are."

Now she broke away from his grasp, and scampered toward me, into the bedroom. She looked around, trying to figure out where I was. I stirred the curtains a little, and her eyes fixed on mine, seeing me there in the tiny gap between the large curtains hanging across the floor-to-ceiling windows. She gave me a nervous little smirk, but now turned to the bedroom door, slumping down on the bed as her lover ventured to the threshold of the room, his eyes scouring the apartment for signs that its owner might actually be around.

Then he came in, and Heidi knelt up on the bed as he climbed onto the mattress to kiss her once more. My God, I could see everything. They were just yards away from me. I could smell her perfume, his cologne. I saw his hands sprawling all over her ass as he kissed her, as he kissed my Heidi.

"You're a hot little kitty," the guy said.

Heidi just smiled bashfully, the old Heidi showing through a little in her blush, those suddenly timid eyes. I was a little concerned that in knowing I was here, Heidi might revert to how she had been before all this. Like how I felt when I met up with my old school friends from time to time, like I hadn't actually progressed since school.

But I had to think Heidi would not refuse this guy, and now that she had him interested in getting physical with her, he was hardly going to stop simply because she became a little more demure than she had been on the dance floor.

"I wanna see more," the guy said, allaying my fears.

He peeled her thin semi-sheer leopard print dress up her body, revealing the white lacy thong that really didn't cover much of her at all, exposing her breasts locked in their matching white lacy bra.

I was so hard watching him handling her. Any desire I'd had for her while I'd seen her dancing with guys in nightclubs, even making out on the dance floor, was now tenfold. Heidi was so stunning — partly because this man on the bed with her wanted her so badly, but also because she was being adventurous, naughty, sexy, right in front of me.

What I couldn't see, because Heidi's back was toward me, I could see in the mirrored front of my built-in wardrobe, which spanned an entire wall of the bedroom. I could see the nervous excitement in Heidi's eyes as he pulled down her bra, to touch and suck on her breasts, taking one stiff nipple into his mouth.

I saw Heidi brush her dark hair back out of her face, then flash a worried look in the mirror my way, frightened that she'd done wrong bringing him here. I parted the curtain a little further, gambling that her

lover was busy sucking on her breasts that he wouldn't see me, and she clearly took some reassurance from my smile, my slight nod of approval, before I allowed the curtain to fall back the way it had been.

"Show me," he said, his hands moving down her body, caressing her hips, toying with the waistband of her tiny white lace panties.

She sat back, letting him peel down her panties and toss them over on the floor close to where I was hiding. And now she was opening her pale thighs for him again, and this time as he leaned down to kiss her mouth, his fingers delved and dipped inside her beautiful almost-hairless pussy, and she was letting him touch her there, sighing as he stirred his digit within her.

"You're so beautiful," he said, placing a hand over her mound, his thumb running along her slippery pink groove, spreading her moisture up over her clit. "Very nice..."

I'd watched plenty of pornography in my time, but I'd never seen two lovers with each other in real life. It was somehow... organic. Real, and yet unreal. Beautiful, even if the choreography was plain compared to the kind of scenes you might see in the movies.

"You're so wet..."

I was impressed by his natural assertiveness. It seemed to me that Heidi responded to it, smiling more, her nerves thawing, she was beginning to enjoy herself again. She liked the alpha male type, it was why she'd lulled me into this new relationship in which I had power over her.

I watched this guy slip his thumb inside Heidi, loving the smoothness of her waxed pussy, and it made me think about Heidi's orchestra friend — Donny. What if the guy was the perfect match for her? A potential soulmate, best friend. But because he wasn't the dominant type, sexually Heidi was going to pass on him every time now.

My phone buzzed as a text message came in. I felt a jolt of fear shake me, paranoid that Heidi's lover would hear the vibration of my phone. But he was too busy pulling open his fly, whipping out his cock for my ex.

I glanced down at the phone. A message from Bella:

>How's it going? Did I choose well?

I smiled. Had Heidi really allowed Bella to choose her guy for the night? It was an amusing thought.

I glanced up to see Heidi kneeling up to grab her lover's cock. I caught my breath as I watched her slowly begin to stroke him — my Heidi touching another man's cock right in front of me, the man leaning

down to kiss her, his hands sprawling over her breasts. It was startling, and yet deeply thrilling. I wouldn't have said he was small, but he wasn't the largest guy in the world, though I wasn't an expert. I guess my view was skewed by the pornography I'd seen before. I never got to see other men naked in the flesh.

Heidi seemed happy enough, though. She'd managed to turn on the bed so I could actually see her lick the tip of his cock and then slip it inside her mouth without having to watch via the mirror. I felt my chest tighten as she drew him inside her mouth. Jealousy, I suppose, though only a mild form. It was so hot to see, though. The thrill of seeing Heidi being so naughty, so unlike the mild conservative Heidi of old, overwhelmed the slight unease I suffered seeing her enjoying another man.

And if anything, the subtle jealousy I felt merely fed into the intense desire I felt for Heidi now, the powerful need to take her back for myself. I had the strange realization that the jealousy wasn't a bad thing, wasn't a negative thing. It heightened my appreciation of everything, made the thrill even more nerve-jangling and heart-stopping. It was like the seasoning that made a bland dish delicious.

I texted Bella back:

>Not bad at all. She's definitely having a good time.

I was finding it difficult to breathe as I watched her sink down on him, a little at a time, before withdrawing to swirl her tongue around his bulbous head. Heidi was teasing me, shocking me, provoking me.

As my ex sucked on him, he pulled off his shirt. He'd clearly spent plenty of time in the gym — he wasn't particularly bulky, but his lean chest was well-defined. He made me feel a touch self-conscious about my own physique, and perhaps stirred the insecurity in me — my subconscious supposing that if Heidi could just go out and get guys like these, why did she still want to be mine?

Her lover — I was beginning to think of him as a "Patrick" now, because that was who she had been with the last time, when I was unable to watch, and because he wasn't unlike her description of Patrick that night — took charge of her sucking on him, withdrawing his stiff cock from her mouth, pumping his shaft himself while stroking its head all over her face. He took hold of her hair and guided her head back onto the tip of his cock, and as she bobbed down on him, he led her pace, controlled her rhythm.

She seemed to like it that way. Knowing how he wanted it, knowing he was happy with her like this. I suppose she was keen to learn, keen to

improve. I wasn't the only one giving her instruction.

Bella texted me:

> You can see everything? What's happening?

I replied:

> I can see everything. They're on my bed, and she's going down on him.

Patrick was kneeling up on the bed and fucking her face, using Heidi, and I was loving every moment. Was this strange kink of mine the result of my occasional use of pornography? I felt almost guilty, that dipping in and out of the world of filthy movies on the Internet ever since college had made me want to see women being used by other men as much as I wanted to sleep with the women myself.

But it was more than just wanting to watch Heidi being used. I felt a stronger bond with her now than I ever had when we'd been together. I did want to sleep with her myself. I just found her more desirable as a less pure, less virginal conservative type.

I was excited by her promiscuity, by her liberated sexuality.

She gave me little sideways glances as she sucked his cock inside her mouth, or as she withdrew it and flicked her tongue around its head. It brought back to mind how hot it was to appreciate that she was enjoying this experience herself — my desire for her wasn't just for her as an object to be used by other men, it was about her getting the thrills of new relationship energy as well, about Heidi feeling the elation of getting to enjoy strange cock.

> You're really going to let him fuck her right in front of you?

Bella's text came as Patrick withdrew himself from Heidi's mouth again, but this time paused before doing anything further. I felt that jarring shock of fear once again, that I was discovered. My paranoia suggested visions of him storming over here, wrenching open the curtains, maybe getting violent — or maybe calling the police to report me for some perverted behavior.

Was this a crime? It was my apartment. Heidi was my ex, my friend. My lover, if you wanted to call her that.

But I had nothing to worry about. Patrick was pulling off his pants and his underwear now, and manhandling Heidi. She let him move her until she was on all fours, not quite facing me, but lined up so that she could look at me as he knelt up behind her, as he grasped hold of her hips, as he pressed his hardness up against her smooth pussy.

I could see the question in her eyes as he stroked his cock against her sensitive slit, spreading her wetness over his length, preparing to

enter her. Was I really okay with this? I'd been fine about her sleeping with the last one, but then I hadn't had to watch it.

I looked in her eyes, with the utmost care to ensure Patrick did not see me there in the dark crack between the curtains. Heidi saw me give an approving nod, though. She saw it, and relaxed.

I was trying hard not to give myself away by breathing too loudly, but now I was concerned my thumping heart might expose me. He was moving down to her, one hand between his legs to position himself, and I had to stifle a gasp as he suddenly pushed into her, taking advantage of her considerable wetness to glide in, filling her and stretching her so quickly that she cried out.

My God.

She groaned as he filled her, her facial expression changing to surprise and then elation. I felt my chest swamped by an intense heat. Jesus, another man's cock was inside Heidi — my Heidi. Right in front of me. Before, when I'd known she was out with her previous guy, sleeping with him, it had still seemed a little hypothetical. I could imagine her fucking him, but it was still only a mental picture, even when I could hear them on the phone. This was far more real. The perspiration on their skin and in their hair, the sound of their labored breathing, the strong scent of their sex in the air, the wet noises of his manhood stirring in her pussy.

It sent adrenaline flaming around my blood vessels, setting my pulse into overdrive and my manhood bulging out of my fly.

He began to move against her, his hands clamped to her lower back and her waist, his body thumping as it pounded against her. Patrick was up to full speed quickly, panting as he thrust into her time and time again.

Heidi, though, was looking at me as he fucked her. There was something seriously sexy about it. Like she was really making love to me, though another man was doing the hard work. Patrick was no more than a toy which I was using on her.

She rocked back and forth, her shapely butt shivering each time he pounded into her. She moaned softly, but continued to gaze into my eyes adoringly.

My phone buzzed again with another text from Bella. She couldn't keep quiet, huh. I wondered how she thought about this whole fantasy. She'd taken delight in toying with Heidi all night, and knowing that she was sending Heidi over to be fucked in front of me.

Her text read:

>He's fucking her, isn't he?

I smiled and texted back:

>Don't you have your own love life to worry about?

With that came back:

>Oh I have nothing to worry about. Certainly not with a guy between my thighs making sure I'm fully satisfied.

I had to stifle a laugh. I texted:

>Seriously?

And she replied:

>You'll never guess who.

Well, who else could I possibly imagine she was referring to? There was no one else Bella and I both knew.

>Donny is going down on you right now?

It actually turned me on to think of the guy on his knees servicing the unquestionably beautiful Bella. How must he be enjoying it? She was, on the surface, way out of his league.

Bella texted back:

>I told you he needed work.

Again, I had to stifle laughter.

I texted her:

>I'll bet he's getting expert training.

Bella replied:

>Oh and then some. He's improving all the time. Heidi's gonna love him.

Somehow it burned inside me to think of Heidi going for Donny. That Bella would somehow turn him into some kind of god in the bedroom, and I would lose her to him completely. At the same time, there was something exciting about Heidi getting to be with some guy who really had a chance with her, not just a one-off hook-up.

It's hard to explain, but that hint of jealousy that spiced up my enjoyment of Heidi fucking this guy right in front of me somehow trebled when it came to think of Heidi actually dating someone, someone who had a good chance of being a boyfriend, a long-term relationship for her.

Sure, the risk of losing her was greater, but somehow the thought of her getting to be with someone special presented more of a thrill to me.

I wanted her to feel the buzz of a new relationship, not just the short sharp thrill of a one night stand.

Here I was, watching Heidi now lie on her front, Patrick straddling the backs of her upper thighs as he continued to fuck her from behind,

and my imagination was already turning toward how it might be for her to be with Donny.

I wanted him to win her over, and yet I was afraid of it.

I texted Bella:

>If we want him to get Heidi interested, we'll have to get him to be a little more alpha male.

In front of me, Patrick heaved Heidi over onto her back, and drove into her missionary-style. The petite brunette was enjoying being manhandled by him, turned this way and that as he desired, tossed around on the bed. Her dress was shoved up under her neck, her bra pulled down, and her breasts jiggled as he thrust into her. But for the first time I could actually see his cock entering her, and it quite took my breath away.

Bella replied:

>I thought that might be something she was into. I can toughen Donny up easily enough. He won't be the alpha male, though. I've told him you're Heidi's top dog xx

Well, that was a surprise. I guess Donny had to already think something strange was going on since he was being bedded by this gorgeous blonde who was actively coaching him to win some other girl — his crush.

Joe: What did he say to that? He must think Heidi's a little kinky.

Bella: Told him she's polyamorous. He seemed impressed. He's into her so much, it doesn't really matter.

Joe: Okay. Well don't break him. I want Heidi to start dating him next week.

Bella: Next week? You are a hard taskmaster. Going to have to take our Donny out shopping for a new look before then. Enjoy the rest of the night, and the rest of Heidi ;-)

I actually envied Donny a little. Heidi was once my crush, and back then I would have done anything to win her. Now she was his crush and there was a certain inevitability about him winning her. Would he feel the same way about her, though, as I did now, knowing that she was sexually involved with other people?

In front of me, Heidi was riding Patrick on top this time, reverse cowgirl facing my way. I watched her small breasts jiggling as she bounced on him, the muscles in her thighs flexing as she pumped him with her pink, soaking pussy. My God, I could see his cock thrusting into her like a piston, glistening with her juices, it was hypnotic. And every breath I took was saturated with the musky scent of their sex.

It was the hottest thing ever. She was initially leaning back, supporting herself with her arms behind her, her hands pressed against his chest, closing her eyes and panting as she fucked him. Then she thought better of it, leaned forward, opened her eyes and gazed into mine as she fucked him.

Patrick was lying on his back, totally obscured from my view by Heidi herself. I felt safe enough to part the curtains a little, to show Heidi just how hard she was making me.

I saw her eyes widen at the sight, but then she was smiling broadly, and the glimpse of me watching her seemed to send her over the edge. Heidi came with a great shivering cry, her body shaking, her chest and cheeks flushing, her pussy clamping around Patrick's hardness, her orgasm attempting to push him into his own.

He grunted, "I'm coming..."

But Heidi wasn't moving. She was riding him still, gazing into my eyes, trying to tease me again, provoke me, shock me with the sight of this stranger squeezing his manhood into her, the sight of it throbbing and bucking as his orgasm hit, the sight of his cock firing off deep inside her, and then as she slipped it out of her, the sight of his reddened cock shooting thick white cream all over her bare pussy.

After that, Heidi pulled herself off him. They lay in the bed for a while, not really saying much, just recovering their breath.

Patrick said, "I'd better be going. It's getting late."

Heidi didn't seem at all put out by him cutting and running. She just lay there and watched him pulling on his clothes. Patrick didn't seem guilty or embarrassed about it, either, but then he had been playing the dominant. He got what he wanted, that was how it went.

"I had a lot of fun," he said. It seemed awkward.

"Me too," Heidi smiled, picking herself up off the bed, reaching for her dress to provide herself some modesty as she showed him out. I'm sure it wasn't just me who could tell she was impatient for something.

"I'll call you," I heard him say as they went to the apartment front door. He sounded as though he'd been expecting her to ask him to stay, at least for a little longer.

But she only said, "Sure."

*

I didn't even wait for the front door to close on Patrick, or whatever his name was, before I was out from behind the curtains and making myself comfortable on the bed. It was my bed, but lying there I was breathing his smell, their smell. I could hardly believe what I'd just witnessed.

There was the sound of the front door closing, and then there was Heidi, scampering back into the bedroom.

"Are you mad at me?" she said, but there was a huge smile plastered all over her face as she sashayed from the doorway over to the bed. "I mean, you didn't exactly tell me to bring him over."

"Of course not," I laughed. "And anyway, how I understand it is, it wasn't your idea."

"No," she grinned, slowly dancing now, teasing me, her hands trailing up her thighs, dragging the hem of her dress up with them, almost to the point where I might see her pussy again. "It was Bella's."

I nodded.

"You have fun with her?" I asked.

"She's nice. I like her."

She gave me a flash of the goods, and I have to admit, I couldn't stop looking. But then she covered it up with her dress again, turned on her heels, and diverted into my large en suite bathroom.

"So you liked watching?" Heidi asked.

"Very much. Couldn't you tell?"

She laughed, and I heard her turn on the shower in the bathroom. "I thought you might not want to see at first," she said loudly over the flow of the water. Then, she came to the doorway, leaned against the jamb. "I mean, I know you wanted me to sleep with a guy, I didn't know if you wanted to see it."

I looked up at her. Said, "Hey, no shower. Come here."

I wanted her now, fresh from her adventure.

She wrinkled her face. "Wait. He's dripping out of me."

My hardness throbbed at the reminder that another man had filled my woman with his come.

My woman — I really was coming to think of her that way.

I wasn't particularly bothered by the mess he might have left behind. But Heidi turned and stepped back into the bathroom, to the sink. She grabbed a flannel from the towel rail by the door and now held it under the faucet, soaking it in warm water.

I watched her rubbing at herself between the thighs, once, twice, three times.

Then she was back out in the bedroom, dancing for me again, sinking her hips, pulling up her dress, bending over to show me her bare behind, then slipping the straps off her shoulders to show me her bare breasts.

"Come here," I ordered her, and she smiled at my obvious need.

"I don't need to reenact everything this time, do I?" she asked, amused that our foreplay in sessions gone by was no longer appropriate.

"I saw everything," I agreed.

"You can just take me as you want me."

She climbed onto the bed, towering over me as she stood on the mattress, still dancing, moving her hips, mimicking an exotic dancer — playful, mischievous, sexy. Where had she learned to move like this? Her grace, her poise, were exquisite.

She slipped off her dress, and now she was stepping over me, one foot either side of me, offering me a sensational view up her body, between her legs.

She danced over my head, as though she was attempting something in a lap dance club. Running her hands all over her body, through her long dark hair. Her nipples stiff as ever, her pussy rosy from use. I reached up to touch her calves, her thighs, running my hands over her soft, freshly shaven flesh.

"You had fun with him?" I asked her.

"He was good," she said. "Not as good as you."

"But you liked it."

"It was nice. Not as nice as having you watch, though."

She lowered herself to me, teasing me, again and again, but each time lifted before I could reach her. I'd sit up, trying to get a taste of her for myself, but she'd lift away from me, keeping out of reach.

"Come here," I demanded again.

This time she allowed me to reach her, and pull her down to my mouth. I could smell the sex strong all over her, despite her attempts with the washcloth. It only lit the flames inside me. I pulled her down, and she squealed as I clamped my mouth to her searing pussy, tasting the tangy wetness on her pussy lips, spearing her with my tongue.

She perched there over me, enjoying my attention, panting as I lapped at her, as I sucked at her clit.

"I thought... you were going... to wear protection..." I complained in between mouthfuls of her nectar.

"Uh-huh," she said in between long sensual sighs. "I forgot..."

"That's not good."

"I am on birth control..."

"Still risky," I said, but I wasn't particularly angry. I guess it's too easy to forgive a little slip. It was bad of her, though.

For now, though, she was forgiven. I was too turned on by her night's performance. I curled my arms around her thighs, locking her against my face as I devoured her, my face pressed against the wonderful softness of her waxed pussy, my tongue gliding into her fragrant groove. From her I heard only panting for a while, moaning, the occasional cry.

For a while she lost herself above me, her body steadily pressed down further and further on my face, and I could hardly see anything, though I didn't need to simply to feed my greedy hunger for her sex. She shivered, she shuddered, she convulsed above me, singing sweet soprano as she came, and for a while I was happy just to satisfy her, to reward her for her evening's courage, for her gift of showing me her debauchery.

Then she slumped forward, to lie over me, her hands moving to unfasten my belt and my fly, her fingers encircling my hard cock. From her moans, she seemed to take delight in just how hard I was for her.

I could take only so much, however, before I forced myself, virtually throwing her down onto the mattress on her back. She squealed and giggled, loving how crazy she'd driven me all night.

I kissed her mouth vigorously, and parted her legs, kneeling up to stroke the head of my cock over her dripping wet pussy. My manhood was throbbing, burning, pulsating with desire for this dirty hussy, her hair still damp with the perspiration of sex with another man, her skin sticky with his traces, her pussy still lubricated by his come.

I thrust into her with a single jab, making her yelp, then groan as I stirred within her, my hands holding her legs just beneath the knees as I pumped my hips to piston into her sex. Her body shook as I fucked her, her breasts shuddering, her stiff nipples shivering.

The way she moaned, the way she gasped, the way she cried — it struck me just how comparatively quiet she'd been with Patrick when he'd been fucking her.

"You like this?" I asked her, in barely more than a grunt.

"Uh-huh," she panted in reply.

"Better than him?"

"Better than anybody."

"But you did... enjoy... being with him?" I asked her. Concerned, now, that she was only flirting and fucking other men because I wanted

her to do so.

"Uh-huh," she said, breathless. "Just not... as much... as this."

"Tell me why," I demanded. "Tell me why you enjoyed him."

She panted a few times as I continued to plug her, considering her reply. Then she said, "He's handsome... it was... nice... knowing that he wanted me.... I liked... being with someone new..."

I smiled.

Then she said, "Most of all... I knew it would make you want me more..."

Well, that wasn't such a bad reason.

She added, "I liked that you were watching me with him. I liked fucking him for you."

I leaned down to kiss her, to crush her breasts in my hands, to squeeze her nipples. She whimpered through our kiss, and fought for breath, then she was shuddering under me, and it seemed to me she was coming yet again.

I broke away from our kiss, my hips pumping as fast as I could humanly achieve, pumping my hardness into her as her cries became screams.

Then I was coming inside her, deep, the tip of my cock hitting her cervix as jet after jet of thick cream erupted within her, her second such dose of the night.

I lay over her as the final pulses of energy burst through my manhood, kissing her lips tenderly, her soft neck. Her arms encircled me, and it was hard to deny there was some kind of chemistry between us, a genuine affection. Perhaps even love, though I wanted to deny it to myself, to her if she asked.

For ages we just kissed each other, smiling, sniggering like naughty children at what we'd just done, my cock softening inside her but not withdrawing.

Then finally I rolled off her, and we lay side-by-side on the bed, recovering.

"You're not going to meet people on the dance floor next Saturday," I said after a long while.

"No?" she seemed only vaguely disappointed. More, I think, she was curious what I had planned.

"You're going to ask someone out from orchestra this week," I said.

"Yes?" it had taken her by surprise, even if I had already coaxed her into flirting with the men in the Philharmonic, coached her on wearing more alluring clothing.

"I want you to ask him out for coffee," I said. "You'll have coffee with him on Wednesday some time. If it goes well, you might do it again on Thursday."

"We have our concert on Thursday."

"Rehearsal in the morning, performance in the afternoon?"

"Yes."

"So you'll have a mid-morning break. Spend it with him. Flirt with him, find out about him, show him you're interested. Then Friday..."

"Friday there's no orchestra."

"Friday you'll arrange to meet him for drinks in the evening."

"Okay. And Saturday?"

"Saturday you'll be here, and you'll give yourself to him fully," I said. My God, my cock was stirring again at the thought, even this soon after orgasm.

"Him'," she said. "You said 'him'. Does that mean you have somebody in mind?"

I laughed. "Donny," I said. "You're going to start dating Donny."

"Oh." She did sound disappointed.

"You'll do it for me. You'll date him, you'll fuck him. And you'll keep your mind open to liking him."

"I do like him," she said. "As a person, I mean. Just not —"

"Well now you'll like him like that, too," I demanded. "Or at least, you'll be open to it. If things really don't go well between you, I won't force it. But I want you to try."

She paused, and one of her hands quietly covered her mound, and began to stir between her thighs. "I'll do whatever you want me to do," she said softly. "If you want me to fuck Donny, I'll fuck Donny."

It wasn't my imagination that there was a little tremor of excitement in her voice. I know she didn't see Donny as someone she actively wanted to bed, but she liked the idea of having to fuck someone for me, someone she wouldn't ordinarily go for. She liked the idea of pleasing me by being naughty with someone like him.

Perhaps she even liked the idea of corrupting Donny.

Only, I was hoping Bella might do some of the heavy lifting first.

Chapter Fourteen

Monday morning. I woke with a funny feeling in my stomach I felt faintly nervous, and it took me until I pulled myself out of bed to remember and realize it was because of the new plan for getting Heidi to date Donny.

By the time I had my first coffee of the day, I was buzzing about it. It had been exciting enough getting Heidi playing and sleeping with other men, but this was taking things to a new level — getting her a long-term playmate. But this wasn't just excitement at getting Heidi a long-term boyfriend, there were also the nerves stemming from the risk that I could lose her in all this.

I don't know, I even felt that losing her would be some kind of success for me, and that just propelled the deep bittersweet feelings of hurt and arousal to new heights.

Hey, I was a mess, but I kind of knew that already.

Eating breakfast in front of CNN and thinking solely about Heidi rather than any of the financial news beaming out from the large screen in front of me, I found that part of my buzz was from the act of setting up Heidi. She liked Donny personally, as a friend, but she wasn't particularly interested in him sexually. Now I was going to change that — potentially with Bella's help. I'm guessing it was a power thing, I liked influencing her life, forcing her to consider something she wouldn't ordinarily and if it paid off for her, then it would feel even better for me, despite the fact that I did face losing her myself.

I still had the feeling, deep down, that losing Heidi would be okay if she was happy with the circumstances, because I still worried that to keep her might lead to an unsatisfactory long-term arrangement for both of us.

Halfway through my bowl of cereal, a text message came in from Bella.

>So are you still planning on getting Heidi to ask out Donny this week?

I chuckled, and replied:

>Planning on it. Why, are you having second thoughts about losing Donny to her?

My manhood was starting to thicken up inside my pants at the thought of Bella taking Donny home with her to "train" him in the sexual arts so that he might capture Heidi's heart. I thought about how lucky the guy was — Bella was very attractive. But if the guy took to his training too well, perhaps Bella would want to keep him herself.

Bella replied:

>No, I'll do my part. Just want to make sure you're doing yours. Donny has a big thing for her, you know.

Feeling mischievous, I replied:

>A big thing? ;-)

And Bella responded:

>It's huge, actually. Surprisingly. Heidi is going to love it. But you have to help kick her out of the friend zone.

I nodded, though she couldn't see me, of course. Texted her:

>I'll make sure she wants him, but you need to help too.

Bella signed off:

>Don't worry about this end. Just worry about your part. xx

After a few more mouthfuls of cereal, I decided I needed to make a start on this project if I was to succeed in my contribution.

I texted Heidi:

>Morning, Heidi. Ready to start on our little project today?

Heidi came back fairly quickly:

>I'm ready. You're sure you want me to ask out Donny?

I was pleased she hadn't forgotten the target of our project, or that she wasn't outright refusing to do it because I'd chosen Donny.

I texted her:

>Trust me. It'll work out. And if it doesn't, we'll find someone else so that it will. What are you wearing today?

Heidi texted me back with a selfie, showing her wearing a pair of jeans and a white t-shirt that was tight enough to show a little of her shape and be sexier than she'd normally wear to orchestra practice. But I wanted her to go further, and I wanted to flex my power over her.

I told her:

>Find a skirt. Lose the bra.

I waited, maybe ten minutes. Then she sent me another picture, this time revealing a black skirt in place of the jeans. It wasn't quite as I'd hoped, dropping down below her knee, but it seemed a little more feminine than her jeans. Her t-shirt was now showing a couple of bullets on her breasts straining against the thin cotton. Now that was a little outrageous, perhaps, but I kind of wanted to shake things up.

She texted me:

>Are you sure about this?

I replied:

>You can wear a sweater or something if you get cold, right? But try not to.

She replied:

>They keep the rehearsal hall pretty warm.

I smiled at that.

>Great. You'll be fine, then. You look fantastic.

Heidi replied:

>What's the plan for today, then?

I told her:

>Just get talking to Donny somehow, smile a lot. You can ask him out for coffee if it feels right, but if not wait until next time. Show you're interested in him, though.

Heidi ended with:

>Okay, I'll let you know how it goes xx

I was quietly buzzing again as I finished up my breakfast, pulled on my jacket and headed out the door for the commute to my office. At work, if there were quiet moments safe from prying eyes, I'd pull out my phone and check out that picture of Heidi again, imagining her reception at orchestra rehearsal, and how Donny might view her.

She did look good. And it wasn't just her new clothes, her perfectly applied make-up, the fact that her lack of a bra meant her nipples were visible pressing against her t-shirt. Her renewed self-confidence just gave her a whole new stance, a poise that hadn't been there when she'd first come to me asking for help. She knew she was attractive, and it only enhanced her beauty the way she carried it.

As the time approached for Heidi to attend orchestra rehearsal, I had to fight to maintain my focus on my work.

But it wasn't long before she sent me a text message that dampened my feelings:

>Donny's off sick today. I guess I'll have to try him another time.

I replied:

>Never mind. There's no massive rush.

Heidi texted back:

>A lot of guys seem to want to check out my cleavage today. I wonder why ;-)

That made me laugh, and put a little lead back into my pencil.

I texted her:

>Enjoy the attention, they think you're gorgeous.

She replied:

>Thought I'd feel all embarrassed about it. But I think I actually like it. And I figure it's your fault because you told me not to wear a bra.

I said:

>You don't need to feel embarrassed because you look great.

Meanwhile, I texted Bella:

>So Donny's off sick today?

Bella replied:

>Don't tell anyone, but he's not really sick.

Joe: So what's the story?

Bella: Well, you gave Heidi a makeover, right? So I'm allowed to give Donny one too.

It brought back to mind how it had been for my shopping expeditions with Heidi. And how the last one had ended with Heidi going down on me in a changing booth in Selfridges.

I texted Bella:

>Don't wear him out. And I hope you're not getting him hooked on yourself instead of Heidi!

Bella replied:

>Trust me, I don't think that's possible. Nice of you to be concerned, though. Jealous of me and Donny? ;-)

I laughed at that.

*

Tuesday morning. This time I called Heidi on Skype to ask her what she was wearing to orchestra practice. When she answered, she was in her bedroom and there were clothes strewn all over her bed that suggested she'd tried on various items already.

"How do I look?"

She modeled for me in front of her laptop, twisting her body this way and that, giving me a twirl. She was wearing a gray t-shirt this time, which was once again tight enough to be highly appealing on her, and offered clear proof that she wasn't wearing a bra today, either. Her skirt was pastel pink, and actually quite stylish hugging her thighs closely, falling to above the knee to put a little more leg on show than the previous day.

"You look wonderful," I said.

She grinned. "Any improvements you want me to make?"

I thought for a moment or two. And a devilish thought sprang to mind.

"What are you wearing under the skirt?" I asked her.

She grinned, and peeled her skirt up her thighs to reveal, eventually, a white cotton thong that had a touch of lace here and there — understated, perhaps, but sexy enough, and an enormous improvement on the old Heidi's underwear choices.

I said, "Take them off."

She didn't hesitate to do as I asked, hooking her thumbs into the waistband of the thong to slip them off her hips, and down her legs to the floor. I paused for a moment or two for a gratuitous enjoyment of her bare pussy, making it look as though I was thinking about what kind of panties she should wear instead.

Then I said, "Great. You can pull your skirt back down, now."

She did so, but seemed surprised. Shocked, even. She said, "That's it? You don't want me to wear anything under it?"

I shook my head. "Not today."

She was a little shaken by that, but it wasn't as though she was wearing a mini skirt. For a moment or two, she looked as if she might snap, she might refuse my direction, reminding me that she played the cello and that neglecting to wear underwear might mean certain exposure.

Then she seemed to remind herself of her submission to me, and that she wanted to remain obedient.

"You know Donny might still be off sick today," she said.

I shrugged. "Maybe. Maybe not."

I had the feeling Donny would be back at rehearsal, though.

This time I went to work, and Heidi texted me before I'd even got into the office.

>I can't sit down on the Tube because people will see up my skirt.

That made me laugh. I texted her:

>Just keep your knees together, right? And anyway, who cares if somebody sees? As long as there aren't kids around...

About ten minutes later, Heidi sent another little text:

>I think a City guy may have got an eyeful on the District Line.

Kind of liked it ;-)

I was pleased Heidi was taking to this, enjoying the attention she was getting, instead of complaining at the dangers that she might end up flashing someone. It was hot to imagine her out and about, and at her place of work, and basically she had nothing but a piece of cloth wrapped around her lower half. She was so exposed.

I was also pleased that she kept me updated as she arrived at orchestra rehearsal.

>Feels so weird to be walking around all these people I know, and I'm not wearing any panties.

And:

>You know the guys seem much more friendly and helpful nowadays. I hope Donny doesn't think I'm out of his league now.

And:

>Smiled at Donny across the room a few times. He's looking kind of different since he was off sick.

And:

>He's got a much shorter haircut, and his clothes look different too. More... grown up, I think.

And:

>Just said hi to Donny over coffee break, you know, just friendly stuff. How are you, hope you're feeling better, etc.

And:

>He's definitely wearing some kind of new cologne. It's really nice, too. Can't stop thinking about it. Really dangerous when I'm not wearing panties ;-)

I sent her encouraging little replies, but it seemed to be mainly Bella's makeover efforts that encouraged her to keep thinking about Donny, keep finding excuses to go talk to him, to start seeing him in a slightly different way — a guy she was going to ask out.

I remembered a girlfriend I had in high school — way before Heidi, before Suzi. Vanessa. I hadn't even been particularly aware of Vanessa — she was just some other girl in class. It wasn't that she was unattractive, it was just that she wasn't really on my radar, I didn't think of her that way. Then during some party or other — one fueled by punch that someone had managed to get a bottle of vodka into — one of her friends told me that Vanessa had a little crush on me, and suggested that I should go ask her out. Since I'd been single at the time, I didn't see why not. But it struck me how differently I viewed Vanessa as I approached her in the knowledge that she was interested in me. I gave her the benefit of any doubt, I guess. I noticed her. I viewed her with optimism because she was offering me some kind of possibility. She was suddenly much more attractive in my eyes than she had been before I'd known she had a crush on me.

Perhaps a similar affect could be at work in Heidi.

A little later, I had another little text from Heidi that made the butterflies stir in my stomach:

>Okay I officially have a little wet spot on my skirt. Not sure if it's the whole thing about not wearing panties, or Donny's new look and cologne. Having to be really careful to hide it from people. Have to keep going to the bathroom to dry off.

I was laughing, but I was hard at the same time. And so I had to conceal myself at my workplace, too.

At the end of the day, I was heading out of my office early for once, and I texted her:

>You asked him out yet?

Her text came back:

>Couldn't manage it today. Finally plucked up the courage, and now he's talking to some other girl.

It was a little frustrating, but I felt the progress Heidi had made that day had been so much, it was worth celebrating. Bella, in particular, seemed to have done a stellar job giving Donny a makeover.

Speaking of the devil, I now received a text from Bella asking how it had all gone.

I replied to her:

>Great, I think. Donny's definitely caught Heidi's eye now.

Bella replied:

>We're calling him Don now, FYI. So did she ask him out?

Don, huh? Well, I suppose it was a little more alpha male than "Donny".

>Not quite, but she very nearly did. Give it a little more time.

Bella replied:

>Fantastic! He's so into her, it's sweet. Well, let me know how it goes tomorrow xx

I felt a kind of warmth inside my chest at the bringing together of two love birds. I don't know, perhaps it was being premature, no one knew if they were going to be any good together.

The thought of Heidi lusting over him, though, and that he might be some kind of boyfriend rather than a simple one night stand, actually made me desire her more and more.

I texted her:

>You going to get home some time soon?

She replied:

>Probably in an hour or so, assuming the Tube doesn't have delays.

I told her:

>I'm coming over.

I was able to get home to my apartment and grab some fresh clothes for the next day, and then hop in a taxi to get over to Heidi's place just as she would be getting home via public transport. She was surprised I'd made it so quickly, but seemed delighted I was there, flinging her arms around me to greet me with a kiss.

"You look like you've had a great day," I said.

"Could say that," she laughed. "You're a cruel man, you know that? Making me go to work without any panties."

"You loved it."

I slid my hands over her butt, and lower down I did find a slightly damp patch on her skirt, no doubt from where she'd been sitting down.

"You accidentally sit in something?" I joked.

She looked up at me and rolled her eyes playfully. "I nearly caved in," she said. "I nearly went out at lunchtime to buy underwear."

"But you didn't," I said, grabbing her, kissing her sweet lips, sliding my hands up under her skirt, pulling it up her thighs almost high enough so I could check she really hadn't put on underwear.

She batted my hands away before I could expose her right there on the street. "Are you coming in?"

I nodded, and clutching my back pack, followed her into her apartment building, and into the elevator.

"So this is nice, a midweek visit," she grinned.

"Just thought you should be rewarded for today," I said.

"I like the sound of that. Are you staying over?"

"I am." She was delighted at that, too.

In the close confines of the elevator, I could smell her perfume — she'd put on a little more than usual that day, I could sense. I could also sense a slight underlying earthiness, something I think I probably could only notice because I was hoping for it, expecting it. There was something deeply sexy to think of her getting aroused by her day going commando, flirting with Donny — Don.

We got up to her apartment and a couple of her roommates were in the living room, sitting around watching TV. Heidi said hello as we went by, and I nodded a silent greeting, but they didn't seem particularly bothered by what she was up to as we scooted on through to her bedroom.

"So you're going to ask him out tomorrow?" I asked her as she finally closed her bedroom door behind her.

"Uh-huh," she said, and she was smiling this time, no uncertainty in her bearing whatsoever.

"You actually want to now, don't you?" I laughed, leaning back against the window sill.

She shrugged, walking toward me. "I never really thought of him... you know... that way before.

"But now I've told you to," I said, pulling her to me, kissing her lips.

"I guess I see him a little differently now. I have to."

"And he got a new cologne," I pointed out.

She grinned. "And he looks... good now. Better than good."

We kissed a little more, and I could feel a little shiver, a little tremor of excitement in her. It wasn't just from having me there, it was the prospect of asking Donny out, I could tell.

"Well, you've shown what a makeover can do," I said. "Why can't Donny?"

She smiled. "He's going by 'Don' now," she said, exactly as Bella had mentioned. "I think I like it better, actually."

We kissed, and my hands stroked their way up her thighs, under her skirt, over her smooth round behind, and this time I really could confirm that she still wasn't wearing any underwear.

"So you'll definitely ask him out tomorrow?"

She nodded.

I turned her, moving around her so that she was leaning up against the window sill. Then I sank down before her, slowly crouching in front of her, pushing up the front of her skirt, revealing that delectable near-hairless pussy of hers.

"You made me a complete mess today," she said, pulling up her skirt all the way to her navel, showing me the wetness that made her mound glisten.

I leaned in, kissed her just below her navel, then down through the small patch of hair that remained on her mound, breathing in the strong scent of her arousal, tasting the lingering wetness on her smooth, warm skin.

"Sure it was me?" I joked. "Maybe it was Don?"

She sighed as my mouth reached the upper reaches of her pussy, and I slipped my tongue along her soaking channel. The air was saturated with her spicy scent, it was exhilarating.

Heidi lifted a leg over my shoulder to give me easier access, and I devoured her, indulging in the delicious wickedness of her free-flowing juices, and the sense that she had been so naughty that day, foregoing panties just because I'd told her to.

After a while she climbed up onto the window sill, and it was easier for me to service her, sucking on her slippery folds, nudging against her clit, slipping my tongue inside her, lapping at her moisture.

She held my head, her fingers teasing through my hair, moaning and sighing breathlessly as I ate her, her body writhing under me. But though she enjoyed it very much, she didn't come. I stopped before she could rise to that particular peak.

I sat on the edge of her bed, and Heidi knelt in front of me, pulling open my pants, retrieving my stiff cock. As she stretched her lips around my hard cock, she made it look as though it was giving her as much pleasure as I had licking her pussy. I suppose she probably experienced some kind of thrill at making me so hard, at turning me on so much.

"So you think you'll want to do this kind of thing with Don?" I asked her.

"Uh-huh," she said, lashing my shaft with her tongue.

"That was an about face, wasn't it?" I smiled.

She grinned up at me. "You want me to," she said, "so I'm looking forward to it."

"Good. You should."

I thought of her sucking on Don, this naughty, beautiful imp. I found myself thinking about Bella sucking on Don, too. And doing other things... Training him. The guy must have thought he'd won the lottery or something.

As I was thinking about Don taking Heidi, after harboring such a strong crush for her for so long, it made me shiver. It also made me come, and Heidi wasn't expecting that, perhaps because I'd told her I'd be rewarding her, and she hadn't yet climaxed herself.

I came, though, and she swallowed it as though it was the most delicious dessert.

We then left to go find some dinner in a restaurant somewhere, and the fact that Heidi had been unable to reach orgasm yet herself, made me start thinking about a new idea.

After a nice leisurely meal in a small Italian place a few blocks away from Heidi's apartment, we returned to head straight back to Heidi's room — and into her bed. Her roommates had been slumped in front of the TV in the living room still, as we'd moved through into Heidi's room, but they didn't seem to care, and didn't seem to recognize me as Heidi's ex in the process of sleeping with her again.

We weren't loud, though. Took things easy, kissing, stripping each other, slowly going down on each other, indulging in our nakedness, our closeness, our desire for each other. And taking on the role Heidi seemed to have given me, I controlled it all — telling her when to kiss me, when to suck on my cock, when to spread her legs and let me taste her; telling her how to lie so I could slide my hardness into her, appreciating just how wet she was after a highly arousing day; ordering her to fuck me when I wanted it, and leave off when I didn't.

And all night, before we eventually slipped off to sleep, I controlled things to such a degree that each time we ventured anywhere near an orgasm for Heidi, we paused, took things down a notch, let her feelings subside.

She didn't remark on it, even as I came all over her stomach and her breasts and she hadn't hit so much as a mini climax that night.

In the morning, though, I woke to the sound of her sighing softly, and saw that she was lying there on the bed next to me, gently touching herself between the thighs.

"No," I said. "I don't want you to do that just now."

I think ordinarily I would have been perfectly content to wake up and find her tending to herself. It was hot, and for Heidi to do it in my

presence represented great progress from how things had been while we had been married. On this occasion, though, I had a plan.

"Oh, I'm sorry..." she said, stopping.

"No need to apologize," I smiled. "I just don't want you to come right now."

"Oh." She seemed disappointed, but at the same time something seemed to click with her, she saw the logic of why I'd made love to her for so long the previous night without taking her to orgasm.

"This is an order," I said firmly. "You're not to come until you've slept with Don."

I heard her catch her breath at that one, though she tried to hide her reaction.

"In fact," I said, "I want Don to be the next person to make you come."

My heart was racing as I told her this. It was a sacrifice for me — I did so enjoy making Heidi come. But it was the ultimate in motivation, I felt.

"Whatever you say," she agreed without question.

Then Heidi had her lips around me, her hands pumping my shaft firmly, and I showed her just how unfair this new direction of mine could be, coming in her mouth, all over her face, her breasts. She didn't actually seem all that upset about being refused an orgasm until things resolved with Don. Somehow, the fact that I was controlling her, directing her in this way, made her happy. She was denied an orgasm, but the fact she was being dominated was almost compensatory in how it made her feel.

After a shower, I lay there in her bed as she figured out what to wear to another day at the orchestra.

I enjoyed her little fashion show, and in terms of her outfit gave her a simple choice: she could opt for a very small mini skirt and wear underwear, or she could choose a longer skirt and wear no panties underneath it.

On this occasion she opted for a tiny mini skirt made of a black and white printed material, and a small blue tank top that showed off her arms nicely — and also her stiff nipples.

"You do know I've got to play the cello in this, don't you?" she said, but she was quite cheerful about it.

"Of course," I smiled in return.

The way she looked as we headed out the door that morning, there was no way Don would be able to refuse her request for a coffee date.

And if she didn't go ask him out, perhaps he'd even ask her out.

Chapter Fifteen

Her text came in almost immediately when it was time for orchestra rehearsal to begin:

>He said yes to coffee! We're going to go somewhere when rehearsal breaks at 11.

I know I'd been working on setting all this up myself, but something about her quick move to ask Don out as soon as rehearsal started — and his fast acceptance of her invitation — felt like a punch in the stomach to me.

Jesus. What if I really couldn't handle Heidi going out with someone like him, someone who actually mattered to her, someone who actually stood a chance of forming some kind of meaningful relationship?

I'd been hurt by losing Suzi, way back when, and the whole marriage to Heidi had been founded on my desperate need to avoid feeling that kind of hurt again. But now was I inviting that level of pain back into my life?

I texted Heidi to let her know that she'd done well, I was very happy she'd set it up with Don. Then I texted Bella to let her know that the coffee date was happening at 11, in barely more than an hour.

Bella replied to me:

>Great! Sounds like it's all going to plan.

I felt my stomach churning, and I found myself asking whether I really wanted it all to go to plan. Maybe I should have just staked my claim to Heidi, and taken her back. At the same time, I still felt

underneath it all that I wasn't what Heidi needed long-term, I wasn't best for her. I wasn't what she was ultimately looking for.

Then 11 o'clock came, and I was nervous as Hell. I wanted things to go well for Heidi and Don, and yet part of me wanted it all to go horrendously wrong.

Half past the hour, Heidi sent a text through:

>Had a really nice time with Don. He wanted to go out for a few drinks later!

Well, I felt that churning feeling in my stomach again, but I was hard as a rock to see Heidi's text message. My Heidi was going out on a date with another guy — and a second date at that, effectively.

I texted her:

>That's wonderful! What did you guys talk about over coffee?

Heidi came back:

>Just this and that. About the orchestra. About each other. About me being polyamorous. About you.

I was surprised that they'd talked about me. What guy would go out with a girl and want to discuss her other boyfriend? I guess I would, but then I was messed up. But then Don so badly wanted to go out with Heidi, maybe he would just overlook the fact that someone else was also seeing her.

Joe: He's okay with it?

Heidi: He said it was interesting. Said if he got to go out with me, he could probably cope with it.

Joe: And you still like him?

Heidi: More than before. He's different somehow. Like he's woken up and now he's doing things properly.

Joe: And you think you'd want to go out with him? Sleep with him?

Heidi: Yes and yes.

Joe: Where and when's the date tonight?

I guess I was also surprised how quickly things were moving. That they would have coffee in the morning, and plan to see each other that night for drinks. But then again, if they were both into each other, why would they want to delay.

I was feeling jealous, I had to admit it to myself. At the same time, the jealousy did feed into the arousal I was also feeling. My Heidi was going to sleep with someone else again, and not only sleep with them but begin dating them.

Heidi texted me the name of a bar close to the Philharmonic's headquarters in Shoreditch, and that they were planning on going soon

after rehearsals ended at 6. I texted Bella the same details, and she came back with:

>Great. See you there.

Well, that was a surprise, though perhaps I should have seen it coming. But just what Bella had in mind I'd have to wait to find out, because suddenly work got a little too busy for comfort. In fact I ended up getting to the Lighthouse Bar quite late, closer to 10.

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The place was almost empty. I wandered in somewhat concerned that Heidi or Don — or both of them — would spot me coming in. Was Bella already there? I didn't even know what the arrangement was supposed to be. I presumed it wasn't some kind of fake double date where Bella and I were supposed to be there.

There was no one I recognized in the main part of the bar. I ended up going downstairs to a cavernous lower floor that was even emptier. I was heading to the bar down there when I heard a loud whisper, "Hey!"

Bella was there, sitting in a booth all on her lonesome with a large, half-filled glass of white wine. It looked wrong — she was too attractive to be sitting on her own in a bar. But then again, the place was almost deserted. Wednesday night wasn't a big one for this bar, that was for sure.

"What's going on?"

"Where've you been?"

Bella pulled me next to her in the booth, and nodded across the place to a table in the corner of the establishment, where I could see two very familiar faces. Heidi was now wearing a short crimson dress and black nylons, nursing a small glass of red wine, while Don sported the smart casual look, with a jacket over smart dark jeans. He was drinking a bottle of Heineken.

"Sorry, held at the office," I told her.

Bella shrugged it off, and reported back to me on the date. "They've been getting on like a house on fire," she said in barely more than a whisper. "About an hour ago they were sitting next to each other and sucking some serious face."

I felt my heart burn. Wow. Heidi was into him already. It was barely hours before that they first agreed to go out, and this was their second date, and Heidi had already been kissing and canoodling with Don.

The jealousy was something I was going to have to learn to deal with. But I was also seriously hard.

From where we were seated, I could see Heidi more easily than Don. Heidi's face, at least — Don had his back to us. God she looked good, all made up, a pair of silver earrings hanging from her earlobes.

"Where did she get the dress?" I asked Bella. "She go home to change?"

"It's one of her concert dresses," Bella said. "She keeps a few spares at the Philharmonic in case there's any problems on the day of a concert."

She called me to come help her get ready for her date, since you were caught at the office."

Heidi just couldn't seem to stop smiling at Don. There were a few nerves in that smile, but she seemed to be getting on with him very well indeed. As we watched, she was crossing her legs and running her hands all over the black nylon that covered them, showing them off for him.

Then as we watched, Heidi subtly lifted one of her feet and started stroking it over Don's thighs — and over his crotch.

Now she was looking around them, around the bar to make sure no one could see — except Bella and I, I was guessing, since she couldn't have failed to notice us there, even though we were hidden from Don's view.

My heart burned to see her stroking his cock through his pants with her foot. This was still virtually a first date. I suppose the two of them knew each other well enough through the Philharmonic, but still.

Another couple walked passed us all, but close to the bar itself, far enough away from Heidi and Don that they couldn't possibly see anything. Nevertheless, Heidi sat up straight to make it seem as though nothing was going on, smirking at Don for being so naughty. As soon as the other couple was gone, she was straight back to fondling Don's lap with her foot.

Bella looked at me and grinned, as though this was all her success.

"She really wants him," she said quietly. "Whatever you did to get her going, you did really well."

I smiled, thinking about how I'd forbidden Heidi from coming until something happened with Don. "It wasn't just me," I replied to the attractive blonde student. "Whatever you did with Don really got her juices flowing."

It wasn't long before Heidi was using both her feet on Don, kicking off her shoes and using her toes to massage the bulge in his pants.

We saw her glance around again, checking on their surroundings, sipping her wine more as some kind of pretense at being there than because she actively wanted to drink red wine. Then she was leaning forward, placing her hands in Don's lap, unzipping his fly.

Jesus. Was she about to do what I thought she was?

Bella elbowed me in the side, and when I looked at her, she gave me a smirk.

We watched Heidi pull Don's hard cock free from his pants. It was definitely a large one. Heidi's face seemed to light up on seeing it. We watched her stroking it in her hands, exploring its immensity, looking as

though she couldn't figure out where Don had been keeping it all these months and years, it was so large.

Then she ducked down, and took the head of his cock in her mouth. Stroking it with her lips, swirling her tongue around it, she only got it three or four inches inside her mouth, but Don groaned quietly as she sucked on him. She looked up at him with adoring eyes as she pumped his shaft in her hand and explored its tip with her mouth.

"Feeling jealous yet?" Bella was beaming ear-to-ear as we watched.

"A little," I admitted.

"You want to go stop them?"

I shook my head. "The jealousy's only a small part of it," I said, although I was playing it down a little. This wasn't the same as watching Heidi with one of her fly-by-night hook-ups. "It's more about appreciating her enjoyment of it all."

Heidi glanced around, but took Don's cock in her mouth again, satisfied no one was going to witness her — or at least, no one she didn't know about.

Bella said, "She's so naughty. I love it!"

As we watched, Don reached forward, and picked something up off the table. It was a mobile phone — Heidi's mobile phone, unless I was very much mistaken. What was he doing? I glanced at Bella, and she looked as puzzled as I was. Don was lifting up the phone, pointing it in such a way that it was obvious he was taking a picture using the phone's camera. He was taking a picture of Heidi sucking on his cock.

Bella stifled a giggle.

It was kind of hot that he'd taken a picture of Heidi sucking his cock — but why use her camera?

He took a few more snaps, but then the feeling of her mouth around his manhood was getting too much for him to concentrate on a camera phone. He planted it back on the table, and lay back in his chair again to enjoy her attention.

Bobbing down on him, Heidi was certainly enjoying herself. She withdrew from it to keep checking for any signs of danger around them, but continued massaging the huge member with both hands, as though obsessed with it.

Then Bella was whispering, "He's gonna come... he's gonna come..." And I could sense that she knew what she was talking about, having trained Heidi's new lover.

He grunted and flinched slightly, though he managed to control himself and keep from bucking like a mule. Heidi was scrambling to get

his tip inside her mouth so she could take every drop of his come. His hardness throbbed, and his body tensed, and now my Heidi was swallowing another man's seed. And Don had the volume of come to match the size of his manhood — Heidi struggled to contain all of it, with some dribbling out of the corner of her mouth.

And with that, she cleaned him fully with her eager tongue, then tucked his softening form back inside his pants, and Heidi was looking all around her, checking they were safe, glancing into my eyes, giggling and sipping her wine.

Naughty girl. God, how I wanted her.

Bella tugged on my jacket, and I saw that she was getting up from the booth. Time to go, she was indicating. Show's over.

Outside the bar, I was a little confused. "What, we're leaving?" I said.

"That's it for tonight," she nodded. "Remember they have a concert tomorrow?"

We were across the street when we saw Heidi and Don stumbling out of the bar, clutching onto each other, laughing at how wanton they'd been in the bar. Don hailed a taxi, and they both went in it.

"You okay?" Bella asked, hooking her arm in mine as we wandered back toward the nearest Tube station.

"They planning on something back at her place?" I asked. "Or his place?"

She shook her head. "No, she's just planning on going home, letting him escort her to the door. And he's not planning on going in with her."

I laughed. "You really have the inside track on both sides, huh?"

She smiled. "Heidi's my friend," she said, "and Don... well, he's my student."

"You must be very proud."

"Oh, I am. Hey, you want some company tonight?"

I looked at Bella. Even in a pair of jeans and a gray sweatshirt, she was highly tempting. I didn't want to get entangled in anything, though. Not if it might disrupt what we had going on with Heidi. Bella had a hint of pity in her eyes, as though she still couldn't quite understand why I would want Heidi to go with someone else, and yet I wasn't pushing to see other women myself.

"I'll be okay," I said.

*

I was lying in bed, beginning to fall asleep, when I heard the electronic code being typed into my apartment front door. It wasn't hard to guess it was Heidi.

"Hey," she said, strolling through to my bedroom.

She was still wearing her red dress, black nylons, fresh from her date with Don.

"I thought you might not be coming over," I smiled, glad she'd turned up.

Dropping her little bag on my bedside table, she returned my smile. "I had to see what you thought."

I nodded. "I thought you might take Don home with you. Maybe go a little further in the privacy of your own room."

She shrugged. "He seemed to want to wait — at least until our next date. I'm in no rush."

"You're not?" I joked, and she knew I was referring to the restriction of her orgasms.

"I was hoping you might want to bend the rule," she said, teasing the straps of her dress off her shoulders, allowing them to fall to the ground. Underneath her dress she was wearing a bra and panties made of red-and-white checked material, finished with a little white lace here and there. Girlish, somehow innocent. Sexy. But then part of the appeal was that I was seeing her in her underwear, and Don had only seen her in her dress.

"Because you've done so well with Don?"

"Something like that."

She crawled onto the bed. Seeming a little cautious until I took her into my arms, and almost threw her onto her back, to lock my lips against hers. Kissing her, sucking on those lips that had stretched around another man's cock earlier that night. Tasting the slightly odd flavor of her mouth, sensing a hint of Don's cologne on her.

"You like him?"

"Yes," she laughed, a touch giddy. She hadn't expected to feel so strongly about Don. She was in some kind of loved-up daze. Strangely, it appealed to me, turned me on, even if she was clearly thinking about Don and not me.

"You more than like him," I stated.

"I think so," she couldn't contain her smile.

I think I was a little taken aback by just how clear it was that she felt strongly about him. "Do you think you might fall for him?" I asked her.

"I... I don't know..." she said, her expression faltering a little, a little trepidation creeping in. "I think I could."

It surprised me how relaxed I was about it. I kissed her mouth, and down her neck, over her chest. Remembering how she'd been in that bar, sucking on a guy's cock in public. I slipped the strap of her bra off her shoulder, then the other, kissing my way over her chest, freeing her small but delectable breasts, taking her stiff little nipples into my mouth.

"Do you want me to stop seeing him?" she asked me, stroking my head with a hand as I resumed kissing her mouth, sucking on her soft, sweet lips.

I was impressed at her offer, at her commitment to me, that she would be willing to give up what she might have with Don.

"Of course not," I said. "I like that you feel strongly about him. That you might be falling for him."

She smiled, and kissed me affectionately.

"He's good for you," I said.

"You're good for me."

"Not like that. That's... it's wonderful, what you have with Don."

For a long while, it seemed, we were just kissing, touching. Sucking on each other's lips, our hands running over each other's bodies. She lost her bra, I lost my t-shirt, but that was about it. It felt as though I was working through her having feelings for another man. Resigning myself to it. Celebrating it.

Heidi, it seemed, was nervous about whether I still wanted her.

I held her. I slid my hands all over her smooth skin. I tangled my lips with hers. I showed her well enough that I wanted her, that what she had with Don only made me want her more.

We murmured this and that to each other as we kissed and touched, and I was teasing her as much as she was teasing me, because I knew she hadn't come yet.

"You enjoyed sucking his cock?"

"Uh-huh."

"You like his cock?"

"Definitely. It's... nice... and so big."

"You think about maybe taking that between your legs? Inside..."

"Can't stop."

She climbed onto me, riding me but without taking off her panties, without having me inside her. Just rubbing herself against me, enjoying how hard she was making me.

"I've been going crazy because you won't let me come," she said.

"Then you'd better get Don into bed quickly," I replied. "Because he's the next man to make you come."

"And if I'm very good to you?" she said with a mischievous smirk, moving down and off me now, spreading her hands over my hardness, stroking it through my boxer shorts.

"A rule's a rule," I insisted.

She ducked down and teased the tip of my cock with her mouth through the thin cotton of my boxer shorts. I reached down and was able to stroke her hair once, twice, before she edged away, peeling my boxer shorts down over my thighs to reveal my stiff cock.

She looked up at me as she licked my full length, and I said, "You can't change my mind."

"Fine," she said, sucking my tip into her mouth briefly, once, twice. "But you know what you're doing... it means every time I'm in Don's presence..."

"Yes?"

"Well, let's just say I'm soon in need of a change of underwear."

I laughed at that. Heidi sank down on my hardness, her long hair trailing around her face, almost hiding her as she sucked on me, until she brushed it back behind her ear.

"Why did Don want to take pictures of you sucking on his cock on your phone?" I asked her as she bobbed down on my shaft.

She withdrew with a smacking of her lips and said somewhat breathlessly, "He told me he wants me to accidentally show you some time," she grinned.

"Accidentally?"

"You know, when we're together, I'd be casually messing with my phone and they'd accidentally come up on screen."

I was intrigued, and even leaned over to the bedside table to pick up her little black bag, and retrieve her phone from it.

"Why would he want me to accidentally catch sight of you going down on him?" I handed her the phone, and she dutifully tapped in the security code before handing it back.

She smiled, shrugged. "I think he's not entirely happy I'm seeing someone else as well as him."

"He's trying to mess with me?"

I touched the photo app on Heidi's phone, and up popped an image showing her lips locked around a large, stiff cock. Don's. Despite having seen her sucking on him, it made me catch my breath to see it so close up now, in such detail. The joy on her face, the strange obscenity of someone else's massive cock stretching her lips, sinking into my Heidi's mouth.

"You don't have to look," she said.

"It's... kinda hot," I smiled. "So he didn't object to you being poly... because he wanted to go out with you... but now he gets to date you... he wants to get rid of me, that it?"

She shrugged again, but nodded.

I laughed, "He obviously doesn't understand where I'm coming from if he thinks pictures of you and him getting intimate are going to put me off."

Yet underneath, I was mildly impressed at Don. He wasn't like me, not at all. He wasn't going to live with Heidi seeing other people for long. But the way he seemed to want to possess her... well, that seemed more like what Heidi wanted in a man than someone who was going to sit back and accept her seeing two masters.

I enjoyed looking at the pictures of Heidi sucking on him a while longer, as she knelt between my thighs and sucked on me. I had the advantage over him for now: I could fuck her already and she seemingly was willing to obey me without question.

"Come here," I said, dropping the phone onto the bedside table, urging her back up my body. "Take the rest of it off."

She stood over me, lifting one leg and then the other to peel off her pantyhose, and then slipped off her panties. I picked them up from beside me, held them up to my face. They were drenched.

"See? I told you," she said. "That's what I'm like all day now, if Don's around."

"Down," I ordered her, and she quickly complied, dropping down over me, taking a hold of my cock, slipping the tip inside her hot, wet pussy.

"Oh..." she moaned as she sank down on me, taking my full length inside her. She lay over me, pressing her breasts to my chest, her lips to mine.

"You know you might make me come any moment," she said, slowly stirring her hips to move my hardness inside her.

"And if you do, I'll refuse you permission to go out with Don on a date," I said.

She pouted. "That's so unfair."

But she kissed me all the same, sucking on my lips passionately.

We didn't so much fuck as hold each other, my hard cock sunk deep inside her, stirring a little, but not really thrusting. I just wanted to feel her like that, knowing that I could and Don could not, not yet.

She sat up, and tried to ride me, but as soon as I felt her building up to something, I held her, stopped her. I owned her, still, even if there was the possibility of ownership passing to another man. I held her. I touched her. I indulged in her naked body, appreciating her smooth skin, her soft hair, her hard nipples, her soaking wet pussy.

I was taking my fill, but not letting her have hers.

She turned around to lay on me and suck my cock, and I could press my face to her pussy, and taste her as I wanted. But I kept close control on her, making sure she never quite reached boiling point.

I entered her again, as she lay on her back on my chest, and I could sweep my hands all over her body to luxuriate in her curves — but my cock remained still inside her. I did not give her release.

I came toward my end, but she hovered in one place, without reaching hers.

By the end, she was begging me, "Please... please let me..."

But I shook my head. I had her kneel between my legs, take my hardness back in her mouth, and this time I came and she swallowed.

"You'll see Don soon," I insisted. "You'll go out with him. Then afterwards, you'll take him home and you'll sleep with him. That's when you can come."

She did as I told her, she was a good girl. But the next day she texted me three times to tell me Don kept looking at her across the orchestra during their concert, and that she'd had to change her underwear at the interval for fear that others around her would be able to tell that she was so soaking wet for him.

Once the afternoon concert was over, Don was due to take her out once again. This time I was certain that my motivational push would drive her into bed with him.

Chapter Sixteen

Bella and I were in a restaurant together that evening, monitoring the situation, but this time neither Heidi nor Don knew that we were there. We weren't so much stalking them, watching their every move. We were just checking in on their progress every now and then.

We even talked about other things than Heidi and Don while we had our own meal and several nice glasses of wine. Bella was in her third year at university as it turned out. I mentally worked out that it might mean she was as young as 21, though she seemed a little more mature than that. She was engaged in a biochemistry degree, and even had good prospects for achieving a high grade.

But our conversation did come back time and time again to the whole sharing thing.

"And you don't think you're a little... you know... bi-curious?" she asked at one point.

"I don't think so." I sipped my wine, having to think about some of her more probing questions. I said, "I guess society expects a guy like me to freak out that another man's been with my woman. That there's any kind of hint that she's been with someone else: lingering cologne, a little remaining sweat, and so on. But it doesn't bother me. I kind of like that there's evidence that she's been with someone else. That doesn't make me bisexual."

"No?"

"I have no interest in sleeping with a guy. Doing anything with him. My focus is completely on Heidi. I just find it erotic that there's a guy

with her, showing her a good time."

It was cathartic talking to her, I was surprised just what a good time I had with her. She was impressed at me, I guess. Impressed at the fact that I wanted Heidi, and that I also wanted her to have other men. I think that I liked that I impressed her. What that meant about how I felt about her, as a result, I wasn't sure.

"You think you'd ever want to marry her?"

"No, I don't think so. I don't think it would work out."

"But you'd be okay if she wanted to marry someone else?"

"Of course."

"Even if it meant you couldn't see her any more?"

"If she was truly happy with him, I'd be happy for her."

"But you'd feel bad about losing her."

"Of course I would."

"So why do you put yourself through the whole possibility of giving her up to someone like Don?"

I wasn't always able to give her a simple answer, of course.

Across the restaurant, Heidi and Don seemed to be getting on like a house on fire, laughing at each other's jokes, engaged in each other's conversation, totally absorbed in each other's eyes. They looked good fresh from their concert — Heidi in a sexy little black dress, Don looking dapper in a tuxedo. I was fully aware I was using Bella's company as a way to distract myself from worrying about how well Don was doing in seducing Heidi.

"Do you think you'd ever want someone other than Heidi?"

"Of course."

"You'd want to get married to someone other than Heidi?"

"Uh-huh," I said. "I think I want to get married some day."

"What would your wife be like?"

"How should I know?"

"I mean, would you want her to... you know... see other guys."

"I think so. I mean, I don't think I'm going to change. I'm assuming five, ten years ahead I'll still find it interesting to have a strong connection with someone, but also encourage her to see other guys as well."

When Don and Heidi left the restaurant, so did we. When they took a walk together, arm-in-arm, along the South bank of the Thames, we went too, walking at a distance. We didn't need to be there. We just wanted to know what the score was. It was like watching sports: we

wanted to know what was going on, we wanted to know if Don was going to take Heidi somewhere to sleep with her.

Both Bella and I seemed to want to see our little project taken to its full conclusion, and that meant my Heidi sleeping with her Don.

After a drink in the Swan by Shakespeare's Globe, it was getting late, and we carefully followed the new lovers out until they got themselves a taxi.

"There it is," Bella said, stopping me as I tried to grab another taxi to follow them.

"Don't you want to — "

She shook her head. "Let them go. I think we can assume we've won. It's going to happen."

"I suppose so."

"You okay?" she asked me.

I nodded. She smiled, and stepped up to me. She surprised me by putting her hand on my crotch, finding almost immediately that I was somewhat stiff.

"You are okay," she smiled, a little apologetically for her uncouth behavior.

Then my phone buzzed with a text message, from Heidi no less.

>Is it okay if we go to your place? My roommates are in tonight, and Don has his brother staying at his place.

I showed Bella the message. She hailed a taxi. So much for letting them go.

I waited until we were a good way toward my apartment in the taxi before responding to Heidi. I was assuming she wasn't just going to go over there and wait there for me to reply. I told her she was welcome to make use of my apartment, and that I hoped the two of them had a good time.

Bella and I arrived at my place well before Heidi and Don. I felt a little guilty about being there, but the curiosity, the strong desire to know exactly what happened between Heidi and Don, kept me on track, showing Bella in, showing her the space behind the curtains in my bedroom, which was so ideal for hiding out — even when it was two people hiding out.

If tonight had been like watching sports, then right now we wanted to watch this particular match live. We wanted to follow every little detail.

I wanted to see Heidi make love to Don. I wanted to see her fall for Don. Perhaps it was simply about redeeming myself, absolving myself

for treating her so badly in our own long-term relationship. Perhaps it was just a turn-on to know that a woman I cared deeply about was going to have a wonderful experience with this man.

*

"Shh!!!"

I was standing there behind the curtains and Bella was crouching beneath me, trying to find a comfortable, stable place from which she could watch, but she kept shaking the curtains and giggling.

We heard the codes being entered into the electronic keypad outside my front door.

Bella, thankfully, managed to quieten down and be still.

We could see all the way out of the bedroom to the front door, where Heidi now entered, followed by Don. She was wearing her little black dress, Don his tuxedo, looking good more for each other than the concert that had taken up much of their day. Heidi dropped her little handbag on the table inside the front door, and now Don pulled her to him.

Heidi's dress didn't remain on long. Don pushed her against the wall beside the front door, claiming her lips with his own, wrenching the dress from her body without concern for its welfare. Heidi certainly wasn't stopping him.

Now she stood there in black high-heeled shoes, black lace-topped stockings, garters, a black lace thong and matching bra. She looked stunning. I'd never seen her in such towering high heels. She was also wearing something black around her neck — a collar, if I was correct. Again, something I'd never seen her wear before. I'll bet she wasn't wearing it at the concert.

I saw Don reach for Heidi's handbag, and as he had on their previous date, he now pulled out her phone. There in the hallway, he had her pose for a picture in her lingerie, acting the catalog model in her black lace, her stockings, her garters, her high heels.

They were laughing together about something. Heidi was telling him, "No, don't!"

But whatever it was she didn't want him to do — I got the feeling he'd done it anyway.

Heidi snatched the phone from his grasp, and now fiddled with it herself. I wondered if she was deleting the pictures he'd taken. I guess it was always a risk these days that something like that would end up spreading all over the Internet.

Don took the phone back from her and slipped it into the pocket of his pants. He turned her around, kissing her shoulder as he ran his hands

all over her body, exploring her curves, her waist, her behind, his hands sweeping around to cover her breasts and slip them out of her bra. God, they were good together. They had stunning natural chemistry. The jealousy burned inside me, though the arousal was stronger.

My hardness was throbbing in my pants, and it took me a while to notice that Bella was leaning back against me, pressing her head against my erect cock. Even if I wanted to I could hardly object to that. I couldn't really move if I wanted to avoid being caught.

My phone buzzed in my pocket. Bella actually reached inside my pocket to hand it to me, since she was right down there. She signaled that perhaps I should turn it off — and she was right, even on silent the sound of the vibrate function might give us away. I took it from her, but before I could turn it off, I saw the text message that Heidi had sent when fiddling with her phone moments before:

>Sorry, I didn't mean to send that.

I was intrigued. Tapping in the security code, I accessed my text messaging app and saw that before she'd sent that particular apology, she'd also sent me a photo — or Don had sent me a photo using her phone — of her standing in my hallway wearing sexy black lace lingerie.

It made my pulse quicken, my cock tingle and throb, to see her in that picture. I showed Bella, and she covered her mouth with a hand to stifle laughter. It did actually turn me on that Don wanted to accidentally show me that he was with my woman, that she was going to sleep with him.

Now I looked over, and Don appeared to be holding something black in his hands as he held Heidi. It took me a while to work out what it was. When he encircled Heidi in his arms, and now wrapped it around her wrists, I saw that it was some kind of rope. Heidi let him bind her wrists. She didn't object to him forcing her down on her knees. She loved his control. Her eyes were filled with desire for him.

Don stroked her long, dark hair out of her face and leaned down to kiss her mouth, and then perching on the chair in my hallway, he took one of her breasts, and her hard nipple into his mouth. He pushed her down onto her hands and knees, his hands running all over her back, her behind, assessing her as though she was some kind of beast in an auction, or slave in a market.

For a while he was just exploring her, holding her by the rope that bound her wrists, kissing her, pressing his face to her flesh and breathing her in. Stroking her hair, her breasts, her thighs, her butt.

Then he stood, and urged her up onto her feet again with that rope. He led her through to the bedroom, standing her by the bed, kissing her mouth, her breasts, squeezing and kneading her buttocks, framed by the black garters she was wearing.

This wasn't just a hook-up. This wasn't merely a one night stand. This was two new lovers taking their time to explore one another — or at least he was taking his time exploring her, since he was clearly in it for the control just as much as she was in it to be controlled. He'd lusted after her for a long while, and now he'd been granted what he'd wanted so badly, he was going to make the most of it.

I was so hard watching them together. This was so much more powerful an experience than watching her with a random fling. Bella was quietly stroking my granite-hard shaft through my pants with her head, rubbing up against it like a cat marking its territory. And there was nothing I could do.

Don urged Heidi back down onto her knees, perching on the edge of the bed himself to continue exploring her breasts with his mouth, her neck, her mouth. Still holding her by that rope, as though she were his possession, not his lover. He sucked on her breasts and reached between her thighs to caress her mound, to touch her sex. I would bet serious money that she was already soaking wet for him.

Heidi was already breathing deeply, moaning, I'd never seen her as into it as she was with this guy. It was both heart-wrenching and unbelievably thrilling at the same time to me. She was incredibly beautiful, and so completely unlike the Heidi who had turned up on my doorstep asking for my help.

And though I did my best, I had never owned her in the same way as Don was owning her right now. His presence, his attitude, his confident command of her person were all so natural, so right, and so what Heidi craved. It made everything I'd done to dominate her seem like some kind of b-movie acting effort.

Was this the real Don? How had Bella turned Donny into this man so quickly?

As he continued to stroke her between the thighs, Heidi was sucking on his mouth and reaching for his crotch. Don broke away from her to sit back on the bed a little further, then he was unfastening his belt while Heidi caressed his bulge through his pants.

She climbed onto the bed, kneeling over him, pulling out his hardness, her fingers curling around its ample girth, her lips parting over its tip. The way she was over him, Heidi had her butt pointed at us,

showing just how little of her sex was covered by the black lace thong she wore. It was almost a g-string. I could see just how wet she was. I could smell just how wet she was.

Heidi sank down on him, and it seemed to me that with every moment she was getting accustomed to his size, getting more and more of his length in her mouth. She was tending to him affectionately, it seemed to me. It was more than the simple excitement of experiencing a cock other than mine. She was moving with more grace than I'd seen before, she was moaning and sighing more than ever, showing how much she was enjoying being with Don.

Was she slipping away from my grasp? It was a frightening prospect, and yet the bottom line was that I wanted her to find someone else, I wanted this to happen. This was like some weird rollercoaster ride — I was both terrified and at the same time filled with adrenaline, experiencing the biggest rush ever.

Don coaxed her up onto her feet again, and I started feeling this strange pressure: it was the realization that this was it, he was going to fuck her. I felt that once he did that, somehow the transaction would be complete, he would own her. Looking at Heidi as she stood, as Don stood with her, turning her on her high heels as he kissed her chest, as he removed her bra, it seemed to me that Heidi was experiencing the same realization I was, that this was a big step for her. For us.

Don removed his jacket and his hands were all over her topless body again as they kissed some more. So much kissing, more so than with any other guy. It really did heighten the tension for me. He turned her as his hands closed around her bare breasts, as though he was purposefully showing her off to me, taunting me now that he had her.

He kissed her shoulders and removed the rest of his clothes. I was impressed at how toned he was. Don, even as harmless Donny, had been a regular gym user. My guess was he had probably felt it was his best way to entice a lover, before winning the lottery in scoring Heidi. Naked, his huge member so disturbingly apparent, he perched on the edge of the bed and began planting kisses around Heidi's hips, over her behind, enjoying the sight of her in those stockings and garters.

Then he was pulling her onto his lap, her stocking-clad legs moving over his with a sigh of nylon on skin, her knees slipping down to rest beside his hips, her lace-clad pussy crushing up against his large erection.

I caught my breath as I saw her reposition herself slightly, pull her thong aside, then sink slowly down on his hard cock. My stomach felt

squeezed by some invisible vice: he was inside my Heidi. And at the same time my heart raced, my own hardness throbbed.

Heidi opened her mouth wide and moaned, cried, whimpered as he slid that great thing into and out of her pussy, stretching her, filling her completely, making her feel so desired, so sexy, so unbelievably satisfied. It was the biggest argument in favor of this experience for me, getting to witness her like this, detached, independent. Appreciating the beauty of a woman being fucked to within an inch of her life.

There was no condom, no barrier between them. Heidi felt safe with Don — well, he hardly had a reputation for being a ladies' man, he'd been quietly pining for Heidi for so long he probably hadn't slept with anyone for months — and Don felt safe with Heidi, it seemed.

Only as the initial shock of seeing her fucking him wore off, and I became a little more accepting of the sight of her moving on his lap, pumping his length with her tight pussy, did I come to notice that my own cock was free of my fly and enclosed in a female hand.

I looked down and Bella was smiling up at me as she stroked my hardness, her other hand was under her skirt, tucked between her thighs, no doubt stroking herself as we watched Heidi riding her new man. I didn't stop her. It felt good, and it seemed like more effort to stop her than it was worth. I liked that she was enjoying the sight of Heidi and Don as much as I was. It made her interesting to me that she had somehow gotten involved in this unconventional arrangement of ours. It made her attractive to me, in a way her striking good looks had failed to do thus far.

Bella was no longer the blandly perfect blonde, there was a little kink to her. So she could play with my hardness if she liked. For now. Until I figured out just what was going on.

It wasn't long before Don rolled Heidi over on the bed, taking more charge as he squeezed his huge cock inside her, lying over her and between her thighs, dominating her completely, his muscles flexing as he thrust into her, a slight sheen of perspiration glistening all over his body.

He rolled her over, urged her up onto her hands and knees. He didn't dive straight back in, however. He reached for something on the floor, and I couldn't quite understand what he was doing. Then he was there, Heidi's phone in his hands again, and as he climbed onto the bed and knelt between her legs, slowly sliding that huge great cock inside her from behind, he was taking pictures again.

He wanted me to accidentally stumble onto the evidence that he was fucking Heidi. It made me smile.

After a little while he dropped the phone, however. He had more pressing matters to focus on. He grabbed her hips and pounded into her from behind, making her cry out as he fucked her hard, deep, a real beast with his beauty. It was almost hypnotic to watch him piston into her, Heidi rocking back and forth from his impacts, the grunting and groaning interspersed with the dull thud of his body slamming against hers.

Heidi collapsed on the bed after a while, but Don kept on fucking her, covering her body with his, rocking the whole bed as he plunged between her buttocks, making her squirm, making her shiver, making her shudder under him.

Heidi came with a great cry as he pumped into her. She came again as he turned her over and thrust into her missionary-style once again. She came as he slowed and spooned with her, lying beside her in such a way that we voyeurs behind the curtain could see everything of their copulation, his big hard shaft disappearing inside her reddened, swollen pussy time and time again. It seemed to me she was getting her own back on me for restricting her orgasms. Well, she had been told to wait until Don made her come. Now he was making her come again and again.

Finally he thrust into her as she lay back on the bed, clutching one of her thighs as he powered into her, and it was clear to all that he was approaching his own peak. He didn't remain inside her, however. Pulling out, he tugged on his own shaft a few times, and as he grunted and groaned above her, his huge cock erupted in his hands, streaming white cream all over her body — her upper chest, her breasts, her stomach, her panties, her pussy. It just kept on coming, jet after jet spraying out over her, an impressive volume.

It was as though he was marking her as his property. And Heidi looked down on her come-streaked body and smiled contentedly, loving the sight of him firing his seed all over her, adoring the way he used her and now seemed to possess her.

I stopped Bella from continuing to massage my own hardness: now that Heidi and Don had slowed to a halt, pausing to take it all in, I was concerned they might hear Bella stroking me, or that she might make me moan to the point that Don would discover us. The blonde student nodded her acceptance, and begrudgingly relinquished her hold on my hardness.

Don was leaning over Heidi, and the two of them were smiling as they gazed into each other's eyes, besotted, recovering their breaths in between more kisses.

We watched Don lie beside her on the bed, saying to her, "Your other boyfriend make you feel like that?"

Heidi said, "No, not like that." Smiling at him. It made me burn inside. But I couldn't deny that the two of them had the kind of chemistry I could never concoct with Heidi, as much as I'd enjoyed being with her, as much as I desired her now that she was as insatiable as she had become.

"When are you seeing him next?" Don asked as they lay there.

"I don't know. Maybe tomorrow. It's up to him."

"It shouldn't be. It should be up to me."

I felt the hairs rise on the back of my neck, and yet underneath the subconscious rivalry I suddenly felt with Don, the rational part of me was rejoicing. Let him have her. I'd always said she needed someone better than me.

"It should be," Heidi said, quietly rubbing his come into her skin over her breasts, her stomach.

Don said, "I want to see you tomorrow night."

"Okay..."

"Do whatever you need to make him reschedule."

"I'll try."

"No trying. I'll see you tomorrow."

I looked at Bella, and she smiled and shrugged, as though to tell me silently that this had been how I'd wanted it. I'd wanted her to be with Don. I'd suggested that he appeal to her desires by being the alpha male, by bringing out her submissive side. Who could have told that underneath the surface, the inner Donny had been an alpha male all along? At least sexually.

At last, we watched Don pick himself up from the bed, to pull on his clothes.

"You can stay if you like," Heidi said, and it made me feel that she'd forgotten about me, forgotten that I was here.

Don said, "I know." It made me think of Han Solo in Return of the Jedi, answering Princess Leia when she told him she loved him. But nevertheless Don continued dressing, pulling on his shirt, his pants, his shoes, his jacket.

"I'm tired," he said as he dressed, "you're tired. Probably best we get some sleep, right?"

"Uh-huh."

"I'm going to want some rest before I see you again. Before I fuck you again."

Heidi's smile was plastered all over her face at the thought of Don fucking her again. Well, wasn't that the whole point of all this? Making her happy. And despite the green monster inside me, the jealousy burning away in my stomach, I did feel an intense arousal at knowing I was making her happy by bringing this man into her life.

"Maybe you should come to my place tomorrow night," Don said as a near-naked Heidi escorted him back out into the living room, over to the apartment front door. The way he said it made me feel like somebody was unclipping the safety wire just before I was to walk a tightrope.

"That would be nice," she said.

I guess if I wanted her to get into a new long-term relationship, I'd have to accept giving her up.

They were kissing again on the doorstep. Don opened the door and thought nothing of holding Heidi there even though she was wearing nothing more than stockings, garters and her panties. He seemed to take pleasure in the risk of a neighbor happening by, seeing him with her. And Heidi wasn't objecting, either. She just wanted him, wanted to be possessed by him.

"See you tomorrow," Don said as they finally parted.

"Uh-huh."

"You should wear that short skirt again at rehearsal," he said. "Or something like it. You looked good in that."

"Okay."

She was all smiles as the door finally closed between them.

Chapter Seventeen

I was hesitant, I have to admit. I froze as Heidi closed the door on Don, leaving her alone out there, no doubt ready for me to approach her. It was something about following on from such an experience that stopped me. I felt like a musician having to go on stage and play to a stadium crowd after the Rolling Stones or Pink Floyd or U2 or The Who had just blown everyone's mind.

It was Bella who pushed me out from behind the curtain. I looked back at her and she signaled with both hands: go on, go on. Smirked at me, knowing I was virtually drooling with lust having seen Heidi fucked so powerfully right in front of me.

"What about..." I started to say.

She shook her head. "Distract her. I'll show myself out," she said. "I'll be fine."

I nodded, and walked cautiously out of the bedroom — cautious, because I didn't want Don to suddenly knock to come back in, changing his mind about staying with Heidi, maybe sleeping overnight.

Heidi was leaning back against the front door now, gazing at me as I came out to her, the biggest smile ever plastered over her lips. Freshly fucked by someone who actually meant something to her, she was irresistible to me.

I glanced down, and decided that if I slumped down onto the couch, and Heidi came to me, she would be facing away from the bedroom door, leaving Bella an opportunity to make a clean getaway. Oh, I could

probably have opened up about Bella being here too, watching the two of them with me. I just didn't want any complications just now.

I got comfortable on the sofa and Heidi surprised me a little by dropping down onto all fours, slinking her way toward me across the floor like some kind of panther, reveling in how I was looking at her, how much I wanted her after her experience with Don.

"Hi," I said as she came near.

"Hi," she grinned.

"You have a good time?"

"Oh yes."

"You look so good," I said, and I really couldn't believe how good she looked in those stockings and garters. Heidi, who I'd stopped seeing as even remotely attractive as our marriage had run aground, was like some sizzling hot model or actress to me now. I'd pick her over some gorgeous celebrity.

"You still want to see me after seeing me with Don?" she said, joking or not.

"I want to see all of you," I said.

She climbed up onto the wooden coffee table in front of me, knocking off a few magazines, a drinks coaster, whatever. Posing for me, loving how sexy she felt, how sexy I obviously thought she was. She perched on the edge of the table and started fondling her breasts for me, running her hands all over her body, touching her pussy through her black lace thong.

It was like some sex show. She pulled her thong aside and started touching herself in front of me, stretching her stocking-clad legs apart so I could see everything.

"You want me to go take a shower?" she said.

"No."

"Even though I'm really, really dirty?"

I couldn't help but pull out my manhood, stroke it as I watched her teasing me. I wasn't going to sit back for long, though.

"I like it when you're really, really dirty," I said, slumping down onto my knees in front of her, leaning into her, between her legs. Kissing her beside her pussy, around it, breathing in that strong, dangerous scent of sex that now surrounded her.

Tasting her sopping wet pussy.

"You don't care that he was just fucking me?" she asked, and she knew the answer well enough after our past experiences. She was just teasing me.

"Nope."

She sighed as I sucked on her pussy lips, as I delved my tongue in her soaking groove, lapping up her wicked tangy juices. What can I say? I'm a pervert, no doubt. She was so gorgeous after sex — her flushed cheeks, those stiff nipples, the hint of perspiration over her body, in her hair.

She held her panties aside for me, and I ate her with abandon, making her moan, making her pant. Making her come, now that it was allowed.

I sat back on the couch and it was her turn to go on her knees, brushing her long brown hair out of her face, sliding her hands up my thighs, pushing her face up just next to my perpendicular manhood.

"Can I suck on it, please?" she asked.

I smiled, and reached out to stroke her cheek, then press my hard cock against it. I rubbed my length all over her face, and she was moaning, loving my control, loving how I used her. I surprised myself by how well I fit into her fantasy. Well, she'd fit into mine well enough.

"Lick it," I said, and she complied, exploring my length with her tongue as I ran my fingers through her hair.

It wasn't long before I guided her mouth to the tip of my cock, and had her suck it into her mouth. Then I was holding her head as she went down on me, keeping firmly in control, fucking her face.

It was like I was trying to out-do Don in the dominance stakes. She was loving every moment.

"Take your panties off," I ordered her but I wasn't letting her go any time soon. She had to do it while continuing to suck on me — she struggled a little, but ultimately achieved it. She handed me her underwear so that I could press it to my face, appreciate her scent. She'd been fucked in these, fucked by another man.

I didn't want to end prematurely, though.

I had Heidi crawl into the bedroom, climb onto the bed. With her knees on the edge of the bed, she pushed up her behind, and I bent down to press my mouth to her succulent, virtually hairless pussy. I couldn't get enough of how wet she was, of how red and swollen she was after being fucked by such a large cock.

I slid my finger inside her, but I wanted more than that. I turned her over onto her back, and while still standing on the floor next to the bed, pulled her body to me so I could ease my cock inside her dripping sex.

She purred, and I groaned at the feeling of gliding inside her, her pussy so slippery, so hot. And I swear I wasn't imagining things: Don had

stretched her out. It felt different being inside her, though it still felt good.

It nearly made me blow just to realize what it was.

"Feel good?" I asked her.

"Oh my God.... So good..."

"Even after Don?"

She grinned. "You know it does."

I kissed her as I thrust into her, but broke away to focus on penetrating her, powering into her, taking out on her pussy what she'd made me feel like as she'd fucked another man. She whimpered, she cried, she came surprisingly easily — and Heidi had never been a faker.

Unlike any time she'd been with a stranger before me, it seemed that Don had primed her, he'd gotten her to such a state that she was camped out on the edge of orgasm.

I swear she came three times just while I was fucking her on that bed, moaning like I'd never heard her before, saying over and over, "Oh my God... oh my God... oh my God..."

I held her thighs together and plunged into her, and the adrenaline made me feel like some kind of sexual god. I turned her over, fucked her like some untamed animal, and she was screaming the house down.

I had to wonder what my neighbors might think.

We were both blaspheming like sailors by the time it came for me to grab hold of her hips and ram myself deep into her, letting loose the dogs of war. After Don had sprayed his seed all over her body, once again I felt myself silently amused that I was topping him another time — coming deep inside her.

But as the high flushed through my body, and the two of us hit the shower, I didn't feel any real need to try to compete with Heidi's new man.

Let them be together.

It actually shocked me just how comfortable I was feeling that she might prefer Don, that he was better for her, that she'd never ever looked at me the way she looked at him, even on our wedding day.

*

We fell asleep together on the bed, lying in each other's arms, a fresh dose of my come inside Heidi. But after what couldn't have been long, I was woken up by a loud, heavy click from out in the rest of the apartment.

It took me a few moments to realize it had been the front door closing. It took my dozy but panicked mind another moment to figure it probably wasn't thieves breaking into my apartment.

Bella had just left — I was sure of it. Had she really been here all this time? I'd not given much thought to her once things had started getting hot and heavy with Heidi. I guess I'd assumed she'd left while I was feasting on Heidi's post-coital body, or caught up in her sucking ferociously on my hard cock. She hadn't.

I pulled myself out of bed, being careful to avoid waking Heidi. I pulled the curtains aside, and stepped out onto the small balcony. I didn't really care that anyone might see me naked — it was late, very late.

I peered over the edge and waited, and sure enough not so long after my apartment front door had clicked shut, there she was, blonde hair streaming out behind her as she strode out of the building, and climbed into a dark Mercedes. Uber taxi, no doubt.

She'd stayed to take in the whole show, the naughty girl. I was certain I'd given her plenty of opportunities to slip out of the apartment while I was with Heidi — but she'd remained steadfast behind the curtains in my bedroom.

As I stepped back in through the curtains, I stepped on something. Stooping to pick it up, I found it was a pair of panties — a black thong, to be precise. Soaking wet and still warm from her body.

I breathed in her scent, and for perhaps the first time, I felt a flicker of desire for her that hadn't been there before.

As I lay back down with Heidi, and we slowly succumbed to sleep, for the first time in a long time I was thinking of someone else. I did wonder if it might be some kind of subconscious self-protection mechanism, because deep down I recognized that Heidi was more attuned to Don than she was to me — that the two of them had a good chance of becoming something.

However, whether or not my subconscious was trying to tear me away from Heidi before she hurt me as I had been hurt by Suzi, I couldn't deny that I was feeling something for Bella, and it wasn't just because

she was the only other female regularly involved in my life just then. I liked that she was fascinated in the whole arrangement I had with Heidi. She'd been obviously turned on by the experience of watching Heidi with Don — but it wasn't just because of the sex going on in front of us, she was actively taken by the idea that I was allowing Heidi to see this other man, and enjoying the physical act of her infidelity.

If Heidi's big fantasy was to be controlled by another man, Bella's seemed to be being shared by her man.

I was beginning to believe that she was more aligned to my desires than Heidi was.

Chapter Eighteen

It was a few more weeks before I saw Bella again. I texted her a couple of times updating her on how Heidi was doing with Don, but it seemed merely polite, and her replies were simply thankful I was keeping her in the loop — as though it was some kind of business relationship.

I was able to watch Heidi with Don again a couple more times, when she brought him round to my place, but on that final time I listened to them lying there, post-coitus, and Don said to her: "I don't think we should come here again."

"Okay..." Heidi replied, sounding as though she was trying to think of a reason to object.

"It is your husband's place. Ex-husband's."

"It just has a really nice big bed, that's all," Heidi said.

Don said, "I'll buy a new bed, okay? A huge bed. Biggest you've ever seen."

Heidi looked torn — I saw her glance my way, thinking that this was going against our arrangement, that I would be offended if she agreed never to let me watch her again. At the same time, I could see how delighted she was at Don's apparent possessiveness, his desire to tear all control of her away from me.

"I suppose..." Heidi said.

"Good," Don nodded, making the decision for them. Then he was pulling himself up from the bed, saying to her, "I can't sleep here. It's not my space."

"Okay," Heidi said, not really knowing what to say to him.

Don was up on his feet, reaching for his clothes. "You know," he said, "Maybe we need to rethink the whole thing."

"The whole thing?"

"You know. You being poly. I mean, it was a little different to begin with. When I probably would have agreed anything just to go out with you. But now..."

Heidi looked frightened all of a sudden. I suspected she was reluctant to make the kind of decision Don was leading her to make. She didn't want to take decisions, she wanted to be led. I could see that well enough. It was her big fantasy — different from mine, but completely in sync with Don's.

Don sighed. "I just think we're good together, Heidi. I've met anyone like you before. You the most perfect girl I ever laid eyes on. Except for one thing — you have to see him as well."

He turned away, sat on the bed with his back to me so that he could put on his shoes, and now Heidi could look over to me without worrying that he would see her, or that he would discover me lurking behind the curtain.

I parted the curtains a little so she could see me easily, and gave her the thumbs up, nodding, telling her silently that it was okay to go with what Don wanted.

She told Don, "I'll talk to him."

"You do that." He stood up and I shrank back into my shady hideaway as he leaned over the bed to kiss Heidi goodbye.

"I'll see you tomorrow?"

"Absolutely."

*

With Don gone, I stepped out from behind the curtains to find Heidi tearing up as she climbed off the bed and stepped up to me.

"I could tell him 'no'," she said, her voice wavering a little. "I could tell him it's just the way I am."

"No, Heidi." I took her in my arms.

"I could tell him either he accepts this, me seeing you as well or... or I don't see him again."

I held her tight, breathing in the shampoo-and-sex scent in her hair. "You can't do that. He means more to you than that."

God, I felt strange inside. I wanted Heidi, I was still seriously turned on from seeing her fucking Don, and yet the recognition that she belonged to someone else now, that her lover was far more right for her than I could ever be was shredding me up inside.

I kissed her, tasting him on her lips, breathing in his scent, their scent, my hands slipping down her back, feeling the dampness of perspiration on her skin, enjoying the curve of her lower back, the roundness of her behind.

"You mean more to me than that..." Heidi said, breathlessly.

"No, Heidi," I shook my head. "He's yours now. He's just what you need, just what you always wanted."

Her hands found my hardness, stroking me through my pants.

"But you... you opened my eyes..." she protested.

I smiled. "I opened your eyes to what you want — and what you want is Don."

She paused, not knowing what to say, and I knew I was right.

I said, "It's okay, Heidi. I always said this would happen, didn't I? And here we are. He's Mr Right."

She sniffed back a few tears. I kissed her mouth, delicately on top of her lips. "It's okay. You can let me go, now. You know deep down this is the right call. You love him. You really do."

She looked at me, then nodded.

I felt my heart being skewered. Some part of me, a large part perhaps, did love her. But it wasn't the same as what she had with Don. It wasn't an all encompassing love. It was more like friends — with benefits.

"You're okay about it?" she asked me.

I shrugged. "You'll be a huge loss," I said. "But I know what's best for you, Heidi — and it isn't me. You'll regret it if you don't do this. You'll regret it, and maybe you'll come to resent me."

"I could never do that."

"Trust me."

She nodded, and kissed me again on the lips, her tongue easing gently into my mouth. Passionate, but cautious, as though she knew this was it, but just wanted one little taste.

"You want me to leave?" she asked me.

I shook my head. "Of course not. You can stay as long as you want. Stay the night, please."

"We'll be friends, right?" she said. "This time?"

I smiled, laughed. "I promise. Friends, always. And if, you know, it doesn't work out with Don... well, maybe we can be friends with benefits."

"Friends with benefits," she grinned, stroking my hard cock once again. "I like that idea."

I felt a flicker of lust surge through my body, finishing up in my throbbing loins. "You know, until you actually tell Don that you've stopped seeing me..."

Heidi laughed. "I can still see you?"

"Something like that."

She unzipped my fly, reached in to spring my cock free. But I pushed her back onto the bed, knelt on the floor, pulled her hips to the edge of the mattress. I figured I had one more night to enjoy her. I was going to take my fill.

She yelped as I wedged my face between her thighs, and ran my tongue over her soaking wet pussy. Then she leaned back and groaned, enjoying my attention, enjoying being adored. I was going to miss her. Despite the way we had started out, now we were finishing the sex was phenomenal.

This final time with Heidi, though, I felt like the boyfriend, not the husband in a cuckolding relationship. I felt like a thief taking what was not mine. There was some illicit pleasure in knowing that she wasn't really mine any more, too. I could see why guys might want to commit adultery with cheating wives, why it might be a little thrill for them beyond simply the wife being another lay.

Heidi lay back and I ate her with abandon.

"Oh God... oh God... oh my God..."

Let me give her one last memory of what I could do, I figured. I didn't let her get away with one simple orgasm, either. I held her down until she was bucking and shuddering all over the place before I climbed onto her to slide my hardness inside her.

It was hot, and it extended so far into the night the sun was coming up by the time we collapsed, exhausted. But try as I did to make the whole thing seem like a great celebration of Heidi finding her Mr Right, there was a hint of sadness in the air.

It persisted in the morning after she'd left, too. I figured that I probably deserved to feel that way, considering how I'd left her after our marriage imploded.

I felt the urge to text Bella to let her know it was all over. But what connection did I have now that Heidi and Don were an item, and I was no longer going to enjoy the strange arrangement I'd had with Heidi? So I didn't text her.

I went to sleep, and resigned myself to the fact that I might have enjoyed something with the pretty blonde, but really I had nothing much in common with her now, if ever. I wondered if I'd offended her that night we'd watched Don and Heidi together — by leaving her to go with Heidi. I'd stopped her touching me, too. After that, our relationship had continued only as cool, dispassionate texts.

But more than that, Bella was so different to me, it could be nothing like Heidi's relationship with Don. She was so much younger than me, her background was different from mine, she had a whole life to lead once she graduated and I was already stuck in some tedious City job. I'd never met her friends, I had nothing in common with any of them anyway. I didn't really have much to talk to her about other than our strange little game involving Heidi and Don.

And the bottom line was, Bella was so completely out of my league.

Chapter Nineteen

The 'save the date' invitation for Don and Heidi's wedding came six months down the line — disturbingly quickly, I thought. Though it seemed to confirm my thinking that the two were perfect for each other.

My life settled into a fairly emotionless plateau, locked in some kind of purgatory. I read stories about husbands who shared their wives, but I figured that such a reality was denied to me — I didn't have a wife, for a start.

I tried a little online dating, but that didn't really go anywhere. I was looking for something that wasn't there.

Along came the invitation for Don and Heidi's wedding, and on accepting, I let Heidi know there wouldn't be a "plus one" for me. That made me feel pretty sad. Nevertheless, I felt good about the wedding. I was certain it would give me closure. I could end that particular chapter in my life and move on. Heidi had found her soulmate, and it wasn't me. She'd asked me for help and I'd given her such good advice that she was now having her happy ever after.

As the wedding loomed, I even started applying for some other jobs — figuring a change of scene was going to help me out of my little rut more than anything. That feeling that I was doing something, even a small step, to improve my life, meant that I arrived at the wedding without the negativity I could have brought. Things had to improve from here, and I was going to make them improve.

The wedding was held at a lavish manor house specially converted into a wedding venue, some two hours' drive from London in the leafy

Hertfordshire countryside. Really lovely place.

I arrived and checked in at reception some two hours before the ceremony itself, and upon hearing my name and checking their records, the woman behind the counter told me my plus one had already checked in.

"My plus one?"

She smiled. "Of course, sir. She arrived a short while ago."

I felt silently frustrated that there had been some error, and that I'd probably end up without a room — but at the same time I didn't want to make a fuss if arrangements had been messed up by Heidi or Don. It was their day. I'd find somewhere to crash if I had to at the end of the night, or I'd call a taxi and try for a room in a local hotel.

Hauling my suitcase up to my room, I even found myself wondering who my plus one would turn out to be — she couldn't have been too far from my age or else the woman on reception would have known there'd been a mistake. Maybe it would be a "he", and the woman on reception thought I was gay.

I slipped the key card into the lock and opened the door. And there, standing in front of a full-length mirror wearing nothing but a pair of white lace panties and a matching bra, was Bella.

"Close the door, honey," she said. "You'll let all the heat out."

I laughed. "You're my plus one?"

She shrugged. "Heidi said there was a slight shortage on rooms, so I volunteered to share with you."

"Okay."

She turned to face me, not at all shy to show herself off in front of me, even though her panties were semi-sheer. "It's okay, isn't it?"

"Uh... sure," I said.

So I changed into my suit as she put on a pair of white sheer pantyhose and then her stunning Royal blue bridesmaid's dress. It seemed to me more than ever that we'd moved past any possible romantic entanglement to the friend zone, or even the post-friend zone. We chatted, caught up with each other on each other's lives, and as we went down to the chapel for the wedding ceremony itself, it was nice spending a little time with her again, even if it was as friends.

If anything, though, it confirmed to me that we were living in different spheres now. She lived in her own world, completely separate from mine. The age difference, the social difference: her friends weren't anything like my friends, she didn't do the same kinds of things I did. I'd lost plenty of good friends over the years who had more in common with

me than her, because time had intervened and we'd gradually lost touch. It was inevitable that our friendship was going to fizzle out.

And after the ceremony, as Don paraded his new wife, who had once been mine, Bella took to the dancing and the festivities with the care-free abandon of the single-at-heart, chatting and flirting and dancing with whomever she pleased.

I found myself hovering at the edge of the dance floor, watching her throwing herself around, dancing in this instance with the Best Man, though loving the fact that most other male eyes in the room were on her, too.

She did look incredible in her dress. But while she was my plus one for the night, and technically booked into the same double room as me, I wasn't under the impression that I'd really cross paths with her again. She'd find some willing lay, and end up in his room no doubt.

"Jesus, Dude, would you look at her?"

I turned to find a second cousin of Heidi's, looking precisely the same way I had been all night.

"I mean, who is she?"

"Friend of Heidi's, I think," I said.

"Is she a model or something? Jesus, what's someone in our family doing knowing someone who looks like that?"

And I had several other similar conversations with guys in both the bride and groom's families regarding the young blonde tearing up the dance floor, her ample cleavage pushed up to tease anyone with a pulse, her dress flaring up as she moved, to flash a tantalizing amount of leg clad in bridal white nylon.

It didn't take me long to regret that I'd failed to respond to any interest she'd shown my way during our little Heidi-Don project.

But as the dance floor thinned, and the wedding venue gradually emptied with midnight passing, and I was watching Bella locked in a slow dance with a tall black guy, looking as though she'd made her choice for the night, I also found myself becoming aroused at the thought that she might sneak off to the guy's room, and that he'd fuck her to oblivion.

I found myself wanting to get up in the morning to see her arrive at breakfast, perhaps showing the subtle signs of having incredible sex the previous night. Her cheeks flushed, her step full of bounce, her eyes bright and her smile radiant.

I'd been quietly turned on all night by Bella flirting with all the guys at the wedding, but now I was hiding a ranging hard-on as she locked

eyes on this guy, as she pressed her body against his, as she touched her cheek to his.

Now I was nervous, too. It wasn't that I'd feel jealous — or envious — as she went away to sleep with him. It was the feeling that I wouldn't get to see her afterward. I wouldn't get to share the details of her tryst with her, as I had shared details of trysts with Heidi.

I got the strong feeling that after tonight, with Heidi and Don going off into the sunset together, I'd never even see Bella again. That was the pain I felt.

I just had to try to focus on the arousal instead, as Bella seemed to accept her dance partner's offer to escort her off the dance floor, out to the stairway, and up to the rooms that lay waiting for the wedding guests.

I felt stunned, crushed, hollow somehow, as I stood there at the foot of the large formal stairs, and she had gone. Bella was my kindred spirit, not Heidi. I suddenly felt that so strongly and yet now I had lost her.

But what could I do?

I sighed, took a deep breath, and went to find the bride and groom, to offer my sincere congratulations and best wishes before I slunk away to bed.

There was Heidi, clinging on to Don still on the dance floor, a little worse the wear for Champagne, but so obviously elated by everything. Jubilant that she had found her Mr Right. Waiting for him, no doubt, to give the order to head upstairs and fuck him right royally.

"You know, I would," she said looking up at me earnestly. "Even now."

"You would?"

"If you told me to. Even on my wedding day."

I chuckled. Couldn't believe she remembered that little conversation of ours. Or that she would really submit to me one last time if I demanded it, now that she had Don.

"Don't worry," I said. "I'm not going to tell you to. You're much better off with Don. And I'm probably as happy that you're this happy, as I would be lying on a bed with you."

I'm not sure I completely made sense, but the alcohol content in both our systems smoothed over the flaws in my message.

"Good luck," I said, kissing her cheek softly. "You'll be all right from now on. He's going to take care of you like I never could."

She nodded, smiled, a tear in her eye. "Thank you, Joe. For everything." Then gave me the biggest bear hug ever. "I never would

have met him without your help. Not the real him, anyway."

I nodded. De nada. Shook Don's hand, wished him all the best. I'd made up for the mess I'd left Heidi in after our marriage was annulled. I could cling on to that. But now, I quietly exited, stage left, floating up the stairs and round the various labyrinthine hallways until I reached my room, and the single malt that was waiting for me in the mini-bar.

I slumped in the armchair and dwelled on the bittersweet feelings flowing through me. The most positive conclusion I could come to before I slipped off to sleep was that while Heidi had found herself, and discovered her true desires, I had also come to find myself and my desires. Heidi had found her Mr Right, and I was fairly sure the type of woman I was now looking for.

Well, it was something to cling on to.

Heidi probably wasn't going to sleep with anyone else other than Don. But his taste for dominating her in the bedroom would keep her happy and fulfilled. Thinking of her as the submissive, monogamous housewife, obedient and faithful only to Don somehow took the luster off her attraction for me.

I was looking for someone much more wild and free.

*

"You don't care, do you?"

"But he's here, he's actually in here?"

I woke to the sound of voices in the darkness.

"Oh, he's here. But he's been wanting this for ages."

It was Bella.

"Here, make yourself comfortable."

"Jesus, that's your husband?"

"Don't worry about it. He's okay."

The bedside lamp came on, and at first the light made me flinch. Now I saw a big black guy lie back on my bed, flashing an awkward smile my way, not quite certain whether Bella had been telling the truth, whether in fact I might want to call the authorities, or resort to violence despite the fact that he was by any judgement quite a lot larger than me.

Bella climbed onto him after dispensing with her dress, turning to me with a big smile on her pretty face.

"Aren't you excited, honey?" she said. "This is actually happening?"

I tried to shake the sleep from my head, tried to figure out just what the hell was going on here. Bella looked stunning in her white lacy bra and white sheer pantyhose. She didn't appear to be wearing anything else at all. Her hair was tied up in a bun as though she were a ballerina.

She straddled the black guy on the bed, though facing me, rubbing herself gently over his chest as the big man put his hands all over her nylon-covered behind.

"You ever thought we'd actually go through with this?" she said as she lay flat against him, rubbing her stomach over what I could imagine was his rapidly-hardening cock. "Your naughty wife with another man?"

She sat up on him, giving me a better view between her legs as she stroked his cock with her pussy, gyrating her hips to grind on him. Through her sheer pantyhose, I could see the hint of a patch of golden hair between her legs, on her mound.

"You like that?" the stranger said, focused on her, avoiding looking my way.

"Oh yeah," she said, but she was looking at me, as though her real pleasure came from teasing me, rather than stroking her body against the man beneath her.

She told me, "I can feel him growing. He's so big, honey."

She was supposed to be my naughty wife, but now she sat a little back and stretched her white hose over her pussy, and it was the first time I'd seen it. She stroked it through the nylon as she continued to press her behind against her black lover's cock, and I already wanted to push my face between her thighs and feast upon her.

Other than a tidy line of blonde hair, her pussy was smooth, pink, hairless. It wouldn't have surprised me if she'd had it waxed, just because that was what Heidi had done. But other than that, she wasn't trying to be Heidi. She was playing at being my wife — my naughty wife. And she certainly had my attention.

Watching her, I could actually picture her as my promiscuous wife. It wasn't outside the realms of possibility. She reached behind to release herself from her bra, and now one of her breasts was exposed, her nipple rosy red and stiff as a pencil.

She turned, straddling him again and continuing to stroke herself over him, but facing him this time, and though this was a strange kind of role-play, I actually felt that slight burn of jealousy. She was mine, but now she was focusing on him.

Her lover ran his hands up from her hips to her waist to her breasts, telling her, "You are so gorgeous."

She giggled. "And you are, too... oh yeah... squeeze them..."

He was fondling her breasts, making her quietly moan, and then she dropped down, still rubbing herself over him, but now I could hear the wet sounds of her kissing his mouth. I could also see her pussy as she straddled him. I was sure she was consciously showing me, taunting me with it, displaying her reddened, swollen lips, teasing me. Even in the low light from the bedside table I could tell she was wet.

I watched his dark hands sprawling all over her back, her ass, then reach between her legs, touching her sex. She sighed as he touched her there, moaned quietly. Then she removed her bra completely, turned and threw it over to me, giggling at her mischief.

I held it up to my face, breathed in the warm, exotic scent of her body, her perfume. It only made me want her more.

Now she was sliding down his body, lying over his legs, her hands gliding all over the sizable tent in his pants.

"Will you let me play with it, honey?" she turned to look at me, then she was stroking his bulge through his pants with her lips.

"Of course," I said, sitting up, feeling myself getting into the role of the willingly cuckolded husband.

"Oh... it feels so good..." she said, beaming at me, almost purring. She was so beautiful when she smiled. Doubly so, perhaps, because she made it feel like it was me making her so happy. "...He's so thick, I can feel it.... I want it so badly..."

She sat up on him, unzipping his fly, pulling open his pants, to reveal the slumbering giant within, gasping at the sight of it.

"Oh honey..."

Her lover said, "You see how hard you get me?"

And she just kept on peeling his pants away, exposing the full enormity of his big, black cock, his bulging balls. Licking him there, sucking on his heavy balls, flicking the tip of her tongue around the base of his cock. The thing was bigger even than Don's, bulging with blood vessels.

Bella picked it up and slipped the head in between her lips, forcing an impressive amount of his length inside her mouth. But she was looking at me as she withdrew it to explore with her tongue, as she stroked his shaft with her fingers. Treating him as a toy with which to tease me, to turn me on. I liked that.

She moaned quietly as she sank down on him, as she bobbed her head on him, as she forced him into her throat. She moaned as she stroked his cock all over her face, her cheeks, her neck. But the way she smiled, the way she performed, it seemed to be more about performing for me, not for him.

"Oh God, honey, it's so nice..." she said, looking at me. "I love it..."

She pulled off his pants completely, climbing off the bed to do so, removing his socks, too, before returning to him, returning to suck on his balls and take his cock back inside her mouth.

She was much younger than me, much younger than Heidi. Still a student. But I could picture her as a naughty wife. As my naughty wife.

"You like watching me, honey?" I wanted her so badly. Her face flushed with the effort of serving this man's huge cock, perspiration beginning to shine her skin.

"Look how big he is," she marveled, but talking to me, treating him as some object for her use, though he hardly seemed to take offense to her objectification.

She rubbed his cock between her breasts, against her nipples, whispering to me, "God, your wife is such a slut, honey..."

Then she was sitting over him again, rubbing her pussy over his hard cock, letting him feel up her breasts, getting ready to take him inside her. I could feel the pressure building inside me, just as it had with

Heidi. I wasn't just watching a beautiful woman fuck a stranger, I was watching my Bella, my wife, fuck a stranger.

He said to her, "You gonna give me that pussy of yours?"

She sat back on him, stroking her pussy through her sheer hose, showing it to him. She said, "You'll have to break through this."

"Okay. Turn around."

She did as he asked, turning to straddle him facing me, bending down, pushing her butt up and toward him. She groaned as he put his hands to her, the tearing sound clearly signifying that her pantyhose were no longer a barrier to his fucking her.

Bella moaned as he pushed up his cock, pressing it against her bare pussy. She shifted back, letting him stroke it against her slippery folds, then finally slowly enter her.

"Oh... oh my God..." she moaned quietly as he eased into her very gradually. She looked at me in wonderment as he filled her, as though she had never thought she'd get him in there, but that now he was inside her it felt like the most exquisite experience of her life.

She rubbed her breasts as she rode him, facing me, her hips gyrating, her body undulating as she rose and fell on that enormous thing. The way she looked at me, it was like she was fucking me, though it was his cock.

"Oh honey... oh yes..." she moaned, her cheeks and upper chest flushed, her skin glowing with a faint sheen of perspiration.

As she fucked him, she pulled on her torn pantyhose, tearing the hole bigger, showing me everything as her sensational pink pussy took in that huge dark cock, which now glistened with her juices.

He rolled her over onto her back, climbing on top of her to slide his massive cock back inside her, his huge frame overwhelming her, swamping her, covering her almost completely.

"Oh yeah..." she sighed, "Oh God, yeah..."

As his thrusts turned increasingly hard, Bella's moans became cries, raising in pitch and volume, to the point where she was yelping, whimpering.

He was fucking her brains out, right in front of me, turning her into a quivering, shuddering, sweaty mess as she came again and again.

"Oh fuck... oh my God... fuck... oh Jesus..."

He turned her onto her hands and knees, stood on the floor to fuck her from behind, and she was yelling at me, "God he's so big, honey... he's so big..."

And as his pace intensified, she was yelling out to him, "Come in me... come in me... come in me..."

And like that, right in front of me, the big guy was grunting and coming inside her, his seed pumping into her pussy, leaking out of it even before he finally tired, and withdrew.

Bella was left moaning and sighing and laughing, rolling over to gauge how I'd taken her debauchery, asking me, "You like it when your wife has fun, honey?"

I smiled.

"Because I love it," she grinned, laughing, showing me her well-used pussy. "Big, thick cocks...Mmm...but I want more now..."

"More?" I smiled, standing up, stepping over to the edge of the bed, my every breath filled with the scent of their sex, the evidence of her wickedness.

"I need you, honey," she said, giving me the kind of seductive look that made it impossible to say no.

Her lover stepped back, grabbing his clothes. He'd find his own way out, he wasn't upset that Bella was now focusing solely on me, that he was old news. She was gorgeous, and he'd fucked her. That was all he cared about. Now he was done, and on his way.

Just the two of us, now. I mopped up her pussy with a hand towel from the bathroom, but I didn't want her to take a shower. I wanted to explore her body and the lingering traces of their sex, inhaling the musty aroma of their copulation, tasting the saltiness of perspiration from her skin.

"That was really something," I said.

She smiled sweetly. "I've been thinking about it ever since we watched Heidi and Don."

"You have?"

"Couldn't get it out of my mind. Fucking someone for you, fucking someone in front of you."

I nodded, moving down to lie over her, to kiss her heaving breast. "I saw you leaving the party with him," I said. "I thought you were gone — that you'd go to his room and maybe I'd never see you again."

She laughed. "We just went for a stroll," she said. "You know, the full moon was out, and it's so beautiful out there on the terrace, you can see all the stars."

"I didn't think you were interested in me any more," I said.

"Are you kidding? I've been trying for you ever since I met you," she said. "Tonight was my big play."

"It was?"

She laughed at my complete failure to read the signs. "Come on, I was dancing with so many guys in front of you. I spent all night teasing you. I was hoping maybe you'd follow us as we went upstairs to the terrace. Maybe I would have pulled out his big cock right there and then, and put on a show for you."

"But I didn't."

"No, you didn't. And you didn't come find me. I had to come find you."

"Pretending to be my wife, though," I smiled. "Where did that come from?"

She giggled. "You didn't like it?"

I shrugged. "Oh, I liked it. Perhaps a little too much."

I took one of her nipples in her mouth, sucked on it gently, breathing her in, mulling over the intoxicating strangeness of a beautiful woman straight after sex with another man.

"Too much?" she asked.

"Well, you know I don't have a great record when it comes to marriage."

Now I kissed my way down her stomach, detecting the other man's cologne, the other man's body, even though the spicy scent of Bella's arousal now strengthened considerably.

"But you know you can't prove anything based on a single result," she said.

"That right?" I kissed my way to her mound, to the little strip of blonde hair guiding the way to her stunning, glistening sex.

"Oh yeah..." she moaned. "I should know... I'm studying for a biochemistry degree. It's a key tenet of science..."

She moaned as my mouth arrived at her exquisite pussy, as I kissed around her reddened lips, taking in the sight, jarred by the memory of it taking such a large cock barely minutes before. I loved making her writhe as I lay between her thighs and ate her. She was truly a goddess. My goddess, I realized.

I said, "Maybe we need to practice a little more. You know, before we actually talk about improving my record."

If I was honest, I did feel a little disturbed how much I wanted this girl to be my wife. My hotwife. And really, we'd known each other for such a short time. I had a bad experience with woman I married after only a relatively short time dating her. But once again, that theory was based on only a single occurrence.

Bella smiled, said, "I'm happy to practice as long as you like."

She moaned as I made her come with my mouth. She moaned and she sighed and she sang like a songbird. And as I hauled myself up her gorgeous body, and slid my hard cock into her sweet pussy, feeling the lubrication of another man's come around it, I figured that actually, Bella was a better fit for me than Heidi.

There was no thought of me having to dominate her, to pretend to be someone I wasn't in order to fulfill her overarching fantasy. Bella wanted to be my naughty wife. She shared my fantasy.

I held her tight and came powerfully within her, and figured I'd been right about Heidi all along, she hadn't been the one for me. So why couldn't I be right about Bella?

#

Author's Note

This book started off as a short story exploring a girlfriend-sharing arrangement, rather than a wife-sharing situation. As it developed, however, the characters propelled the story along so that it became a novella, and not long afterwards a full-length novel (at least as far as this genre goes).

It also saw Heidi becoming Joe's ex, rather than his girlfriend, and a kind of ex-wife at that if you can say that about an annulled marriage.

I was trying to mix things up in the wife-sharing sub-genre, I suppose, but as often happens with these things, the characters ran away with the plot and it became something I didn't entirely expect. I do still intend to write a girlfriend-sharing story, perhaps even soon, because I think that is a dynamic different from the commitment involved in marriage.

I don't think the ending of Heidi, Corrupted, was quite the normal kind of thing for this sub-genre either, but it felt right for these particular characters. It also seems to me that it's nice to shake up the expectations of the sub-genre from time to time, because then the reader feels a similar kind of tension as the narrator (husband), that perhaps the risks to the central relationship are real, and things might not pan out as the couple originally hopes.

Anyway, I do hope you've enjoyed reading this story. If you have a spare moment, why not share your thoughts in a review wherever you purchased this book. It might seem like vanity on my part, but reviews help indie authors like myself reach more readers, and as a result I can justify spending more time in writing these stories rather than attending to other paid writing assignments. More reviews mean more stories from me, basically.

And I wouldn't have been able to write half the stories I've written without the support readers like yourself have given me by purchasing or borrowing my books, so whether you're a review or not, sincere thanks to you, dear reader — you can personally take credit for this particular tale seeing the light of day.

I'd also like to drop a quick line of thanks to the other fine authors at Hotwifebooks.com, who are a constant source of inspiration and support, including Kenny Wright who shared his thoughts on the story and provided a wonderful cover design. And, I'd like to thank my team of

beta readers — Anjali, Chris, Dan, Ian, Jay, Nick and Robert — who have worked quickly and diligently to iron out the typos and glitches in the story.

Until next time,

Max Sebastian

London, March 30, 2016

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目录

Chapter One	6
Chapter Two	14
Chapter Three	24
Chapter Four	42
Chapter Five	53
Chapter Six	61
Chapter Seven	77
Chapter Eight	92
Chapter Nine	98
Chapter Ten	111
Chapter Eleven	120
Chapter Twelve	128
Chapter Thirteen	133
Chapter Fourteen	147
Chapter Fifteen	160
Chapter Sixteen	172
Chapter Seventeen	184
Chapter Eighteen	190
Chapter Nineteen	195